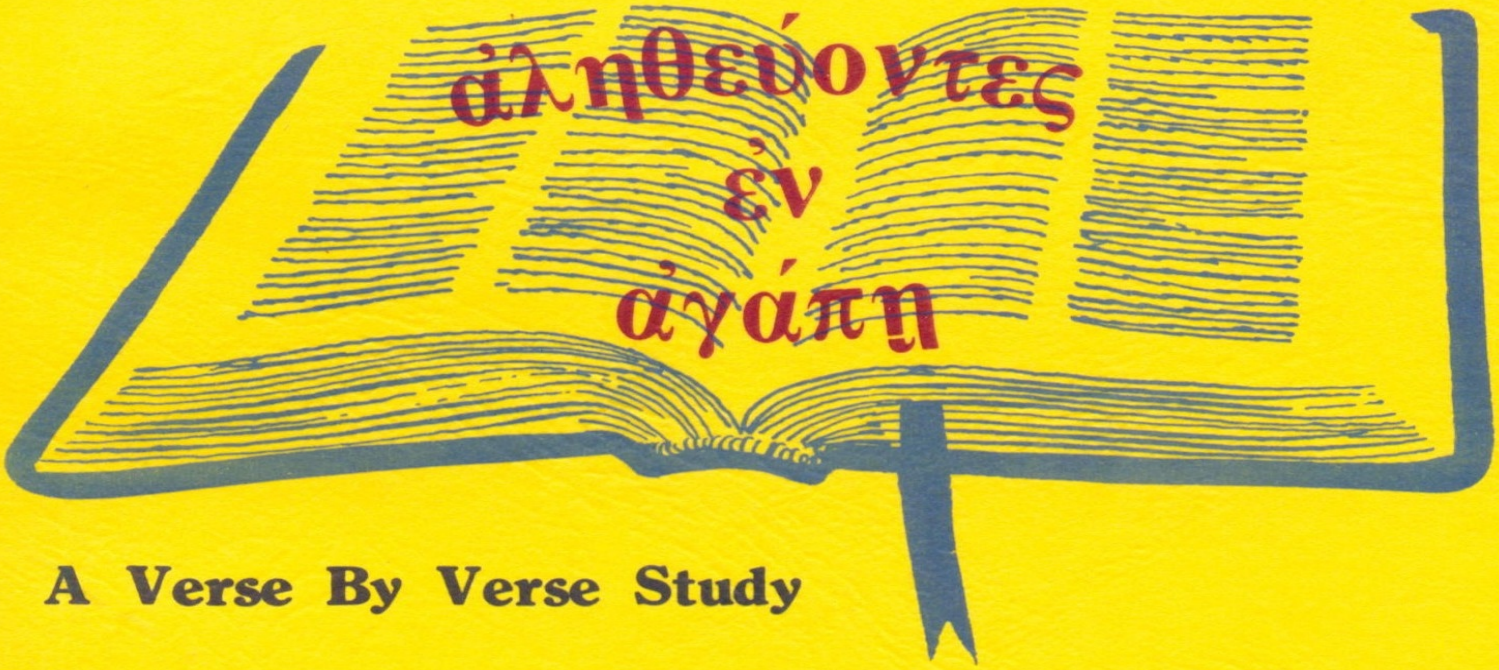
A Commentary Of

COLOSSIANS & PHILEMON

Based On The Greek New Testament



A Verse By Verse Study

By Ernest R. Campbell

COLOSSIANS
&
PHILEMON

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Unlocking Truth from the Greek New Testament

COLOSSIANS & PHILEMON

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Ernest R. Campbell was born at Michigan, North Dakota, in 1915. His farm environment instilled in him the importance of hard work, gave a breadth of experience, and encourage independent thinking and initiative. He moved to Oregon in 1933. For four years he worked in the electrical and radio broadcasting fields.

He received his B. A. degree from the University of Oregon. His major was in English literature, which has strengthened his ability in Biblical interpretation. His B. A. also included a major (hours beyond B. A.) in psychology and two years of classical Greek. He earned his B. D. and Th. D. degrees from Northern Baptist Theological Seminary. His major Greek New Testament was under the renowned Greek scholar, Dr. Julius R. Mantey.

He has taught New Testament Greek at North Park College. He was Dean of the faculty at the Detroit Bible Institute where he taught beginner through advanced New Testament Greek. He has been the pastor of the Salem Bible Church for thirty years during which time his ministry has been based entirely on the Greek New Testament. Simultaneous with this he had taught private Greek classes prior to the beginning of Canyonview Bible College & Seminary.

The author was one of the founders of an evening school in 1973, which became the forerunner of Canyonview Bible College & Seminary. At this time he introduced a new natural method of teaching New Testament Greek, which is now enabling Canyonview students to teach directly from their Greek New Testaments.

As the president of Canyonview Bible College & Seminary the author's supreme burden is to equip students to literally teach the books of the Bible in a verse by verse manner. He is convinced that the ability to teach from the Greek New Testament is the most important single factor in accomplishing this end in an interesting and authoritative manner.

The author realistically recognizes that it is not possible for all Bible teachers to acquire competency in New Testament Greek. This is why he has written this commentary, the Second in a series on Paul's epistles, that the English reader may more fully share in the treasures of the Greek text!

PREFACE

In this preface we want to clearly set forth our *purpose* in writing this book. Some religious books are written to promote certain idiosyncratic interpretations of the Bible. Many religious books are written to dogmatically foist weird, bizarre, and unfounded prophetic views on Christendom. Other books are written by well-meaning individuals who are convinced that they have a panacea for all spiritual illness. In the final analysis, all of the books have one thing in common, they *lack sound biblical content,* and are counterproductive to the extent that they steal reading time from the Bible!

As we have written this book our mind has been focused on *ONE BOOK, THE BOOK* of books, *THE BIBLE!* This BOOK, which contains sixty-six books and epistles written by God the Holy Spirit, is of *Divine origin,* was *Divinely inspired,* and has been *Divinely preserved.* This *BOOK* is *God's complete library* of all necessary Divine information for those who were under the Mosaic Law, for those who are now members of the Church, and for those who will be subjects of Christ during the Kingdom age.

Having affirmed the fact that the Bible is God's library of all essential spiritual truth, why the prolific writing of religious books today? Never before have the shelves of Christian bookstores been so heavily loaded! Never before has the immorality of our nation so brazenly raised its ugly head in defiance of the Bible! What is wrong?

Can it be that the prolific production of humanistically oriented religious books has *stolen the show* from the Divinely authored Word of God? Is it possible that many of these books, with titles that appeal to the flesh, have *robbed believers of the time they should have spent with God in His Word?* It is our conviction that everyone who has been "born from above" by the Holy Spirit (John 3:3-5; Gal. 6:15) is *conscious of his need* to spend time with God in His Word (1 John 4:6). Also, we know that Satan hates to see the one who was once his subject studying the Bible, and he readily uses the reading of so-called Christian books (instead of the Bible) *to salve such a person's conscience!*

We are fully aware of the seriousness of doing anything that would deter one from studying the Bible. Furthermore, we do not want to be guilty of giving anyone *an excuse* for not spending time in the Word of God. Therefore, we have determined *not to become involved in* writing and publishing religious books that are subject to *human imbalance* or that *may be used as an excuse* to refrain from bathing in God's own Personal Word!

Our purpose in writing this book is *closely linked* with *THE BOOK, THE BIBLE!* Since the New Testament was written in the common Greek of the first century, there is a language barrier that needs to be overcome through *translating, interpreting, and explaining.* Our purpose is to take our readers back to the grammatical and historical cradle in which the New Testament was communicated to men. First, in doing this, we give *a literal, accurate, and conservative translation* of the Greek into English. Second, we endeavor to *precisely and exactly interpret* each part in the light of the whole context. Third, we *clearly and lucidly explain* what the Greek is saying in the historical setting.

This book is not an end in itself, but its object is to accurately convey to English readers *what God the Holy Spirit is saying in THE BOOK of books.* It cannot displace the Word of God for it is constantly setting forth and explaining the message of the Word of God. The Bible occupies the *primary place,* and this book has *a secondary role in relation to it.* In this secondary role it is valuable to the extent that it *throws light on the meaning of the Bible.* In writing it we have endeavored to strengthen the Spiritual impact of the Bible to our generation through the use of sound grammatical-historical exegesis.

First, let us consider the *PRINCIPLE OF ACCURACY.* This book is written that, as far as possible, we might have an *accurate knowledge of what the Bible is saying.* This entails getting back to the *basic meaning* of the Greek words that are used in the New Testament. We believe that every Greek word has *a basic meaning,* i.e., *a single meaning* that is more basic than any other meanings. This meaning *must be adhered to* in every context where it makes sense. Where it does not make sense *deviation from the basic meaning should be kept to a minimum.* One of the great weaknesses of many modern translations is *inadequate adherence to the basic meaning* of Greek words. The older conservative translations do *a*

much better job of adhering to the basic meanings.

Accuracy involves paying close attention to the various *voices, modes, and tenses* of the Greek language. There are three voices in the Greek and each one indicates *a different relation* between the subject and the verb (action). Since distinguishing between these voices often requires more detail, no English translations meticulously follow the thought of the Greek in this area. The *active voice* portrays the subject as *producing the action.* The *middle voice* portrays the subject as *acting upon itself.* The *passive voice* portrays the subject as *being acted upon* by someone or something else.

Accuracy involves understanding the *temporal relation* between aorist and present participles and the main verb of a sentence. Most of the English translations fail to consistently pass on the exact time-relation between participles and the leading verb (cf. Matt. 28:19; Acts 19:2). In our own personal investigation of the New Testament we have found that the *aorist participle always refers to action prior to that of the main verb.* Using Acts 19:2 as an example, Paul asked twelve disciples at Ephesus the question: "If *having believed* did you receive the Holy Spirit?" The aorist participle used here could equally well be translated "after you believed" or "when you believed." *The present participle depicts action that is simultaneous with that of the main verb.* Using Matthew 10:7 as an example, Jesus says, *"While you are going preach saying. . .*" This present participle could also be translated "as you are going" or "during the time you are going."

Accuracy involves ascertaining the *basic meaning of' prepositions* as they are used with the different Greek cases. The *case* with which a preposition is used determines its general meaning. There is perhaps no area in the Greek language that requires as much flexibility in meaning as the prepositions. On the other hand, we believe that every preposition has its *basic meaning,* and as far as possible we *must hold to it,* unless the obvious sense of the context forces us to deviate. For example, the basic meaning of the preposition *"επι"* is *upon* (cf. Matt. 16:18), and in translating we must always keep this meaning in mind, but at the same time be ready to deviate from it according to the *sense of the contexts* in which it is used. Unless one knows New Testament Greek well enough to readily navigate in the entire context it is impossible to be a reliable translator!

Accuracy involves knowing New Testament Greek well enough to be able to detect *idiomatic expressions.* Failure to perceive that a phrase is an idiom could cause one to err by *overemphasizing* certain words. Let us go back to the marriage in Cana of Galilee for an example of an idiom. In response to Mary's statement, "They have no wine," Jesus said, *"τι εμοι και σοι,"* which could be literally translated, "What is it to me and to you?" (John 2:4). As we observe this Greek phrase used in other New Testament contexts, in which it cannot be translated literally as above, we conclude that *it is a Greek idiom,* and as such is best translated, "What have I to do with you?" Also the Greek phrase *"επι το αυτο*" appears to be an idiom with the meaning *at the same place* of *for the same purpose* (cf. Matt. 22:34; Acts 2:47; 4:26; 1 Cor. 7:5; 11:20; 14:23).

If the Bible is the inspired Word of God, which we thoroughly believe that it is, then we must do everything possible to accurately translate and interpret it! The first thing that we must posit is the *PRINCIPLE OF ACCURACY.* This means that as we have written this book our first object has been to *accurately open up the truth of the Greek text* to our readers.

Second, let us consider the *PRINCIPLE OF EMPHASIS.* This principle rests upon the premise that the truth which God has revealed through the writers of the Bible *varies in importance.* There are many factors that have contributed toward this variation; time will suffice to mention only a few of them.

The story of the Bible is that of God mercifully and relentlessly reaching out to men to bring them back into fellowship with Himself. In doing this He has always *met men where they are,* i.e., He has *adjusted His message* to the circumstances of men in the process of time. His message to Noah, Abraham, Moses, David, John the Baptist, and Paul was adjusted to the circumstances of each and the times in which they lived. In other words, God's purpose has been gradually revealed *in conjunction with circumstances in the unfolding of history!* Part of God's message may have been *limited* to the immediate circumstances, part of it may have been *fulfilled,* part of it may be universally *foundational,* and part of it may *await fulfillment.* It was all written for our learning (Rom. 15:4), but at the same time it had *a specific purpose,* such as Jesus Christ's earthly ministry *fulfilling Kingdom promises to Israel* (Rom. 15:8) and the Apostle Paul's ministry of *revealing truth for the Body of Christ,* the Church

(Eph. 3:2-11).

If one takes the position that all the Bible is equally for us today he is standing on *a very broad platform.* We have already pointed out that the Bible contains many *specific messages* for given individuals, peoples, and nations. Some of these have been fulfilled, some are being fulfilled, and others are to be fulfilled. If the entire Bible is equally for us today, then we raise the question: *What part* of its message should we consider most important? We are *forced* to come face to face with the fact that there are no *contradictions in the Bible as long as its contents are kept in their intended historical setting,* but if we violate the principle of *to whom and for whom* its parts were written, we are confronted with inescapable contradictions (Acts 21:20-26; Gal. 1:6-9, 11-12; 3:19-25; 5:2-6; Col. 2:13-19)!

The premise that all the Bible is equally for us has been and continues to be the *progenitor* of denominationalism, sectarianism, and even of many of the cults! Most denominations came into existence as a result of *a strong emphasis on certain parts* of the Word of God. It may well be that this emphasis was in accordance with the truth of the Bible; however, if it is *disproportionate and unbalanced* in relation to the total truth for the Church, then it tends to produce schism. God has carefully given a total gamut of truth for the Church, and He has synchronized the gifts of each member "in order that there might be no schism in the body, but that the members might have the same concern for one another" (1 Cor. 12:25).

As we write this book the cry of our heart is for *oneness and unity* between the Lord's people! This was also the burden of our Wonderful Lord as he faced the Cross (John 17:20-23); it was a burden which rested heavily upon Paul's heart (Eph. 4:1-13); and it was a burden that occupied the mind of the Apostle John (1 John 1:3). There is nothing more destructive to the cause of Christ today than *infighting and a sectarian spirit that is dividing* professed Christendom! By our attitudes and actions toward one another we are *denying* the Christian characteristics we espouse.

In spite of what we see around us, *there is an answer, there is a basis for hope,* and it is in rightly handling the Word of God (2 Tim. 2:15). If we will take the Bible *literally,* and keep each book and letter in its intended orbit, we will be on the way toward properly distinguishing between the things that differ (Phil. 1:9-10). As we

intelligently approach the Bible in this manner we will be *forced to recognize the distinct revelation of truth* for the Church, the Body of Christ, *which was given to the Apostle Paul* (1 Cor. 2:6-10; Gal. 1:12). Paul refers to this message for the Church as "my gospel" (Rom. 2:16; 16:25-26; 2 Tim. 2:8), and as the "Gospel of the Grace of God" (Acts 20:24). This means that in this Church age we should be *majoring in the epistles written to the churches,* namely, Paul's and those in alignment with them.

Having established the fact that in this Church age we are to major in the epistles written to the churches or pertaining to them, let us consider the significance of the *principle of emphasis.* Basically, this principle means that we are to be *identified with the writer in emphasis.* As we study Paul's fourteen epistles (Hebrews included), and consider the truth that is presented in each one of them, what is Paul's *overall emphasis?*

First, as we move into these epistles we must follow Paul in accuracy. Second, after we have accurately ascertained what Paul is teaching, we must *follow him in emphasis.* As one inspired by the Holy Spirit what Paul has written is *a perfect balance of truth.* To the extent that you and I follow him in emphasis we will likewise be *balanced in the truth for the Church!* As we all evaluate what we believe by this principle we will be *laying a sound basis* for "maintaining the unity of the Spirit" (Eph. 4:3).

Ernest R. Campbell

INTRODUCTION

In this brief introduction we will be considering the main *purpose* for which this book was written. We will point out some of the most *significant truths* that are taught in this epistle. We will also consider the approximate *date* that it was written.

Paul's purpose in writing *chapter one* is that they might *know* some very important facts. First, he desires them to know that he is constantly praying for them that they might perfectly *know God's will* and live worthily of Him (9-12). Second, he wants them to *know who Jesus Christ really* is - the Creator, Sustainer, and Peacemaker of the universe (15-19). Third, he wants them to *know that they have been reconciled* through Christ's death if they continue grounded and solid in the faith (21-23). Fourth, he wants them to *know that he is suffering* and agonizing in his effort to make known the truth of the mystery, that he might present each of them perfect in Christ (24-29).

Paul's purpose in writing *chapter two* is primarily to *warn them against false teaching* that displaces the centrality of Jesus Christ. In warning them against being *deluded,* he wants them to know about his struggle for all of them in that part of Asia, that their hearts might be joined together in love, and that they might have a perfect knowledge of the mystery, even Christ, who is the embodiment of all wisdom and knowledge (1-5). He *warns them against those who would rob them* of their completeness in Christ through their philosophy and human traditions (6-10). He *warns them against those who were trying to subject them to the Law,* pointing out that the dogmas of the Law were nailed to the cross, and that living together with Christ they have triumphed over all legalism (13-15). He *warns them against all religious law-keeping, the worshipping of angels, and asceticism,* telling them that Christ is the Head of the Body who supplies all they need for growth in God (16-19). He *warns them against being subject to human commandments and teachings,* for such are unable to subdue the lusts of the flesh (20-23).

Paul's purpose in writing *chapter three* is to *instruct* them to exchange their old life for the new life in Christ. First, as those who had died with Christ to earthly things and had been raised with Him, they are to constantly *seek and think upon thing) above (1-4).*

Second, as those who have put off the old man, they are to put off his practices; and as those who have put on the new man, they are to daily *become like Christ (5-11).* Third, as God's elect they are to be *compassionate, kind, humble, gentle, patient, sustaining, forgiving, and loving* toward one another (12-15). Fourth, filled with the Word they are to *mutually teach and admonish one another* in the name of the Lord Jesus, continuously giving thanks (16-17). Fifth, specific instructions are given to wives, husbands, children, slaves, and masters, that each one might *live pleasing to the Lord,* and do all things as unto the Lord (18-4:1).

Paul's purpose in *chapter four* is to give them *final instructions and personal greetings.* First, he asks them *to pray for him that he might boldly speak the mystery of Christ,* that which has caused his imprisonment (2-4). Second, they are *to be wise in their dealings with unbelievers,* appropriately answering each one (5-6). Third, Tychicus and Onesimus will give them further personal details about Paul and encourage their hearts (7-9). Fourth, Paul conveys greetings to them from Aristarchus, Mark, Justus, Luke, Demas, and Epaphras, who was from Colossae and who agonized in prayer that they might stand perfect and fully assured in all the will of God (10-14). Fifth, they are to greet the Laodiceans, give them this epistle to read, and read the letter sent to the Laodiceans (15-16).

Now let us turn our attention to some of the most *significant truths* taught in this epistle. First, *chapter one* emphasizes the importance of three basic ingredients essential for true spirituality, namely, *faith, hope,* and *love (4-5).* Second, the spiritual *wisdom* and *understanding* found in the Word is essential if one would know the will of God (9). Third, believers are to *continuously thank God* for sovereignly making them sufficient to be a part of the Body of Christ (12-13). Fourth, in Christ we have *redemption, forgiveness, reconciliation,* and peace with God (14, 20). Fifth, Christ Himself is the *image* of God, the *Head* of the Church, has *first place,* and embodies the *fulness* of God (15, 18-19). Sixth, reconciled through the death of Christ believers are *blameless* and *faultless* before God (22). Seventh, the Word of God for today is the *mystery,* Ch*ri*st in the believer, the hope of glory (25-27). Eighth, Paul specialized in teaching the *wisdom of the mystery* to every person, that he might present everyone *perfect in Christ* (28-29).

Some of the significant truths set forth in *chapter two* are: first, the

treasures of the *wisdom* and *knowledge* of the mystery are found *in Christ (2-3);* and second, believers have been made *complete in Christ, made alive together with Him,* and have *triumphed in Him.*

The first significant truth we see in *chapter three* is that believers have *died with Christ* and have been spiritually *raised with Christ (1-3).* Second, when Christ appears (comes), believers will *appear with Him* in glory (4). Third, the new man in Christ knows *no racial distinctions;* all these have been *obliterated in Christ* who is everything to him (9-11). Fourth, the *right relation* to fellow-believers is of utmost importance (12-15). Fifth, the believers in a local assembly have the *responsibility of building up one another* in the Lord (16-17). Sixth, regardless of one's physical circumstances he should *do all things as unto the Lord* and not to men (23-24).

The first significant truth that impresses us in *chapter four* is the importance Paul places on *prayer* and *thanksgiving (2).* Five times throughout this epistle he uses the words for praying or prayer and five times the words for thanksgiving. Second, Paul refers to the message he proclaimed as the *mystery of Christ.* It was the message that caused him to be jailed, but regardless of the trouble it caused him, it was *imperative that he boldly speak it (3-4).* Third, believers are to *live wisely and to speak appropriately* before the unsaved (5-6). Fourth, the fact that Paul commends John Mark to them indicates that he *had forgiven him* before this time, i.e., he practiced what he preached (10). Fifth, Epaphras is a good example of our *need to pray for the spiritual stability* of fellow-believers (12-13).

This is one of the four epistles Paul wrote while he was in prison at Rome. There is considerable evidence in favor of *Philippians being the last epistle written during this imprisonment,* i.e., probably near the time Paul was to be released (Phil. 1:25). The likeness between Colossians and Ephesians strongly suggests that they were probably written about the same time. The fact that Onesimus was to accompany Tychicus, the one who was to take this epistle to Colossae, implies that Philemon was also written about the same time (Col. 4:9; Philemon 10, 12). In view of the information we have available and the number of those associated with Paul at the time he wrote this epistle, it may well have been written sometime during the first half of his imprisonment, or *approximately A. D. 60.*

CHAPTER 1

1. ***"Paul an apostle of Christ Jesus through the will of God, and Timothy the brother,"***

Paul clearly states that he himself is the one writing this epistle. He refers to himself as an "apostle" (αποστολος), i.e., one who is literally *sent from (*απο*)* another; hence, one who is *sent forth* with a given message. Paul was not just another apostle, but one who represented a very important person, he was an apostle of Christ Jesus. The genitive case indicates that he was an apostle who was *possessed by* Jesus Christ; he *belonged to* God the Son and was at His disposal to accomplish His work.

As a young man Saul of Tarsus was sure of one thing, that he would never become an apostle of Jesus Christ, but the *will of God* had different plans for his life (cf. Gal. 1:13-16). On the Damascus Road Saul of Tarsus was changed into the Apostle Paul *through the agency of the irresistible will of God (*δια θελημματος θεου).

Paul's emphasis on the fact that he is an apostle through the will of God suggests that some at Colossae were questioning his Divine authority. False teachers and enemies of the cross of Christ (Col. 1:21; Phil. 3:18), in their efforts to undermine Paul's Gospel, commonly attacked his apostolic authority. This was true with the Corinthians (cf. 1 Cor. 1:1; 9:1-2; 2 Cor. 12:11-12) and with the Galatians (cf. Gal. 1:1, 11-12).

In writing to Timothy Paul positively affirms that he was appointed "a preacher and an apostle and a teacher" of the Gospel (2 Tim. 1:11; cf. 1 Tim. 2:7). In exercising his apostleship Paul's ministry was directed toward all men (cf. Rom. 1:14, 16); however, he was particularly the first apostle commissioned to go unto the Gentiles (cf. Acts 9:15; Rom. 11:13; Eph. 3:1-2). Furthermore, observe that Paul's distinct apostolic authority on behalf of the Church was recognized by the Twelve Apostles (cf. Acts 15:6-29; Gal. 2:7-9).

Paul associates Timothy with himself in the writing of this epistle. Also, in writing to the Philippians under the same circumstances Timothy was associated with him (cf. Phil. 1:1). The question we raise is the *nature of Timothy's association* with Paul in Rome.

In the last chapter in the Book of Acts Luke says that Paul remained "two entire years in his own rented living quarters, and he was receiving all those coming to him" (Acts 28:30). The next thing we hear about Paul's physical circumstances is that he had been bound because of his faithful preaching of the "mystery of Christ" (Col. 4:3) or "the mystery of the gospel" (Eph. 6:19-20). Paul further speaks of his bound condition as that which would have normally hindered the spread of the Gospel, such as imprisonment would be expected to, but instead it gave him a new area of outreach (cf. Phil. 1:12-14).

In view of the above facts it appears that while Paul was awaiting trial he lived in his own rented quarters; however, after his trial he was put in a much more confined prison environment. During this time of imprisonment Timothy, together with others (cf. 1:8; Phil. 2:25-30), did have at least limited access to Paul. Thus we see that Timothy, the key person who ministered to Paul from outside the prison, is associated with Paul in the writing of this epistle.

2. ***"to the saints and faithful brethren in Christ at Colossae; grace and peace to you from God our Father."***

Paul addresses this letter to the "saints" *(*αγιοις*),* to the *holy ones,* to *those separated* unto God. Likewise, he addresses it to the "faithful brethren" *(*πιστοις αδελφοις), to the *believing brethren,* i.e. to those who are *trustworthy.* Observe that these saints and faithful brethren *are in Christ.* Left to themselves all men are dead in trespasses and sins (cf. Rom. 3:23; Eph. 2:1). Since men in their very nature are sinners, it is impossible to conceive of men in themselves as being anything else but sinners. There is no such thing as human righteousness; both Gentiles and Jews have condemned themselves as sinners according to the first three chapters in Romans (Rom. 3:9-18).

The only way for a sinner to become a saint, i.e., to be separated unto God, is *in Christ* (cf. 2 Cor. 5:2 1). Furthermore, the only way for a sinner to become faithful and trustworthy before God, and in his relations with his fellowmen, is by being made *a new creature* in Christ (cf. 2 Cor. 5:17). In other words, in the true sense of the word, there is no such thing as a saint or faithful brother apart from Christ!

The particular saints and faithful brethren Paul is addressing here are located at *Colossae.* This city was located above the Lycus River

that flowed through the Lycus Valley. It was ten miles south of Laodicea, and its native population was Phrygian Gentiles. Also, there were apparently a number of Jews in the area, who originally probably heard the Gospel through Epaphras (cf. 1:7). While Paul was at Ephesus for some three years Epaphras apparently visited that city, was converted and instructed under Paul's ministry, and returned to Colossae and taught the Gospel there.

Also, there is some reason to think that Philemon may have had a prominent part in starting the church at Colossae. Paul speaks of him as being *our fellow-worker* (Philemon 1), and the Colossian church was apparently meeting in his house (Philemon 2). Philemon may have also come in contact with the Gospel under Paul at Ephesus, or he may have heard the Gospel from Epaphras as most of the Colossians had (cf. 1:7).

Paul's salutatory expression "grace and peace to you from God our Father" must be considered for what it actually says rather than as a formal nicety. No one appreciated what the grace of God had done in his life more than the Apostle Paul. As one who was formerly a blasphemer and a persecutor, Paul had, received mercy because he did it in a state of unbelief. At such a time, he says, "the grace of our Lord superabounded with faith and love that is in Christ Jesus" (1 Tim. 1:14). Paul looked at his being saved by grace as an example of how God was going to save others during this present age of Grace (cf. 1 Tim. 1:16). Not only are we *totally dependent upon the grace of God for original salvation* (cf. Eph. 2:8), but also for our daily walk and service for Christ, for in First Corinthians 15:10, Paul says that the grace of God *labored with him* in effecting the work of the Lord.

It is most logical that Paul should associate *peace* with grace, for it is the result of God's grace. No sinner would ever find peace if it was not for the grace of God! As God's grace puts the sinner in Christ, the true haven for spiritual peace, there the sinner becomes a saint and he knows what it is to be at *peace with God and men!*

In Romans 5:1, Paul says, "Therefore having been justified out of faith we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ." Furthermore, in the third chapter of this epistle Paul says, "Let the peace of Christ rule in your hearts, unto which you were called in one body. . . (Col. 3:15). Here we see that peace belongs to those who are *members of the Body of Christ,* to those who are in Christ, and it

is to rule or govern the hearts of those who truly belong to Him! We need to clearly keep in mind that the grace and peace Paul is talking about here is *from God,* the gift of God.

3. ***"We give thanks to God the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, praying always for you,"***

The word translated "we give thanks" (ευχαριστουμεν) comes from the two Greek words "ευ" and "χαρις" and literally means to have *good grace, to be grateful;* hence it expresses the idea of *gratitude* and *thankfulness.* In spite of all the trouble Paul went through for the sake of the Gospel - dying daily with Christ but being preserved, being in and out of prisons, etc. - yet he abounded in thanksgiving and told the Thessalonians to be thankful in everything (1 Thess. 5:18).

It is important that we observe that Paul directed his thanks and gratitude to *God the Father.* Paul very consistently directs all thanksgiving and prayer to the Person of God the Father. God the Father was the *one to whom he prayed,* to whom he spoke, and with whom he conversed (cf. Rom. 1:8; 1 Cor. 1:4; Phil. 1:3). On the other hand, keep in mind that according to Paul, all prayer was to be made *in the name of or through the Person of Jesus Christ* (cf. Rom. 1:8; 7:25).

It is important that we meticulously follow what the Scriptures say on important issues such as this! When we have free access to come into the *very presence of God the Father* through the finished work of Christ on Calvary, let us honor God by *using our privilege,* and let us give due credit to Christ for providing direct access to the Father.

Having told them about his thankfulness to God for them, Paul now proceeds to inform them that he is always praying for them. The Greek word translated "always" *(παντοτε)* literally means *all the time.* Paul uses this same adverb in conjunction with both giving thanks and praying in his epistles, emphasizing that he was *always in a mental state of thankfulness and prayer* on behalf of the Churches under his care (cf. I Cor. 1:4; Eph. 5:20; 2 Thess. 1:11). Paul conveys this same thought to the Thessalonians as he tells them to unceasingly (αδιαλειπτως) pray, i.e., to pray *without letting up,* or *without remission* (I Thess. 5:17).

There is only one interpretation that we call give passages such

as this. Paul knew the secret of *continuously communicating* with God the Father under all circumstances and in all situations. He knew nothing of the false concept of "praying through" to God; for he lived moment by moment in a relation with God in which he could freely converse with Him either audibly or silently. No one can read this epistle to the Colossians Without being *convinced* that prayer was *exceedingly important* to the Apostle Paul! There is no doubt about it, he believed that prayer did *make a difference,* it did *change things and people!*

4. ***"having heard of your faith in Christ Jesus, and the love which you have unto all the saints,"***

This verse begins to give us the *reason* why Paul was continuously thanking God for the Colossian saints. The Greek word translated "having heard" *(*ακουσαντες*)* is all aorist participle, and as such indicates that Paul had heard about their spiritual state *prior to* giving thanks for them. The one through whom Paul had heard the good news about them was *Epyphras,* as we see in verse eight. Epaphras had apparently come to Rome recently to share with Paul what was happening at Colossae, Laodicea, and Hierapolis, i.e., in the Lycus Valley churches. What he had told Paul on the one hand was the basis for thanking God for them and on the other hand the basis for concerned prayer for them (cf. 4:12-13).

The first thing Paul thanks God for is their *faith in Christ Jesus.* The key word here is "faith" *(*πιστιν*),* which as used in this context has the idea of *trust, belief* confidence, etc. True faith in Christ involves: (1) belief that *He* is who He claimed to be, or in the case of these Colossians, that He was what Paul through Epaphras had taught that He was. This means that to the extent they had knowledge of Jesus Christ they believed it. And (2) faith in Jesus Christ may be *identification* with Christ, or *appropriation* of Christ, through a personal exercise of faith. This faith is *a gift of God* and the exercise of it is absolutely essential for salvation (cf. Eph. 2:8). To the extent that the Colossians had *faith in the integrity* of the Divine Person of Jesus Christ, and to the extent that their lives were in alignment with the *exercise of Divine faith* in Christ as Saviour, thus showing that their faith was not empty (cf. 1 Cor. 15:2), they did have faith in Christ.

What Epaphras had reported to Paul, and what Paul says here

on the basis of his report, indicates that there were at least a number of true believers at Colossae. In beginning his epistles, Paul always looked for those *positive qualities* in his readers for which he could thank God, and their faith in Christ is the first one he mentions here. There is also another thing that argues in favor of the genuineness of their faith in Christ, and that is the *spiritual and intellectual depth of this epistle,* which strongly suggests that they would have to be relatively mature to understand it.

The second thing Paul thanks God for is their love unto all the saints. The word translated "love" *(αγαπην)* is commonly used in the New Testament to depict *Divine love* (John 3:16; Rom. 5:5), and this use would certainly fit the context here; however, some passages appear to use it in more mundane manners (John 3:19; 2 Tim. 4:10). Extra Biblical Greek definitely uses this word in speaking of love on a human plane. Love between believers is not a humanly generated thing, but it is *produced by the Holy Spirit* in believers, for it is the first listed *fruit of the Spirit* (Gal. 5:22).

It is difficult to define exactly what love is, i.e., what the word "αγαπαω" means, apart from considering its actual usage in the New Testament. Love for a person is *the opposite of hate f*or a person (Rom. 9:13). To love a person is to treat that person *as You would treat yourself* (Rom. 13:9). Love for a person is a willingness to *give your life* for that person, i.e., to train and discipline (Heb. 12:6).

In view of the way the Bible uses this word we can say that true love between believers must be based upon *the standard of presenting everyone perfect in Christ* (Col. 1:28). What we do in relation to one another should be unto the end of *maturing* and *developing* one another to be like Christ (cf. 2 Cor. 4:10). *The mutual* ministry of believers in the early New Testament church afforded believers an ideal opportunity to show their love unto one another through *teaching, encouraging,* and *helping* one another in the things of the Lord!

5. ***"because of the hope that is laid up for you in the heavens, which you previously heard in the word of the truth of the gospel,"***

The third thing that Paul thanks God for is their effective *hope* in that which is reserved for them in the heavens. The word translated "hope" *(ελπιδα)* conveys the idea of *projection beyond the present.* It

involves an *expectation, a looking forward to,* and *a longing for something out in the future.*

Epaphras and others had obviously taught the Colossians some of the basic truths about the coming of Christ for His Church and how they would meet Him in the air and ever be with the Lord (cf. 1 Thess. 4:17). He probably also explained to them some of the truths pertaining to the judgment seat of Christ that Paul writes about to the Corinthians (cf. 1 Cor. 3:14; 4:5). We may not know exactly what their prophetic understanding was, but of one thing we can be certain, their hope in what was yet to take place was *so strong* that it *stimulated* them to have *increased faith* in Christ and *a greater love* unto one another. Their hope effectively produced genuine spirituality!

Now that we have considered how their prophetic *hope* made a real *impact* on their daily living for Christ, let us now turn our attention to *how* they had learned about this hope. Speaking of this hope, Paul says, "which you previously heard in the word of the truth of the gospel." The Greek word translated "previously heard" *(*προη–κουσατε) speaks of that which they heard about in past time, probably a number of years prior to Paul's writing of this epistle.

On the basis of the information we have available, we assume that Epaphras was taught the Gospel by Paul at Ephesus, during his approximate three year ministry there, and then returned again unto Colossae as probably the main teaching elder there. The *time that they previously heard* about the heavenly hope probably corresponds to the time when Epaphras returned to Colossae and began his teaching ministry in his own home town. The information about their future hope in heaven was apparently *a part* of the message they heard taught by Epaphras.

The phrase "the word of the truth of the gospel" can well be interpreted to mean *the message of truth* which belongs to the Gospel, i.e., the message of truth is the *contents of' the Gospel.* What we have here is an apposition relationship - *the message of' truth is the Gospel* and the *Gospel is the message of truth.* The important thing to see here is that the *Gospel is constituted of truth,* and part of this truth had to do with *prophecy,* the fact that one day they will be *manifested with Christ in glory* (Col. 3:4; cf. Phil. 3:20-21).

6. ***"which is come unto you, even as also in all the world it is bearing fruit and increasing even as also among you, from the***

day you heard it and perfectly knew the grace of God in truth:"

The phrase "which is come" (του παροντος) is the article with *a present* participle, and it may be better translated *which is present* in this context. The basic verb behind this participle conveys both the idea of *something coming,* and when it has come, then the idea of its *presence.* The use of the present participle favors the idea that the Gospel having come unto them is *now present* with them, and being present with them it is in a position to bear fruit.

Paul reminds them of how *widespread* the influence of the Gospel really is; it is bearing fruit in *all the world* and increasing. The use of two present participles "bearing fruit" *(*καρποφορουμενον*)* and "increasing" *(*αυξανομενον*)* makes clear that the Gospel was on the move in the world; it was changing lives, and it was transforming immoral derelicts into the image of Christ.

Also, the Gospel was "increasing", it was growing, it was reaching out and penetrating new heathen areas. Even though Paul was in prison for proclaiming the mystery of the Gospel; yet, when he considered the advancement of the Gospel in the world it excited him, and he is here sharing some of this excitement with the Colossian believers (cf. Phil 1:12-14). He wants them to know that they are not alone, but they are part of a great worldwide movement that is replacing immorality with morality and daily making new converts. Paul reminds the Colossians that what is going on in the world is likewise happening in their midst, for in the same manner they are bearing fruit and increasing in numbers. Furthermore, this has been going on in their midst *from the day when they first heard* the Gospel and came to perfectly know the grace of God in truth.

The emphasis here is on the *grace of God,* of which they gained a perfect knowledge *in the sphere of the truth* of the Gospel, or it may be translated *by means of the truth* of the Gospel. There is only one way to understand the grace of God, and that is by *studying* and *listening to* the literal truth of the Gospel. The grace of God is systematically set forth in the New Testament epistles, particularly the epistles of Paul, and those who want to accurately understand it must give themselves to an orderly verse by verse and epistle by epistle study of the New Testament! Those who come to perfectly know the grace of God will also be like the Colossians and other early believers, namely, *bearing fruit* and *reaching out* to others with the

Gospel!

7. ***"even as you learned from Epaphras our beloved fellow slave, who is a faithful minister of Christ on behalf of us,"***

This verse specifically settles the issue as to who originally preached the Gospel unto them. In the fourth chapter Paul refers to Epaphras as *one out of you (ο εξ υμων),* which is commonly understood to mean that he was probably a native of Colossae.

Also, the statement in the nineteenth chapter of Acts, pertaining to the widespread influence of Paul's Ephesian ministry, is very significant in better understanding how the Gospel spread to Colossae through Epaphras. Luke says, speaking of Paul's ministry in the school of Tyrannus, "and this was for two years, so that all those dwelling in Asia heard the word of the Lord, both Jews and Greeks." Since Paul apparently remained in Ephesus and made the school of Tyrannus his teaching headquarters, and since all those in Asia heard the Word, they must have come to Ephesus and studied under him, i.e., men like Epaphras who went back again to their home towns and taught the Word. Under these circumstances all Asia may very well have heard the Word both directly and indirectly from the Apostle Paul.

Paul speaks of Epaphras as being his beloved *fellow slave.* In writing to Philemon Paul refers to Epaphras as being his *fellow prisoner* (Philemon 23). The implication of this statement in Philemon is that Epaphras was incarcerated with Paul in Rome. Granting that this is the case, then the word *fellow slave* is perhaps to be understood more in terms of a fellow bound one or prisoner.

We have no information as to what might have led to the imprisonment of Epaphras. It may have been the direct result of his bold proclamation of the Gospel in Colossae which led to his imprisonment in Rome. His imprisonment may have taken place when he came to Rome to visit Paul, and the Asian Jews there stirred up trouble for him (cf. Acts 21:27). On the other hand, his imprisonment may have been self-imposed so that he could help minister to Paul's needs.

Paul also speaks of him as being a faithful minister of Christ on his behalf. This could be interpreted to refer to one who faithfully ministered to Paul's needs in prison; or it could be interpreted to

mean that he was a faithful minister of the Gospel to the Colossians on behalf of Paul, i.e., as one associated with Paul. Regardless of which interpretation is correct, one thing is obvious, there was a close bond between Paul and Epaphras.

8. ***"who also has declared to us your love in the Spirit."***

In verse four Paul spoke about their love unto all the saints; this was based upon information he had received from Epaphras. Here he speaks about their love from the view point of who *produces* it, i.e., they love *in the sphere of* the Spirit, or they love *by means of* the Spirit. The first and greatest fruit the Holy Spirit produced in and through believers is mutual love one to another. That which *marked* the early church and made it *a powerful testimony* for Christ was the *love of its members for one another!* The Spirit of God is *longing* to produce this same love through you and me today! May we not grieve Him, but allow Him to take over these bodies as His temple (1 Cor. 6:19; Eph. 4:30).

9. ***"Because of this we also, from the day we heard of it, we do not cease praying and asking for you, that you might be filled with the perfect knowledge of his will in all spiritual wisdom and understanding,"***

The Greek phrase "δια τουτο," which may be translated because of this, on account of this, or for this reason, refers back to what Paul has said in the previous paragraph. The phrase "from the day we heard" takes us back to the time when Epaphras had come from Colossae to Rome and shared with Paul the news about the Colossian believers (1:8).

He had told Paul about their strong hope in soon being glorified together with Christ (3:4), and how this *hope* was causing their *faith* in Christ and their *love* unto all the saints to increase (1:4-5). Also, Epaphras had emphasized their yieldedness to the Holy Spirit and how the Spirit was producing in and through them His love, the supreme fruit of the Spirit (Gal. 5:22). From the day Paul had received this report from Epaphras, which contained encouraging information as we have already seen and depressing news about the aggressive activity of false teachers (1:23; 2:4, 8), he makes them a very important part of his daily prayer life.

In view of the very serious doctrinal error that was being forced

upon the Colossian believers, apparently from the outside, Paul says "we do not cease" (ου παυομεθα), *let up,* or *stop* praying for you. Likewise, the word praying is a present participle, and as such, emphasizes the fact that Paul was *continuously* praying for them.

Furthermore, the Greek word translated "asking" *(αιτουμενοι),* which conveys the idea of *requesting* even to the point of *begging* (cf. Acts 3:2), also is a present participle and indicates that as a part of Paul's praying for them he was *continuously asking* and petitioning God to do something specific for them. This word is consistently used in the New Testament to denote praying for *specific requests* (cf. 1 Cor. 1:22; Eph. 3:13; 1 John 3:22). When the words *praying* (προσευχομενοι) and *asking (αιτουμενοι)* are used together, such as in this context, the implication is that praying is the more comprehensive term, and that asking involves *particular requests* in the prayer (cf. Matt. 21:22).

Paul prayed with *a specific purpose* in mind; there was *a given object* that he wanted to accomplish through prayer. This purpose is clearly seen in the *"ινα"* clause, namely, "in order that" God would produce specific positive knowledge in their minds. The purpose of Paul's continuous praying and asking was that they might be filled with a perfect knowledge of God's will.

The Greek verb translated "filled" *(πληρωθητε)* means to *make full,* to *fully supply,* or to *make complete.* Since this word is in the passive voice it is clear that Paul is not talking about something that they themselves are to do, but contrariwise, he is asking *God to do something for them.* God is the one who actively fills, supplies, and completes; they are the cooperating recipients of the work of God.

The specific thing Paul asks God to do is to fill them with a perfect knowledge of His will. The word translated "perfect knowledge" *(επιγνωσιν)* is derived from two Greek words, "επι" and "γινωσκω." The word "γινωσκω" by itself means to *know.* When the preposition "επι" is prefixed to this word the meaning is strengthened and perfected; therefore, we prefer to translate it *perfect knowledge, full knowledge,* complete knowledge, etc. This meaning is well supported by the use of *"επιγνωσις"* in the Greek New Testament (cf. Rom 10:2; Eph. 1:17; 4:13; 1 Tim. 2:4; 1 Cor. 13:12). Observe, that which Paul wants them to have is a perfect knowledge of *God's will.*

There is nothing that will establish believers and prepare them to stand against false teaching like a perfect knowledge of the will of God. False teaching is an expression of the will of man, originating in the depraved mind of man (cf. Eph. 2:1-3). True teaching is the expression of the will of God, originating in the mind of God, and recorded in the Word of God, the Bible. Paul recognizes that there is only one adequate combatant against error and false teaching, and that is a perfect knowledge of the will of God as revealed in the Word of God!

Paul goes on to affirm that the perfect knowledge of the will of God is in all spiritual wisdom and understanding. If we interpret the case here as being locative; then the idea would be that a perfect knowledge of God's will is to be found *in the sphere of* all spiritual wisdom and understanding. On the other hand, if we interpret the case here as being instrumental, which would be our second feasible interpretation; then the idea would be that a perfect knowledge of God's will comes *by means of* all spiritual wisdom and understanding.

The original Greek word order brings out the fact that the wisdom and understanding Paul is writing about is characterized as being spiritual, i.e., that which is *given by the Spirit.* Regardless of whether we interpret this case as being locative or instrumental, the basic thought remains the same, believers gain a perfect knowledge of God's will either in the sphere of Spirit-given wisdom and understanding or by means of Spirit-given wisdom and understanding. In the first case we have a picture of believers mentally *bathing* in the wisdom revealed by the Holy Spirit, and in the second case Spirit revealed wisdom is the *means* by which believers obtain a perfect knowledge of the will of God.

Paul uses the word "wisdom" *(σοφια)* in the New Testament with reference to *a distinct body of truth.* He does not tell the Colossians to search the Old Testament Scriptures in order to gain a perfect knowledge of God's will as to how they are to think and live in this present Church age. If the Law was the basis for the conduct of believers in the Church; then it logically follows that Paul would have told them to meticulously study the Law in order to perfectly know and do the will of God.

Furthermore, if truth regarding the distinct organism, the Church, the Body of Christ, was revealed in the Old Testament; then why

didn't Paul refer them back to the Old Testament for wisdom and understanding that would enable them to perfectly know the will of God? The fact is that the wisdom and knowledge Paul is referring to here *is not revealed in the Old Testament,* but is *distinct truth* that was *revealed by the Spirit* primarily through the Apostle Paul (cf. Rom. 16:25-26; 1 Cor. 2:6-10; Eph. 3:2-10).

Paul uses the Greek word translated "wisdom" *(σοφια)* some twenty-seven times in his epistles. Approximately *sixteen* times he uses it with reference to distinct truth for the Church which was revealed by the Spirit (1 Cor 2:10). Most of the other times Paul uses the word "wisdom" with reference to the human wisdom of men. We can positively say, without fear of contradiction, that in Paul's vocabulary the word "wisdom" *(σοφια),* when used of Divine truth, is used almost exclusively pertaining to truth for the Body of Christ, the Church. It is used synonymously with such terms as the *mystery,* the dispensation of the grace of God, and the unsearchable riches of Christ (Eph. 3:2-10).

Never forget, God the Holy Spirit uses this Divinely revealed wisdom, the mystery, to produce in us a perfect knowledge of His will! This is why we major in teaching literally the epistles of the Apostle Paul.

10. ***"to walk worthily of the Lord pleasing in everything, bearing fruit in every good work, and increasing in the perfect knowledge of God,"***

The main emphasis of the previous verse was that believers might be filled with a perfect knowledge of God's will. To know God's will is absolutely essential to the doing of God's will. The emphasis in this verse is on *living* according to the will of God. Paul admonishes them to walk worthily of the Lord. The Greek word translated "walk" *(περιπατησαι)* comes from two Greek words that literally mean to walk about or around; hence, it is used to refer to the conduct, living, and life-style of believers.

The Gospel first involves *straight thinking* about God and the need to have a perfect knowledge of His will, and second it involves *straight living* that conforms to the straight thinking, that which is in alignment with His perfect will. In other words, believers are to walk "worthily" *(αξιως)* of the Lord, i.e., in a manner that is *fitting, proper,* and *in keeping with* His person and will.

Paul goes on to define more exactly what it is to walk worthily of the Lord. It is conduct that has as its end *to please God in every single thing.* The preposition "εις" used with the accusative singular *"πασαν"* emphasizes the fact that the ultimate object of our conduct and life-style should be to please God in *everything* we say and do. Thus we see that to live worthily of the Lord is first, to *know His will,* second, to *do His will,* and third, to *please Him* in every aspect of our conduct.

Paul emphasizes this same truth in his other epistles, for he tells the Ephesians to walk *worthily of their calling* (Eph. 4:1); he tells the Philippians to conduct themselves *worthily of the Gospel* of Christ (Phil. 1:27); and he encourages the Thessalonians to walk *worthily of God* (I Thess. 2:12). God is the one who has determined the *standard* by which believers are to conduct themselves (Eph. 2:10). This standard is synonymous with the will of God; it has been revealed by the Spirit of God (1 Cor. 2:10-12), and it is recorded in the Word of God.

Paul now adds a third dimension to what it means to walk worthily of the Lord, namely, believers are to *bear fruit* in every good work. The word translated "bearing fruit" (καρποφορουντες) conveys the idea of *bringing forth or producing fruit.* Paul is specifically speaking of the fruit of *good works* here (Gal. 5:22-23); these are good works which God prepared beforehand for believers to fulfill (Eph. 2:10).

The Greek word "καρποφορουντες" is a present participle, and as such, indicates that this is to be a continuous way of life for believers. In verse six Paul speaks of the *Gospel* as that which bears fruit through believers. In writing to the Roman believers, Paul says that they have been joined to the living Christ that they might continuously bear fruit to God (Rom. 7:4). This fruit bearing is not to be limited to a narrow gamut, but is to include *every good work* as determined by the needs in the believer's immediate environment.

Furthermore, to walk worthily of the Lord includes the fourth dimension of *increasing* in the perfect knowledge of God. The word translated "increasing" (αυξανομενοι) speaks of movement, growth, and the augmenting of our perfect knowledge of God. The emphasis in the previous verse was that believers might be filled with a perfect knowledge of God's will, whereas the emphasis in this verse is on

believers daily (present tense) laying hold of the *perfect knowledge of God Himself.*

It is one thing to theoretically know about God, which is basic truth, but it is imperative that we *personally and empirically know Him* through daily walking with Him! The position of this statement in the context, immediately following Paul's emphasis on a walk worthy of the Lord and rich in good works, makes it clear that entering into this knowledge is *on the basis of practical obedience* to the truth. We need to keep in mind that God's desire for all believers is to be filled with a perfect knowledge of His will and to grow in the perfect knowledge of Himself; however, these are *goals* which can only be attained through a *balance between studying and practicing* His Word!

Those who flagrantly disobey God's will, as they know it today, have no right to expect further insight into His will tomorrow! Likewise, those who fail to walk worthily of the Lord, and who fail to allow the Spirit to produce good works in their lives, will *never* enter into the perfect knowledge of God Himself! *Studying* and *obeying* the Word of God are the two ingredients essential for increasing in the perfect knowledge of God!

11. ***"being made powerful with all power, according to the might of his glory, unto all endurance and longsuffering,"***

Paul continues praying for them that they might be made powerful with all power. Both the noun "power" (δυναμει) and the participle "being made powerful" (δυναμουμενοι) come from the same root word, which is transliterated into English as dynamite. Since the participle here is in the present tense and the passive voice, Paul is literally praying that they might *continuously* be made powerful *by God,* i.e., through the agency of the Holy Spirit.

ALL natural men are in a state and condition of *weakness (*ασθενεια*).* In Romans 5:6, Paul says that Christ died for men when they were weak. In Romans 8:3, Paul affirms that the Law failed due to the weakness of the flesh. In other words, estranged from God all men are weak, infirm, and spiritually sick. As believers, identified with God through Jesus Christ, we have the privilege of living by the power of God. We are able to do all things according to the power of God which energizes in us (Eph. 3:20).

The extent of God's power available to believers is according to the might of His glory. The Greek word translated "might" (κρατος) has the idea of *force, strength,* and *power.* The greatness of the Divine power allotted to believers is measured by the force and strength of His glory, i.e., the force that exalts God as the glorious sovereign of the universe. If Paul has in mind that the "Lord" is God the Son, then he may be referring to the force and power which Christ will display when He comes in power and great glory to establish His Kingdom (Matt. 24:30). Another possible interpretation is that the measure of God's power toward believers is as great as His glorious power. Regardless of which of the above interpretations we prefer, what Paul is really saying is that God's power available to believers is *unlimited!*

The reason Paul is praying is that they may be empowered with the power of God unto the end that they might have *all endurance and longsuffering.* The word translated "endurance" *(υπομονην)* is derived from a combining of two Greek words, which together literally mean to *remain under;* hence *to bear with, to be patient,* and *to be steadfast* in adversity. The word translated "longsuffering" *(μακρο–θυμιαν)* is also derived from the combining of two Greek words, which literally have the idea of *tong feeling, long in compassion or forbearance,* or *to be slow in avenging or punishing,* i.e., *to put up with a long time.*

This is the fourth fruit of the Spirit listed in Galatians 5:22. Paul's emphasis here is that they *need to be powerful in God's power* if they are going to have the *endurance,* steadfastness, and patience they should have. Furthermore, if they are going to have the *longsuffering, lengthy compassion,* and willingness to graciously *put up with others,* there is *no way* apart from having the *power of God the Holy Spirit* energizing in their lives! May God give us *power to endure* affliction (Rom. 5:3), and *longsuffering* that loves and forgives (1 Cor. 13:4; Eph. 4:2).

12. ***"(with joy) giving thanks to the Father who has qualified you to share the inheritance of the saints in the light;"***

Back in verse nine Paul told the Colossians that he was unceasingly praying and petitioning God on their behalf. As we have already observed he asked God to do several specific things in their lives. Now he reminds them that he and those associated with him

are *continuously* (present tense) thanking God for them. As we have already pointed out the word translated "giving thanks" (ευχαριστουντες) expresses the idea of *good grace, a good gift;* hence, *gratefulness* and *gratitude* for what God has graciously given to them.

It appears to us that the words "with joy," which in the verse division come at the end of verse eleven, should be actually the first part of verse twelve, with which the punctuation appearing in the Greek text concurs. This means that Paul *joyfully* expressed his thanks and gratitude to God for what He had freely *given* to them and for what He had done and was going to do in their lives (cf. Phil. 1:4)! Certainly, it is an occasion for great joy when one watches the *grace of God change the sinner into a saint who* loves *the Lord Jesus Christ with all his mind and heart!*

Paul joyfully directs his thanksgiving to God the *Father* the one who has qualified them to share in the inheritance of the saints. The word translated "qualified" *(*ικανωσαντι*)* means to *make fit* or *sufficient* for a given position. In Second Corinthians 3:5-6, Paul says that God is the one who made him *fit, sufficient,* and *qualified* as a minister of the new covenant.

Man is a totally depraved sinner by nature and is void of all inclination toward God (cf. Eph. 2:1-3; Rom. 3:9-18). Apart from God's sufficient provision of grace, entailing Christ's substitutionary redemptive work, the prevenient energizing of the Holy Spirit, and the faith to believe, no man is sufficient to become a partaker of the saints in the light (cf. Eph. 1:7; 2:4-9). God the Father, on the basis of His mercy and grace, makes His own elect *qualified* to take their position with the saints of all ages.

The thought here is that the saints do have an "inheritance" (κληρου), a lot, or a portion assigned to them, and this is in the sphere of the light, which may be interpreted to mean in the sphere of God, i.e., before or in the presence of God (cf. Eph. 5:8; 1 Thess. 5:5; 1 John 1:5). Thus we see that Paul was joyfully thanking God the Father for providing so great a salvation for the Colossians, those who were once sinners without God in this world, in total darkness, but now *by His grace* are sharing with all the saints their portion in the very presence of God.

13. ***"who delivered us out of the authority of darkness and***

transferred us into the kingdom of the Son of His love,"

Again, we emphasize the fact that Paul is not thanking God for what the Colossian saints have done themselves, but for what *God has done for them* through His grace. Speaking in this same vein, Paul now proceeds to add that God has *delivered us,* i.e., all believers, out of the power of darkness. The key word here is "delivered" *(*ερρυσατο*),* which depicts the idea to *draw out from,* to *save from,* and to *rescue.* As used in the New Testament the best English equivalent is the word *deliver,* with the word *rescue* coming in as a close second choice. Examples are Paul's desire to be delivered from disobedient, perverse, and evil men (Rom. 15:31; 2 Thess. 3:2); the fact that Jesus will deliver believers from the coming wrath (1 Thess. 1:10); and Paul's use of it to describe how the Lord delivered him out of a lion's mouth (2 Tim. 4:17). It is never used in the New Testament with reference to a person delivering himself, but the one delivering is always the Lord, it is the exclusive work of the Lord.

The word "delivered" *(*ερρυσατο*)* is used here in the aorist tense, which means that those to whom Paul is referring were delivered at a given point of time in the past. In other words, Paul is talking about a once-and-for-all deliverance, a completed transaction, and that which was produced by God. We must keep in mind that this deliverance was *initiated,* preveniently *effected* in time, and ultimately *completed* by God. Since it is that which has been wrought by God, and God does all things perfectly, it stands to reason that the deliverance Paul is talking about here *cannot be undone;* the results of this deliverance are for eternity.

One of the tragedies of our age is that *atheistic humanism* has subtly infiltrated the minds of many Christians, and unaware of the *diabolical perverting influence* this has had upon their minds, they are *interpreting the Word of God in the light of their humanistic bias* instead of permitting it to say what it literally says. We need believers today who will take God and His Word seriously, apart from all influences of this present evil age (2 Cor. 4:4), and who will recognize that God alone is able to give the sinner the *quality* that makes him a saint, and that God alone is able to *deliver* one out of the power of darkness and transfer him into the Body of Christ, the Church! Thanks be unto God who *has delivered* us and who knows how to daily deliver us from overwhelming temptation (2 Peter 2:9).

We have tried to give God total credit as the *one* who delivers; now we want to consider that from which he has delivered us, namely, the *power of darkness.* The Greek word translated "power" (εξουσιας) may equally well be translated *authority.* These two meanings tend to converge; one has authority because he has power and one has power because he has authority. Many passages in the New Testament are preferably translated authority, but lurking in the background of each is the idea of power. Examples of these are Jesus teaching as one who had *authority* (Matt. 7:29); the fact that the Son of Man had *authority* to forgive sins (Mark 2:10); and Jesus gave His disciples *power (εξουσιαν)* and *authority* over all demons (Mark 3:15). The thought in this context is that God delivered us out of the power of darkness, i.e., *out from under the authority* of the one characterized as darkness.

What does Paul mean by the phrase the *power or authority of darkness?* Jesus uses the identical phrase in Luke 22:53, obviously with reference to Satan. In Acts 26:18, Paul speaks of himself as being sent to turn men from the *power or authority of Satan* (darkness) to God. In Ephesians 2:2, Paul speaks of the "ruler of the power (εξουσιας) of the air, the spirit now energizing in the sons of disobedience," which obviously refers to Satan. Paul is talking about God reaching into Satan's domain and taking out from under his authority men, women, and children and transferring them into the kingdom of Christ. Apart from the sovereign prevenient grace of God no man can be freed from the power and authority of Satan!

God having delivered us out from under Satan's power and authority, transfers us into the kingdom of the Son of His love. The word "transferred" *(μετεστησεν)* comes from a combination of two Greek words, which literally mean to *change one's position* or the place he stands; hence the translation *transferred* or *transported* in the aorist tense, which we have here. The phrase the "kingdom of the Son of his love" is used only here in the New Testament and apparently refers to the *Church,* the *Body of Christ,* which is the only thing God is making believers members of today.

The word "kingdom" *(βασιλεια),* as used in the New Testament, almost exclusively refers to the earthly Messianic Kingdom over which Jesus Christ will reign as King (cf. Matt. 3:2; 4:17; 9:35). We today are not involved in an earthly kingdom program, with its

accompanying sign gifts, but we have been delivered from Satan's domain and *transferred into a spiritual kingdom,* the Body of Christ, the Church. May we with Paul continuously *thank God* for so great a deliverance and transfer!

14. ***"in whom we have the redemption, the forgiveness of sins."***

As Paul thanks God for making them saints, for delivering them from the power of Satan, and for transferring them into Christ's kingdom, he recognizes that the basis for all this Divine working is the redemption that we have in Christ. The word translated "redemption" *(*απολυτρωσιν*)* has the literal meaning of *buying, redeeming, and ransoming from;* hence *redemption, deliverance,* and *liberation* as a result of Christ's substitutionary death on Calvary. It is important to note that this redemption is *in Christ,* the locative case, in the sphere of the Person of Jesus Christ.

Paul emphasizes this same truth in his other epistles; redemption is in Christ and He is the embodiment of redemption. In Romans 3:24, Paul speaks of the redemption that is in Christ Jesus. In First Corinthians 1:30, Paul says that Christ was made redemption for us believers. In Ephesians 1:7, Paul affirms that we have redemption in Christ through His blood. Peter also makes it clear that there *is no salvation* in any name under heaven except that of Jesus Christ (Acts 4:12). In Jesus Christ, and in Him alone, we have redemption, liberation, and deliverance from sin.

Furthermore, in Jesus Christ we have the forgiveness of sins. The Greek word for "forgiveness" *(*αφεσιν*)* comes from a combining of the two Greek words "απο" and *"*ιηυι*"* and literally means *to send from, to send away,* and *to dismiss.* In keeping with the literal meaning the noun form that we have here is well translated *remission, forgiveness,* and *pardon.*

The word translated "sins" *(*αμαρτιων*)* has the basic idea of *missing the mark,* and is the most common Greek word used for sin in the New Testament. The *sending away, remission,* and *forgiveness* of sins is in Christ. The locative case indicates that the remitting of sins is in the sphere of Jesus Christ, with the implication that He alone is able to erase our sins. In Acts 10:43, Peter says that everyone believing through the name of Jesus Christ has forgiveness of sins. In Acts 13:38, Paul tells the Galatians that forgiveness of sins is through Jesus Christ. The basis for forgiveness of sins is the Blood

of Christ (cf. Eph. 1:7; Heb. 9:22). The redemption and the forgiveness of sins, which God the Father has provided for us in Christ His Son, is a maximum expression of the *grace of God.*

15. ***"Who is the image of the invisible God, the first-born of all creation,"***

This verse gives us two important facts describing who Jesus Christ is. First, He is the image of God who is invisible to the eyes of men. The word "image" *(εικων)* means *to be like, likeness, replica,* and an *expression. In* John 1:18, we are told that no one has ever seen God; but that the only begotten God, Christ, has led Him out, i.e., made Him manifest. In Second Corinthians 4:4, Paul affirms the same truth that we have here, namely, Christ is the image of God. In First Corinthians 11:7, man, as a new creation in Christ, was created in God's image and is to be daily renewed according to the image of his Creator (Col. 3:10).

God's ultimate purpose for us believers is change unto the end that we might bear the perfect image of Christ, who is the very image of God (cf. 2 Cor. 3:18; 1 Cor. 15:49). In Christ, the image of God, we have a manifestation of the invisible Person of God the Father, for Jesus says in John 14:9, "the one who has seen me has seen the Father."

The second fact about Jesus Christ is that He is the *first-born of all creation.* In as much as all things were created by means of and through the eternal Christ; therefore, He *had to be existing* before anything else was brought into existence. According to the Word of God Paul knew that God the Son was active in creation and obviously existed before that time; however, how *long* prior to that time, apparently he had no particular revelation.

The Greek word translated "first-born" (πρωτοτοκος) may be used to speak of the *child born first* in a given family (cf. Luke 2:7; Heb. 11:28); however, out of the eight times it is used in the New Testament, five times it definitely refers to the Person of Jesus Christ. In three of the contexts in which it is used the emphasis is on the fact that Jesus Christ was the *first to establish a new order* such as the *resurrection,* in whose train others would follow (cf. Col. 1:18; Rev. 1:5); likewise, God's purpose was that He (Christ) might be first among believers *conformed to the image of His Son* (Rom. 8:29). The idea in these passages is *on priority in the sense of time* and has

absolutely nothing to do with initial existence.

The word first-born is used twice as *a proper name,* once of the eternal Christ (cf. Heb. 1:6) and once of believers (cf. Heb. 12:23). The only basic thing we can establish with regard to the meaning of this word is that it does emphasize one as being *first or prior in time.* To try to use it to prove that God the Father produced the birth of Christ, and therefore He is a created being inferior to God, and not a part of the eternal Trinity, is unsubstantiated by its use in the New Testament.

As we have often pointed out, the meaning of a given word is determined by two things, its *etymology* (derivation) and the meaning given to it in *actual usage.* Paul's epistles consistently present *Jesus Christ as God,* as *God the Son,* and his use of the word "first-born" here, according to usage, says the same thing (cf. Rom. 1:4; Eph. 3:19; Col. 2:9; 3:3).

One thing that all cults have in common is that they *attack the integrity of the Person of Jesus Christ,* and particularly *His deity.* As those who are naive or willfully ignorant of the truth of the New Testament, particularly of the distinct revelation of *truth pertaining to the Church,* they pervert the Scriptures to the destruction of themselves and others. Some of them go so far as to try to change the original Greek text and pervert its meaning in their effort to foist their Satanic apostasy on others!

Paul's use of the word "first-born" *(πρωτοτοκος)* here *emphasizes only* the fact that Christ *existed prior* to the creation of the universe and all that is in it, and cannot be justifiably used to prove that He is a created being, which is the furthest thing from Paul's mind in this context.

In writing to the Ephesians about God's sovereign purpose prior to the creation of the universe, Paul takes for granted the existence of the eternal Christ (Eph. 1:4-5). It is impossible to think of God, who according to the Scriptures is a Triune God, as existing at all unless He existed totally, i.e., in the form of God the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit (cf. Gen. 1:26; 11:7)!

16. ***"because all things were created by him, in the heavens and upon the earth, visible and invisible things, whether thrones or dominions or rulers or authorities; all things were created***

through him and unto him,"

This may be translated "because all things were created *in him,"* which would make it a locative case; or it may be translated "all things were created *by him,"* or *by means of Him,* as in the instrumental case, which most clearly brings out the obvious intended meaning. The Greek word for "created" (εκτιοθη) means *to make, found,* and *to form* something out of nothing (John 1:3). This word is used *exclusively of God* in the New Testament; it speaks of that which is the *work of God.* The emphasis here is that the Triune God, by means of the Person of the Son, created all things. In the last part of this verse the preposition "δια" used with the genitive emphasized the fact that all things were created *through the agency of* Jesus Christ, in other words, he was the Divine Agent in creation (cf. John 1:3; Eph. 3:9; Heb. 1:2; 11:3).

Having observed the fact that all things were created *by means* of Jesus Christ, we now want to consider the *extensiveness* of what He created. He was the active agent through whom *all things* were created in the sphere of the heavens and upon the earth.

The Greek word for "heavens" (ουρανοις) depicts the heights and regions above the earth, i.e., the unlimited expanse of the sky and space. It is the sphere in which the stars exist (Heb. 11:12). Paul speaks of being taken up *until* (εως) the third heaven, i.e., as far as the third heaven (2 Cor. 12:2). He also refers to Christ as one who ascended *far above (υπερανω)* all the heavens (Eph. 4:10). Furthermore, Paul speaks of the heavens as being the sphere in which God the Father and Son dwell (cf. Eph. 6:9; Heb. 8:1); and John says that it was the place from which the Holy Spirit came (John 1:32). Thus we see that the word "heavens" apparently includes everything in the universe apart from the earth.

Paul refers to the earth as that area which is under the heaven (1:23). According to the Biblical mind the universe consisted of two spheres, the heavens and the earth, and both were created *through the Divine agency of Jesus Christ.* This same truth is affirmed in John 1:3, where we read, "ALL things were made through him, and not one thing was made apart from him, which was made." Paul confirms this same truth in Hebrews 1:10, where God the Father says of the Son, "You from the beginning, Lord, have founded the earth, and the heavens are the works of your hand." Regardless of where one is in

the universe, whether upon the earth or in space, all that surrounds him was created by and through the Person of Jesus Christ!

Paul goes on to emphasize the fact that Christ was the *sole creator* of all things in the heavens and upon the earth. Both "visible things" *(*τα ορατα*),* things which are seen, and "invisible things" (τα αορατα), things which are not seen were created by Him. Since the human eye is capable of impressing upon the brain only a very small part of that which has been created; therefore Paul declares that Christ has created that which is invisible as well as that which is visible. Nothing exists in the universe apart from Christ having created it, whether it be so minute that it cannot be seen, or so gigantic that it cannot be comprehended (John 1:3). Paul leaves *no room* for anything to have come into existence through the utterly unscientific theory of evolution, which is a ridiculous unproved figment of the humanistic mind estranged from God (cf. Rom. 1:20-23).

Whatever we find in the universe, whether thrones, dominions, rulers, or authorities, all have been created by Jesus Christ. The Greek word translated "thrones" *(*θρονοι*)* refers to *a seat, a chair with a footstool,* or *the place occupied by kings.* In the New Testament it is used with reference to the throne of God in heaven (Matt. 5:34); it is used regarding the throne Christ will occupy in glory (Matt. 19:28); and it is used regarding the Disciples, who will sit upon twelve thrones judging the twelve tribes of Israel (Matt. 19:28). It is also used with reference to the throne of Satan (Rev. 2:13). It appears that Paul is using this word here metaphorically regarding *exalted dignitaries,* those with supreme power, kings, etc. He is obviously not using it with reference to God the Father or Son, for the latter is the one who has created these majestic dignitaries.

The Greek word translated "dominions" *(*κυριοτητες*)* speaks of those who have positions of *lordship, authority over others,* or *potentates.* When God the Father raised Jesus Christ out from the dead He exalted Him to His right hand far above everyone having a position of lordship (Eph. 1:21). Peter speaks of unrighteous men who despise those in positions of Lordship (2 Peter 2:10). Jude likewise speaks of defiled men who reject the lordship over them (Jude 8). It may be difficult to precisely determine who those are in these positions of lordship, but one thing is clear, they were created by the Eternal Christ.

The Greek word translated "rulers" *(αρχαι),* literally those who are *first in rank and power,* and the Greek word for "authorities" (εξουσιαι), literally *those who have the ability, right, and authority,* are commonly used together in the New Testament. Jesus Christ, in His exalted position at the right hand of God the Father, is far above every ruler and authority (Eph. 1:21).

Paul speaks of the *rebellious rulers and authorities* of Satan who endeavor to destroy believers (Eph. 6:12; cf. 3:10). Through His death on the cross Jesus Christ *divested* Satanic rulers and authorities of their power, once and for all triumphing over them (Col. 2:14-15). In the future Jesus Christ *will destroy* all rule, authority, and power, i.e., these rebellious associates of Satan will be judged (1 Cor. 15:23-24).

From these passages it is obvious that Paul commonly uses these two words to represent the evil forces associated with Satan. Paul makes it clear that Satan is the god of this age (2 Cor. 4:4), and as such these rulers and authorities are cooperating with him (Eph. 2:2-3). Their ultimate object is to *keep men in darkness* under their control; hence to prevent them from believing the Gospel and coming under the Lordship of Christ (2 Cor. 4:4).

In summarizing the truth that Christ created these thrones, dominions, rulers, and authorities, observe with us some of the implications. First, regardless of whether their present purpose is to do good or evil, to exercise their power for God or for Satan, they were *originally created by Christ.* Second, they were originally created for the purpose of *glorifying God,* of synchronizing together to produce that which was good (cf. Gen. 1:31). Third, as free moral agents Satan and his cohorts rebelled against God, they rose up in disobedient opposition to God, thus introducing evil into the world (Gen. 3:1-20; Rom. 8:18-25). Fourth, all rule, authority, and power had its beginning with God and was created by Christ, and as such is said to be arranged by God (cf. Rom. 13:1-2).

Subsequent to Satan's rebellion God had granted him considerable authority in conjunction with the world system, namely, *over the kingdoms of the inhabited earth* (Luke 4:1-7). Jesus calls Satan the *ruler of the world* (John 14:30), and Paul refers to him as *the god of this age (2* Cor. 4:4).

In conclusion, just because these rulers were arranged by God

and arranged by Christ does not mean that *today,* since the rebellion, they are accomplishing their original intended purpose of good. Believers *must discern* what is good and evil according to the Word of God and be ready to say with Peter and John, "If it is right in the sight of God to obey You rather than God, you judge" (Acts 4:19).

Finally, Paul says that God the Father created all things *through Him (Christ) and unto Him.* The first part of this statement is a reaffirmation of what Paul already said at the beginning of this verse. The main difference is that above Paul emphasized that *Christ was the means* by which God the Father created all things; whereas, here he emphasizes that *Christ is the agent* through whom God the Father has created all things. The Greek preposition "δια" with the genitive case consistently expresses the idea of personal agency, i.e., the Godhead through the personal agency of the Son effected the creation of all things.

The statement that all things were created unto Him (Christ) sets forth exceedingly important truth. The preposition "εις" used with the accusative case expresses the fact that Christ is not only the agent in producing creation, but He Himself is the *end of creation,* the *object* of creation, the *reason why* all things were created. As we grasp this truth that Christ is the end and reason for all of creation; then we come to understand that life has *meaning and purpose* only for those who are identified with Him through faith (2 Cor. 5:14-15; Gal. 2:20; Phil. 1:21)!

17. ***"and he is before all things, and all things are held together by him."***

The Greek verb *"εστιν"* is in the present tense; therefore, we have translated it He *is* before all things. In the light of the preceding context it appears that the thought being conveyed would be more accurately expressed by the English verb was, i.e., He was before all things. The word translated "before" (προ) means to be before in the sense of time, to be in advance of, or prior to all things. If all things were created by and through Christ, it follows that He had to exist prior to all things.

John affirms the same truth, the eternal existence of Christ, for he says that the Word (Christ) was *with God in the beginning* (John 1:1-2). In John 17:5, Jesus says that He shared glory with the Father prior to the existence of the world. Furthermore, Jesus declares that

the Father loved Him before the foundation of the world (John 17:24). To deny the eternal existence of Christ is to deny the literal truth of God's Word! The *Bible will condemn* those cults which deny that the eternal Christ is God on the Day of Judgment - their end will be eternal destruction!

In view of the context, we prefer to translate the latter part of this verse "all things are held together by him" (instrumental case) rather than "all things are held together *in* him" (locative case). In the first case the emphasis is on *Christ as the means* by which all things are held together. In the latter case the emphasis is on *Christ as the sphere* in which all things are held together. The Bible does not teach that God is a subjective part of creation, as the latter translation might suggest, but that He bears an *objective relation* to it (cf. Gen. 1:31-2:3). God the Son is not a part of, but *apart from* all that He created, and in this apart from position holds all things together.

The Greek word translated "held together" (συνεστη–κεν) is derived from two Greek words *"συν"* and *"ιστημι"* which literally mean to *stand with* or to *place together.* Paul uses this word some sixteen times in his epistles with the predominant meaning of *commend, recommend,* or to *present as approved.* Luke uses this word once with the basic idea of standing with (Luke 9:32). Peter uses the same word once regarding the formation of the earth out of water and through water; however the context is such that it does not give us a precise meaning, but is probably best translated *formed, shaped together, or compacted (2* Peter 3:5). The Greek verb "συνεστηκεν" which we have translated held together, is in the *perfect tense, and* indicates that at the time of creation Christ *initiated a given act,* the results of which *continue in full effect.*

Due to the fluidity of this word and its predominant meaning in Paul's other epistles, we raise the question: Just what did Christ initiate and continue to effect? If we translate it as placed together, formed, compacted, etc., as a once-and-for-all act; then why didn't Paul use the aorist tense? If we translate it by the English words *are held together,* are given cohesion, etc., then we would expect the perfect tense to be used, as it is, indicating Christ's *continuous role in sustaining* that which He has created. If we were to use Paul's predominant usage-meaning, then the thought would be that God the Father by means of the Son commends or approves all things as

being good (cf. Gen. 1:31).

In view of the way this word is used in other Biblical and extra-biblical passages, its basic meaning, and its use in this context with the perfect tense, we prefer to translate and interpret it to mean that Christ is the one *who gave cohesion,* and who *continues to give cohesion,* to all that He created. This being true, God the Son is, indeed, the very center of the universe, the one who holds all mass together and who maintains the planets in their respective orbits.

18. ***"And he is the head of the body, the church; who is the beginning, the first-born out from the dead, that he might be the first one in all things,"***

Having adequately dealt with Christ's eternal existence and His key role in creation, Paul declares that He is now the *Head of the Body,* the Church. The Old Testament prophets looked forward to His coming as one who would occupy the throne of David and reign as *a King* (cf. Isa. 9:6-7; Jer. 23:5-6; Daniel 2:44; Micah 4:1-5). The Synoptic Gospels looked upon Him as the one who did come to fulfill Old Testament prophecy; He was virgin born in human flesh to be *King of the Jews* (cf. Matt. 1:1, 6, 22-23; 2:2; 27:37; Rom. 15:8). The Jewish religious leaders having rejected Him as their king (Matt. 27:1-2; Acts 4:1-4; 7:51-54), God in Grace established the Church, the Body of Christ, over which He made Jesus Christ the sole Head (Eph. 1:22-23).

The supreme task of making known the nature of God's new program and purpose, the Church, was committed unto the Apostle Paul (cf. Eph. 3:2-11). We must keep in mind that false teachers were endeavoring to pervert the truth of the Gospel at Colossae. Paul's main deterrent, in combating their evil influence, was to point out to the Colossian believers exactly *who Jesus Christ is* and *what He had done for them,* i.e., that they are *complete in Him,* the Head over the Body, the Church (Col. 2:10). The answer to false doctrine is true Biblical knowledge of the *Person* and *work* of Jesus Christ!

Having stated the fact that Christ is the Head of the Body, the Church, Paul proceeds to add that He is the "beginning" (αρχη), i.e., since He was in the beginning, at the very first, Paul defines, describes, and names Him the *Beginning.* Go back to the furthest extremity of time, to a time known only by God the Spirit, and *God the Son was there* according to the Spirit, for He says, "In the beginning

was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. This one was in the beginning with God" (John 1:1-2).

According to the testimony of the Spirit in the Book of Hebrews, He had *no beginning of days* (Heb. 7:3). The testimony of the Spirit through John was that He was *from the beginning* (1 John 1:1; 2:14), i.e., there is no evidence that there was a time when He was not. In the Book of Revelation, as in this verse, the Spirit of God through John gives Jesus the name *The Beginning* (Rev. 21:6; 22:13). The clear testimony of the Word of God, corroborated by the testimony of the Spirit in the redeemed mind, is that Christ has *eternally existed* and is rightfully called *The Beginning!*

Christ who is the beginning is also said to be the "first-born" (πρωτοτοκος) out from the dead. The Greek word for "first-born" depicts Christ as being the *first in a new order of resurrected beings.* The thought Paul is conveying here is that Christ is the first one to initiate a *spiritual generation* constituted of those who were once dead. Even as through Adam a physical generation of human beings was brought into existence; likewise through Jesus Christ a spiritual generation of *spiritual beings is brought into existence.*

Paul uses the word "first-fruit" (απαρχη) to express the same general thought in writing to the Corinthians, for he says, "And now Christ is raised out from the dead, the first-fruits of those who have been sleeping" (I Cor. 15:20). The idea here is that Christ's resurrection is the first of something new (a crop) and in due season the resurrection of believers will follow. Thus we see that the resurrection of Jesus Christ is the basis for our resurrection (cf. 1 Thess. 4:14). Just as certainly as He was raised; likewise our resurrection will *follow!*

In summarizing the above facts relating to Jesus Christ, we observe the following truths. First, He is the *image* of the invisible God. Second, He has *eternally existed,* He was here before anything else. Third, all things in the universe were *created by Him.* Fourth, Christ is the *end, object,* and *purpose of creation.* Fifth, He continues to hold together all that He created. Sixth, He is the exclusive *Head* over the Church. Seventh, He is named *The Beginning.* Eighth, He is the progenitor of a new race of resurrected beings.

After having told the Colossians *who* Jesus Christ is and that all things have been created by Him, Paul goes on to explain why God

the Father allotted to Him, God the Son, such a prestigious role. The purpose is clearly stated in the Greek through the use of *"ινα"* with the subjunctive mode, which is most literally translated, "in order that He, Himself, might be the first one in all things." The obvious implication is that before the Colossians could or would give Jesus Christ first place in their lives, they had to know *who* He was and *what* He had done.

True and lasting commitment and devotion to Jesus Christ must be based upon a thorough knowledge of His Person, of who He is, of the authority assigned to Him, and of what He has accomplished. We must endeavor to learn all we can about Him through the predictions in the Old Testament, through His incarnate life, death, and resurrection presented in the Gospels, and through meticulously studying the New Testament epistles! Over and over again Paul pleads with us as believers: "Brethren, I do not want You to be *ignorant* (αγνοεω)," i.e., *without knowledge* (cf. Rom. 11:25, 1 Cor. 10:1; 1 Thess. 4:13).

Paul's purpose in communicating knowledge about Jesus Christ to the Colossians was that they might make Him the *first one* in their lives. The Greek word which we have translated "first one" *(πρωτευων)* conveys the idea of both *first in time* and *first in preeminence.* Since Paul has already emphasized the fact that Christ is first in the sense of time and has laid this as a basis, we believe the emphasis here is that He is *first in rank, the preeminent one,* and the *supreme one.* The Greek word *"πρωτευων"* is a present participle in the nominative case. It is really the *subject* of this clause, and for grammatical clarity could be translated, "first one that he might be."

The emphasis here is on the *Person of Jesus Christ and* the position we are to give to Him in our lives in relation to other things and persons. False teachers were trying to get the Colossians to put other things first in their lives, such as humanistic religious wisdom, philosophy, human traditions, circumcision, Judaistic legal requirements, worshiping of angels, etc. (cf. Col. 2:3-4, 8-10, 16-18, 20-23). Also, pressure was probably being brought to bear upon them to put other men ahead of Christ, such as Moses, the Pharisees, the Sadducees, etc. As Paul writes here he is instructing us believers in the Body of Christ, the Church, *to make Christ the first one* above everything and everyone else.

John the Baptist confirms the fact that Christ is the first and

supreme one, for he cried out, "The one coming after me has been before me, because he was *first"* (John 1:15). The genitive of comparison used here indicates that Jesus in comparison to John was the first, supreme, and preeminent one.

Furthermore, Jesus makes it clear in Luke 14:26 that He will *never take second place* to any other person, for He says, "if anyone comes to me and does not hate his own father and mother and wife and children and brothers and sisters, and even his own life, it is not possible to be my disciple." Jesus leaves no room for dividing allegiance. It is impossible for us to serve two masters; neither can we serve Him and money simultaneously (Luke 16:13). Regardless of the dispensational setting, whether it is Church or Kingdom, Jesus Christ demands to be the *first, supreme,* and *preeminent one* in our lives (cf. John 21:15-17; Gal. 2:20; Phil. 1:21; 3:8-10).

*19. **"for he was pleased (God the Father) for all the fullness to dwell in him"***

This verse is a brief summary of the *reason why* Jesus Christ is worthy to be the first one in the lives of believers. The Greek conjunction translated "for" *(οτι)* more literally has the idea of *because* in this context, i.e., because all the fullness dwells in Christ; therefore He was to be the first one. ALL that Paul has said about who Christ is and what He accomplished is summed up in the statement *all the fullness* and is basic to God the Father's purpose that Christ should be the first and supreme one in our lives. The Greek word translated "pleased" (ευδοκησεν) means that God the Father *thought it good* or was *delighted* that the Trinity should fully occupy the Person of Jesus Christ, which in turn is the basis for His being the first one.

Now let us turn our attention to the most significant phrase "all the fullness" *(παν το πληρωμα*). The key word in this phrase is "fullness" (πληρωμα), which has the general meaning of that which *fills up,* that which is *complete,* full measure, etc. It is used with respect to twelve full baskets of bread fragments (Mark 6:43). It is used of the fullness of the earth, i.e., regarding all that the earth produces (1 Cor. 10:26).

The more important question is whether or not Paul uses this word with *a specific proper meaning.* Paul speaks of *the Church as the fullness* of God the Father (Eph. 1:23). Paul's prayer is that believers will be filled with all *the fullness of God* (Eph. 3:19). Paul's

desire for us is that we might attain unto the *fullness of Christ* (Eph. 4:13). In this verse we are told that all the *fullness dwells in Christ.* In chapter two Paul says that all the *fullness of deity* dwells in Him bodily (2:9).

It strikes us that the word "fullness" *(πληρωμα)* may be used as a common denominator in all these passages cited, and as such implies an *inscrutably close bond* between God the Father, Holy Spirit, Christ, the Church, and the believer as a part of the Church. It is exciting to reflect upon the fact that as the Church we are the fullness of God, which involves the fullness of Christ, which entails the fullness of the Godhead, an intimate relationship that exceeds the wildest imagination!

In the light of this highly privileged relationship with Christ in God the least we can do in this Satan dominated world, which hates Jesus Christ, is to make Christ the first, supreme, and preeminent one in our daily living (cf. John 7:7; 15:25; 2 Cor. 4:4).

20. ***"and through him to reconcile all things unto himself, having made peace through the blood of his cross, (through him) whether things upon the earth or things in the heavens."***

The Greek word translated "reconcile" (αποκαταλλαξαι) means to *transfer* from a given state to another, to *reinstate* to a position of harmony. If the prefixed "απο" has perfective significance, which would be logical in the three contexts in which it is used in the New Testament; then it could well convey the idea of to *reconcile thoroughly, completely,* or *perfectly.* God the Father, "through" (δια with the genitive) the personal agent of Jesus Christ the Son, made provision for a perfect reconciliation of all things unto Himself. In order to understand what Paul is talking about here we must posit the fact that with the Adamic sin also creation was cursed (cf. Gen. 3:16-18; Rom. 8:20,22).

Sin produced a barrier of *enmity* between God and all that had been created through Christ. The Cross, where Jesus Christ shed His blood in death as a result of assuming our sin, is the *basis* for replacing enmity with peace. Man's sin has brought the *wrath* of God against him; however, Christ, having assumed his sin and its wrath, has made provision for man to be reconciled and at peace with God (Rom. 5:1). The use of the aorist participle makes it clear that the *first thing* that had to take place was the *substitutionary death of Christ,*

which removed our sin and its enmity, and resulted in peace (cf. Rom. 5:9-10; Heb. 9:22).

Christ's blood shed upon Calvary's Cross is sufficient to reconcile all things in the universe, i.e., both on earth and in the heavens. The extent to which the universe was cursed by Adam's sin is not fully revealed, but in due time it will be reconciled (Rom. 8:19-22).

21. ***"And you were once alienated and enemies in mind-set in evil works,"***

These Colossians are now new creations in Christ (2 Cor. 5:17), those who have been perfectly reconciled to God through Christ, and those who have made their peace with God through the blood of the cross by exercising faith in Jesus Christ (Rom. 3:25). Paul momentarily turns the clock back a few months or years and reminds them what they *once were.*

First, they were a people who were "alienated" (απηλλοτριωμενους). The Greek word for "alienated" comes from the two words "απο" and "αλλοτριοω" and literally means to be *a stranger, alien,* or *foreigner away from,* i.e., who is totally *separated* from God. The perfect participle form used here indicates that at a given point of time in the past they had become alienated from God (cf. Rom. 5:12), the result of which left them to continue on as *alienated ones,* those in a state and condition *estranged from God.*

Second, they were a people who were "enemies" (εχθρους); a people who lived in a state of hatred, bitterness, hostility, and opposition toward God (cf. Eph. 4:17-18, 22). These two words accurately describe the state of every natural descendant of Adam in this world.

Now let us consider where this state of alienation and enmity resides in the natural man. Paul says that they were once an alienated and enemy people *in the mind.* The Greek words translated "the mind" *(τη διανοια)* are well thought of as the *brain in action.* The sum total of the physical activity of the brain is defined by the Greek word *"διανοια,"* which may be defined by the English terms mind, mind-set intellect, understanding, thinking, mode of thinking, and thought.

The grammatical form of this Greek word makes it possible for it to be in three different cases, two of which we will consider as

feasible in this context. First, it may be interpreted as a dative of respect, which would mean they were an alienated and enemy people *with respect to their minds.* Second, it may be interpreted as a locative case, which would mean they were aliens and enemies *in the sphere of their minds.* Regardless of which interpretation we might prefer, one thing is clear, the seat of their spiritual problem was in their mind or mind-set! With respect to their minds they were alienated and totally separated from God; He had absolutely no place in their lives, they were completely cut off from Him.

Furthermore, Paul did not want them to get the erroneous idea that as alienated ones they were passive, for he knew from his own personal experience how the natural man struggles against God; therefore, he adds the fact that they were *enemies.* To have met one of these unsaved Colossians on a country road, you may have felt that outwardly he was like any other person. However, after you had given him an opportunity to freely express what was on his alienated and hostile mind, you would have probably said, "Apart from Satan I cannot understand such bitterness and hatred of Jesus Christ and of God." Unless you understood how the sovereignty of God works, how that in mercy and grace the Holy Spirit irresistibly leads the vilest of sinners to faith in Jesus Christ, you probably would have given this person up as one who would never be saved.

We believe it is exceedingly important that we know the *seat* of the natural man's problem; it is in the *sphere of his mind* (cf. Rom. 1:21; 2 Cor. 11:3; 2 Tim. 3:8; Tit. 3:3). According to the Bible two things are necessary if his problem is going to be corrected. These two things are equally important, they are interdependent, and one is ineffectual without the other. From the standpoint of time one has precedence over the other; however, in actual practice it is most ideal for both to be working simultaneously.

First, the Spirit of God must begin working on the mind of the natural man, enabling him to see himself as he is, making him dissatisfied with his sinful state, implanting in him an interest in the Word of God, and ultimately drawing him to the Saviour, Jesus Christ (cf. John 6:44; 1 Cor. 1:30; Eph. 1:4). Second, the truth of the Gospel of God's Grace must be impressed upon the mind of the natural man, which involves the fact that all men are sinners, that Christ died for our sins, and that through the exercise of Divine faith we are identified with Christ as our Saviour. Furthermore, it contains

knowledge of how we are to live as members of the Body of Christ (Acts 20:24; Rom. 3:23; 1 Cor. 15:3; Eph. 2:8; Col. 1:28).

Even as the Spirit of God used the *Word of God, the Gospel of' Grace,* to lead many of the Colossians to faith in Jesus Christ; likewise this is God's method today. Our battle is for the *minds of men,* our weapon is an accurate presentation of the Gospel of God's Grace, which lays a *solid knowledgeable foundation in the mind* that was alien and at enmity with God (cf. 2 Cor. 4:3-6; 10:3-6; Eph. 6:12, 17).

Finally, we observe that when the Colossians were aliens and enemies with respect to their minds, this manifested itself through their living in the sphere of evil works. What the mind is determines what it will produce. A mind that is totally separated from God, that hates Him, cannot possibly produce anything else than evil works. Furthermore, living in the sphere of evil works tends to harden and accelerate further degeneration (cf. Eph. 4:17-18).

22. ***"but now you have been reconciled by his flesh body through death, to present you holy and blameless and irreproachable before him,"***

In verse twenty we saw that God the Father reconciled *all things* unto Himself through Jesus Christ. The main emphasis there was on the reconciliation of the universe, things which were upon the earth and in the heavens. The emphasis in this verse is on the reconciliation of the *Colossian saints,* which is an example of how God reconciles *everyone* who is an alien and enemy in his mind-set.

We have the same basic verb used here as in verse twenty for "reconcile" (αποκατηλλαγητε), with the prefixed preposition "απο;" this apparently emphasizes the fact that God has *perfectly* and *completely reconciled* these Colossian saints unto Himself. This verb is in the second person plural, the aorist tense, and the passive voice, which means three things: first, *you* personally were reconciled; second, it was an instantaneous *once-for-all* transaction; and third, it was the *work of God* on their behalf. Since God is the one who does the reconciling of sinful men unto Himself, it has to be a perfect act, a complete reconciliation, and that which is for eternity!

In verse twenty we observed that the reconciliation of all things is *based on the Blood of the Cross.* Likewise here, the reconciliation of

men is based on *the body of His flesh through death,* i.e., the basis is the *sacrifice of the physical body of Jesus Christ in death* upon Calvary.

The consistent testimony of the Word of God is that the *death* and *blood* of Jesus Christ is the basis for our reconciliation to God. In Romans 5:10, Paul says that we were reconciled to God through the death of His Son. In Second Corinthians 5:18-21, the heart of the message of reconciliation is that Christ, "the one not knowing sin, was made sin for us, that we might be made the righteousness of God in Him." The thought here is that Jesus Christ was *made our sin substitute* on the cross; this alone is the reason for His death.

When the word reconciliation is used we have in the background the idea of estrangement, hostility, enmity, and hatred. Adamic disobedience, which is sin, estranged men from God, linked them to Satan (cf. Gen. 3:4-6), and brought about enmity *(εχθραν)* toward God by both Jew and Gentiles. In Ephesians 2:16, Paul says that God reconciled both Jews and Gentiles "by one body to God through the cross, having killed the enmity by it." Without the shedding of Christ's Blood there could be no remission of sin, and without the remission of sin there could be no reconciliation, and without reconciliation all men would be eternally lost.

Paul, having declared that they have been reconciled, by means of the death of the body of Jesus Christ, now speaks of the end result of their being reconciled, namely, that they might be presented holy, blameless, and irreproachable before God the Father. The Greek word which we have translated "to present" *(παραστησαι)* literally means to *stand beside, to place beside,* or *to position before* or in the presence of God. Ultimately every believer will be presented, will stand beside, or take his position before the judgment seat of God (Rom. 14:10).

When Christ presents us to God the Father we will have three characteristics based upon our position in Him. First, we will be "holy" (αγιους), i.e., *separated unto God* from that which is common and unclean. Believers are to be identified with God in the attribute of holiness, for He has said, "You be holy, because I am holy" (Lev. 11:44; I Peter 1:16).

Second, we will be "blameless" (αμωμους), which literally means *without blemish, stain,* or *defect.* Jesus Christ, as the Lamb of God,

was offered upon Calvary void of any moral blemish, stain, or defect (cf. Heb. 9:14; 1 Peter 1:19); likewise, on the basis of His perfect sacrifice we will be without blame or defect before the Father.

Third, we will be "irreproachable" (ανεγκλητους), we *cannot be called in question, no one can bring any charges or accusations against us or arraign or indict us.* Deacons, elders, and overseers are to be irreproachable, i.e., their lives are to be such that no one can bring a charge against them (cf. 1 Tim. 3:10; Titus 1:6-7). Since God has justified us on the basis of the Cross we cannot be arraigned; we will stand irreproachable before God the Father (cf. Rom. 8:33-34).

23. ***"if you continue in the faith having been grounded and settled and are not being moved from the hope of the gospel which you heard, which was preached in all the creation under heaven, of which I Paul was made a minister."***

In the previous verse we emphasized the fact that our holy, blameless, and irreproachable position before God was totally dependent upon the death of Jesus Christ. This verse raises a very important question, namely, *who* are depending upon the redemptive work of Christ for a perfect standing before God? What evidence do we have that a person is truly born again by the Spirit of God?

Paul never vouched for the salvation of any person; neither did he go around telling people that they were unconditionally saved. If they believed the Gospel, if they stood upon the truth of the Gospel, and if they were indeed saved; then they would *continue to hold fast* (cf. 1 Cor. 15:1-2; 2 Cor. 13:5: Rom. 8:13-14; Heb. 3:6, 14). Keep in mind that a person is not saved by holding fast, but by believing in Jesus Christ, and holding fast is only the *result or mark* of the fact that he is truly saved (cf. Acts 16:31).

As Paul writes to the Colossians he recognizes that they are under a barrage of false doctrine, which separates the pseudo professors from the true believers (cf. 1 John 2:19). Those who are genuinely saved through the Blood of Christ will "continue" *(επιμενετε),* which comes from the combining of the two Greek words "επι" and "μενω" and literally means to *remain upon* or to *rest upon.* According to actual usage in this combination the prefix "επι" has the meaning of *in;* hence the basic idea is to *remain in,* which is best translated to *continue* and *persevere* (cf. Rom. 6:1; 1 Cor. 16:7). The use of the present tense also enhances the idea of continuance and

perseverance in the faith.

The Greek word translated "faith" *(πιστει)* may be interpreted in three different ways here. First, it may refer to a body of truth which constitutes the Gospel; that which is to be believed (cf. Gal. 1:23). Certainly the true believer will continue in true doctrine. Second, it may refer to the faith which one exercises in the truth of the Gospel (cf. Eph. 2:8). This faith is a gift of God which the believer exercises, and there is no salvation apart from it, for it is God's way of identifying the sinner with the Saviour. Third, the Greek word *"πιστει"* used here also conveys the idea of *faithfulness* in some contexts (cf. Gal. 3:22; Philemon 5). This meaning would emphasize the need for believers to continue in faithfulness, i.e., to live in obedience to the truth of the Gospel.

In summarizing the above three interpretations they are really three parts of the whole. Believers who have *exercised true faith* in Jesus Christ will *continue in the truth* of the Gospel and they will be *faithful in their relation to the Lord and to men.* The genuine Christian will be characterized by *continuing to exercise faith* in Christ, by *continuing to adhere to the truth* of the Gospel and by *continuing to faithfully walk* according to the Gospel. Lack of evidence in any one of these three areas raises the question: Is the person really saved?

First, believers who continue in the faith thereby show that they are those "having been grounded" (τεθεμελιωμενοι), *who have been built* upon the true foundation, and *who have genuinely rested* upon the unmovable footing - the Blood of Christ. The Greek uses *a perfect participle in* the nominative case here, and it is most fully translated, *those who have been and continue to be grounded.*

The perfect tense speaks of an action which *has taken place,* the results of which *continue in full effect.* The thought here is that if they had been reconciled to God through Christ's death at a given point of time in the past, they *would continue in this reconciled state,* and will be presented holy, blameless, and irreproachable before God the Father. Again we emphasize, their continuance in the faith has *nothing to do with gaining their salvation,* but is only *a mark of identification,* it *separates the possessors* from the professors.

Second, believers who continue in the faith thereby reveal that they are in a settled state. The word translated "settled" (εδραιοι) has the basic idea of *seated;* hence to be *firmly fixed, steadfast,* and

established. Paul uses it in First Corinthians 7:37, with reference to the person who is settled, fixed, and firm in that which he has determined in his heart. Likewise, he exhorts all the Corinthians to be settled ones, and as such, to be always abounding in the work of the Lord (1 Cor. 15:58).

Their continuance in the faith proves that they are settled, established, and solid in the truth of the Gospel. As those who are snugly seated with Christ, on the basis of His sacrificial work, believers will stand before God the Father as holy, blameless, and irreproachable (cf. Eph. 2:6).

Third, believers who continue in the faith show by it that they are not being moved from the hope of the Gospel. The Greek words translated "not being moved" (μη μετακινουμενοι) are derived from the three words *"*μετα*,"* and *"*κινεω*"* which have the basic idea of *not being moved in the sense of changing location, moving away, or transferring.*

This word is a present *passive* participle, which indicates that Paul was concerned lest they be moved away by an outside source, namely, Satan working through the false teachers. The *present* tense suggests that this moving away and transferring from the hope of the Gospel might be *an insidious gradual thing.* Continuously, little by little, Paul could see Satan subtly endeavoring to control them; however, his devices would not succeed with true believers, the elect, for they would *continue in the faith.*

What is the hope of the Gospel which the Colossians had previously heard about through Epaphras and others? First, on the basis of verse five, it was a hope which focused on *something that is laid up in heaven* for all believers. Second, it was *a prominent part of the truth* of the Gospel that was commonly proclaimed by the Apostle Paul. Third, it promises each believer *a portion of the inheritance of the saints* in the light (Col. 1:12). Fourth, it is a hope of *future glory* based on the fact that Christ is in believers (Col. 1:27). Fifth, when Christ is manifested we will be manifested *with Him in glory* (Col. 3:4). Sixth, the Lord is going to give to believers *a reward,* the inheritance (Col. 3:24).

Seventh, according to the Book of Philippians, which speaks of the same hope, there was the constant *expectation that Christ would come* again out of heaven (Phil. 3:20). Eighth, the bodies of believers

will be *conformed to the body of Christ,* bodies designed for existence in glory (Phil. 3:21).

With respect to the Gospel, of which the message of hope was a very significant part, Paul says that it was "preached in all creation under heaven." The Greek word translated "preached" *(*κηρυχθεντος*)* is in the aorist tense and the passive voice, which implies that it had already been preached or proclaimed in all creation at the time Paul is writing. The phrase "in all creation" *(*εν παση κτισει*)* is probably best understood as being in the locative case, i.e., it was preached *in the sphere of* or *in the midst of* all creation.

To interpret and translate this *to every creature* is inconsistent with the known historical facts. Also, if this were the intended meaning, we would expect the same grammatical construction as in Mark 16:15, "to every creature" *(*παση τη κτισει*).* In writing to the Romans Paul refers to the limits to which he had preached the Gospel, namely, as far north as Illyricum (Rom. 15:19). He had wanted to get as far west as Spain (cf. Rom. 15:24, 28); however we have no record of him getting there.

Paul now affirms the fact that he was made a minister of the Gospel. It appears to us that the verb *"*εγενομην*"* must be given *a passive meaning* in this phrase. To hold that it is a middle voice, and to translate it accordingly, means that Paul made himself a minister of the Gospel, which is foreign to his historical background and other affirmations.

Contrary to his own will Paul had been made a minister of the Gospel (cf. Acts 9:13-16; Rom. 1:1; 1 Cor. 1:1; Gal. 1:1, 15-16; Eph. 3:1-5). The correct grammatical appraisal of the form of this word must allow it to have both a middle (cf. 1 Cor. 2:3; 9:15) and a passive meaning (cf. Heb. 2:2; 11:7). Paul was made a minister of the *Gospel of the Grace of God* (cf. Acts 20:24), the *Gospel for this present Church age,* which declares that believers will be holy, blameless, and irreproachable *solely on the basis of Jesus Christ's meritorious death.*

24. ***"Now I rejoice in the sufferings for you, and I fill up the things lacking of the afflictions of Christ in my flesh for the sake of his body, which is the church,"***

Paul now tells them that he rejoices in all the sufferings involved

in teaching and preaching the Gospel to them. The Greek says I rejoice in "the sufferings" *(τοις παθημασιν),* which includes the sufferings of Paul, Epaphras, and the others who were ministering to the Colossians (cf. 4:12-13). Having referred to all the suffering that had been entailed in teaching them the Gospel, Paul now deals with his own attitude toward suffering and how he interprets it in relation to the Body of Christ, the Church. As one who had been made a minister of the Gospel, Paul was destined to suffer (cf. Acts 9:16), and he looked at this suffering as having positive value in completing the Body of Christ.

He says "I fill up" *(αντανα πληρω)* and complete "the things lacking" *(τα υστερηματα),* i.e., that which is *wanting* and *needed* of the afflictions of Christ. First, observe that Paul's use of the word *"αντι"* prefixed to the Greek word *"αναπληρω"* suggests the idea of filling up and completing *in the place of* or *instead of* Christ. He was assuming a role of suffering as he was establishing and nurturing the Church. Even as Christ had *perfectly completed His vicarious sufferings* as the basis on which the Church is built (cf. Eph. 1:7; 2:13, 20); likewise Paul is suffering as he struggles to meet the *need of making known the mystery,* truth regarding the Body of Christ, the Church (cf. Eph. 3:1-2; 6:19-20; Cal. 4:3).

Second, the Greek word translated *things lacking* is plural. This includes all that is involved in planting, developing, nurturing, instructing, teaching, and shepherding the New Testament churches, which represented the Body of Christ in physical manifestation. Third, keep in mind that Paul's suffering was in his flesh, which would include both physical suffering as well as mental and emotional suffering and distress (cf. 2 Cor. 11:24, 28).

Paul makes it clear that "the afflictions" *(των θλιψεων), pressures,* and *distressing circumstances* he is suffering are *on behalf of Christ's Body,* the Church. Jesus Christ's afflictions were wholly and totally as our *sin substitute;* the Just suffering for the unjust that we might have *forgiveness of sins* and be clothed in His *righteousness* (cf. Isa. 53:4-6; 2 Cor. 5:21). The afflictions and sufferings which Jesus Christ our Sin-bearer bore were *unique to Him, He alone could bear them,* no man would or could have shared them, and even God the Father had to *forsake* Him during those lonely hours on Calvary (cf. Matt. 27:46).

It is most important that we *don't confuse* the phrase "the

afflictions of Christ" *(*των θλιψεως του χριστου*)* with the Cross and what preceded it. This phrase relates *only* to the afflictions involved in the establishing and continuing of the *Body of Christ, the Church!*

25. ***"of which I was made a minister according to the dispensation of God which was given to me for you, to fulfill the Word of God,"***

Again we have the verb "I was made" *(*εγενομην*), w*hich we have already pointed out may have either middle or passive voice significance, depending on the context in which it is used, and in this context it obviously has passive significance as Paul states that the *Lord had made* him a minister of the Church. Even as Paul previously affirmed that the Lord had made him a minister of the Gospel (1:23; Eph. 3:6-7); likewise he now affirms that the Lord had also made him *a minister of the Church.* This is the only time Paul refers to himself as a minister of the Church. However he does refer to himself as a minister of the new covenant (cf. 2 Cor. 3:6), as a minister of God (cf. 2 Cor. 6:4), a minister of righteousness (2 Cor. 11:15), and lie commonly refers to his associates as ministers of Christ (cf. Eph. 6:21; Col. 1:7; 1 Tim. 4:6).

According to Paul's own words he was made a minister of the Church *according to the dispensation of God* which was given to him. The Greek word translated "dispensation" (οικονομιαν) is derived from the two words "οικος" and *"*νεμω*"* and has the basic idea of the *management of a household;* hence *a Divine arrangement, an administration, governing truth,* and *a plan.* What Paul is telling us here is that according to God's Divine arrangement and administration, which was given to him, he was made a minister of the Body of Christ, the Church (cf. Eph. 3:2, 7).

Now let us consider the fact that this dispensation of God was *given to the Apostle Paul.* In writing to the Corinthians Paul affirms that he has been *trusted with a dispensation,* i.e., with a new Divine administration (I Cor. 9:17). He tells the Ephesians that the *dispensation of the grace of God has been given to him* (Eph. 3:2). Paul was given the special *grace of bringing to light the dispensation of the mystery* (Eph. 3:8-9).

This new Divine administration given to Paul pertained to *a new way in which the Lord would relate to His people.* Previously the Lord had related to His people through the Law of Moses - a legal

relationship. Now the Lord was going to relate to His people through the Church - *a grace relationship.* Paul was made the *chief custodian of the truth pertaining to this new Divine administration;* the specifics of it are to be found primarily in his epistles (cf. Rom. 2:16; 16:25-26; 1 Cor. 12:12-26).

As Paul writes to the Colossians he says that the dispensation of God was given to him "for you" (εις υμας). Taking this literally it would mean that the truth relating to the Divine administration, the Church, was for *all those* in the local assemblies.

Sometimes Paul speaks as though it was more particularly for the Gentiles (cf. Eph. 3:1, 8). However, even though it throws the door wide open for the Gentiles to come to the Lord (cf. Eph. 3:6); it also lays before the Jews a new way of mercy to approach the Lord (cf. Rom. 11:31-32). During the present age of grace, when God is relating to men through the Divine administration of the Church, there is no difference *between the Jews and Gentiles,* all are totally dependent upon the mercy and *grace of God* for their salvation (cf. Rom. 9:11, 16).

Lastly, Paul says that his unique ministry was to fulfill the word of God. The Greek word translated "fulfill" *(πληρωσαι)* conveys the idea of *making full, to fill,* or *to fill up.* We feel that this statement is open to two possible interpretations. First, the truth of the dispensation of God mentioned here is the *Word of God for the Church,* and Paul's ministry was to *make it fully known,* to make all men see this Church truth (cf. Eph. 3:9). Whether or not this is the emphasis of this particular statement, one thing is certain: *this was Paul's consuming burden* (cf. Eph. 3:8-13; 2 Tim. 4:6-7).

Second, the dispensation of God is the final revelation of truth that God has made, and it fills and *completes the canon* of the Word of God. It is God's final message pertaining to the Body of Christ, the Church, as to *what it is* and *how we are to live* as members of it (cf. Eph. 1:22-23; 4:1-6:20). Regardless of which emphasis we give this passage, the dispensation of God, the Divine arrangement of the Church, is the *last program* and purpose God has disclosed to men, and we are to *sacrificially give of all that we are and have to make it fully known!*

26. ***"the mystery which has been hidden from the ages and from the generations, but now was manifested to his saints,"***

The phrase *the Word of God* and *the mystery* are in apposition; the Word of God is the mystery and the mystery is the word of God. The Greek word translated "mystery" *(μυστηριον)* has the basic idea of that which is a *secret, hidden,* or *concealed.*

This word is used *twenty-eight times* in the New Testament. It is used three times in the Synoptic Gospels of Matthew, Mark, and Luke; all three apparently record the same utterance, which means that Jesus used this word only once. The Apostle John uses it four times in the Book of Revelation. *The Apostle Paul uses it twenty one times* in six of his epistles: Romans, First Corinthians, Ephesians, Colossians, Second Thessalonians, and First Timothy. *Eighteen times Paul uses it with reference to a distinct body of truth* revealed unto him. Three times Paul uses it with the basic meaning of a secret.

In the light of the fact that Paul's preponderant usage is with reference to a distinct body of truth, it behooves us to examine some of the characteristics of this truth. The first thing we observe on the basis of the meaning of the word *"μυστηριον"* is that prior to being revealed *this truth was kept secret.* This thought is reinforced in this context by the additional statement, *having been hidden* from previous ages and generations. Prior to the Apostle Paul no *one* in any age nor in any generation knew anything about the mystery; during this time it was a secret in the mind of the Godhead. The fact that the mystery had been kept a secret right up to Paul's time is adequately corroborated in his epistles (cf. Rom. 16:25; 1 Cor. 2:7-9; Eph. 3:5, 9).

Second, Paul uses the word "now" *(νυν)* to focus on a pivotal point in time. Prior to the time represented by the word "now" the mystery was *a secret in God;* at the beginning of the *now-time* there began a gradual unfolding of the truth of the mystery. Over a period of some fifteen to twenty-five years the Lord was *progressively revealing* to the Apostle Paul the truth that constitutes the mystery (cf. Acts 26:16; 2 Cor. 12:1, 7; and Acts 20:20, 27 with Eph. 3:3-4). In writing to the Romans regarding the mystery Paul says, "and having been manifested now..." (Rom. 16:26). As Paul writes to the Ephesians about the mystery, he says, "which to other generations was not made known to the sons of men as it has now been revealed..." (Eph. 3:5).

There was a time when God dealt with men through the

administration of the Law; during this time the mystery was a perfectly guarded secret in God. When the nation of Israel rejected God's prophetic program, the King and His Kingdom, God revealed to Paul, and through the New Testament apostles and prophets, the truth of the mystery (cf. Acts 7:54-59; Eph. 3:5).

We have been emphasizing the fact that the mystery was revealed to the Apostle Paul; however, here Paul himself says that it was *manifested to His saints.* How do we resolve this seeming contradiction? Let us consider *the evidence* that indicates the mystery was indeed revealed unto Paul.

First, in the immediately preceding verse Paul says that he was made a minister of the Church, and that the dispensation of God was *given to him,* which is mystery truth pertaining to God's administration, the Church. Second, Paul refers to the revealed truth of the mystery as being *his gospel,* i.e., in the first person, *"my (μου) Gospel,"* that which belonged to him (Rom. 2:16). Third, Paul speaks of the preaching of Jesus Christ according to the revelation of the mystery as being his gospel, i.e., "my *(μου) Gospel"* (Rom. 16:25).

Fourth, no human being made any contribution to Paul's Gospel, it was given to him exclusively *through revelation of Jesus Christ* (Gal. 1:11-12). Paul says that God was the one who revealed His Son "in me" *(εν εμοι)* in order that I might preach Him among the Gentiles (Gal. 1:16). Observe two things: (1) this revelation of the Son was *distinct to Paul, in him,* and (2) to preach Him among the Gentiles definitely *ties this with the mystery* (Eph. 3:6). In Galatians Paul maintains that his Gospel was a distinct revelation from the Lord that embraced the Gentiles (cf. 2:7-9; 3:26-28; 6:15).

Thus we see on the one hand that the mystery, the comprehensive truth of Christ and His Church, was *directly* made known to Paul (cf. Eph. 3:2-3, 8-9; further it was the distinct *message Timothy was to teach,* cf. 2 Tim. 1:13-14; 2:2; 3:10, 14). On the other hand we see that the mystery Gospel given to Paul was *distributed and made known* through the New Testament apostles, prophets, and saints (cf. Rom. 16:26; Eph. 3:5-6; Acts 10:34-36; 11:12, 18).

The irrefutable evidence is that the *mystery was* revealed to the Apostle Paul! The statement, "but now was manifested to his saints," must be understood in the light of the immediate context. Paul has just affirmed that the *mystery was hidden* from previous ages and

"generations" *(γενεων), progeny, offspring, and peoples.* The emphasis is that *no human being* previously knew about the mystery, but now "it was manifested" (εφανερωθη), *made visible, disclosed,* and *opened up* to His saints, holy ones.

The contrast here is between *all people who lived previously,* from whom the mystery was totally hidden, and the *now-people of God,* the saints, to whom it has been disclosed. This disclosure to the saints has been primarily *through the Apostle Paul* (Eph. 3:2-4)

27. ***"to whom God willed to make known what the rich glory of this mystery is among the Gentiles, which is Christ in you, the hope of glory;"***

In the previous verse Paul declared that the mystery was manifested to the saints. With reference to these saints he says that it was God's will to make known to them a certain thing about the mystery. The Greek word translated "willed" (ηθελησεν) means to exercise the will in the sense of positive *determination* (cf. 1 Cor. 12:18; 15:38; Philemon 14), or it may have a weaker idea of *inclination,* in which case it would be translated to wish or want (cf. Rom. 1:13; 1 Cor. 7:7; Gal. 3:2).

When we look at our sovereign God effecting a given thing apart from man, there is *no distinction* between His inclination and determination; that which He is inclined or wants to do He does. On the other hand, when what God does is dependent upon the obedience of man, we then have *a conditional* element. In such contexts the thought is more accurately expressed by the English words *wish, want,* or *desire* (cf. 1 Tim. 2:4; God's saving men is contingent on their election and exercising faith).

It appears to us that there is a certain degree of human contingency involved in the carrying out of God's will here. Historically speaking the mystery was manifested to the saints of Paul's day. Furthermore, in the same historical setting God willed to make known to these saints just what the rich glory of this mystery is *in* or *among* the Gentiles. The thing that God willed and wanted them to know was the *quality* and *richness* of the glory that belonged to the mystery. Putting it in another way, God's will for them was to know something that was really important, namely, the *exceeding rich glory of the mystery.*

Observe further that this surpassing rich glory of the mystery is *among the Gentiles.* Previously the Gentiles were spiritually bankrupt in trespasses and sins; against this background the truth of the mystery was exceedingly glorious. This is the first time that the Gentiles had heard the glorious message of the mystery - that they could become *fellow-heirs, fellow-body-members,* and *fellow-partakers* of the Holy Spirit in Jesus Christ (cf. Eph. 3:6).

Furthermore, the surpassing rich glory of the mystery promised both Gentiles and Jews that Christ would *spiritually reside in them.* The unsaved pagan Gentiles were undoubtedly acquainted with evil spirits indwelling them, and the thought of the Son of God living in them certainly must have been glorious news to them!

The concept of Christ dwelling in believers is *effected* through the indwelling Holy Spirit. After Jesus promised His disciples that the Holy Spirit would be in them, then He proceeds to tell them that He would come and make His abode with them (cf. John 14:17, 23), i.e., in conjunction with the indwelling Holy Spirit. This same inter-related concept of the indwelling Spirit and the indwelling Christ is set forth in the Book of Romans (cf. Rom. 8:9-10). Again, in Ephesians the indwelling Spirit and indwelling Christ are associated; the latter dwells in the hearts of believers through faith (Eph. 3:16-17).

The center and the heart of glorious mystery truth is the fact that Christ is *in* believers, and this is the *basis* for the hope of glory. According to Romans 8:30, the ultimate thing our sovereign God does for us is that of *glorifying us* together with Christ. According to Philippians 3:21, our bodies will be conformed to the body of His glory, i.e., we will be given glorified bodies like His for our eternal existence with Him. The fact that Christ is in us now, the fact that we belong to Him and are intimately related to Him now, this assures us of future glorification with Him.

Our position of Christ in us is permanent, we are sealed in this position by the Holy Spirit unto the time of redemption, namely, when our physical bodies will be transformed to be like His glorious body (Eph. 1:13-14; 2 Cor. 1:22). We can rest assured that if God has sovereignly put Christ in us, He will also sovereignly glorify us with Christ! This is the hope of the Gospel of the mystery.

28. ***"whom we proclaim admonishing every man and teaching every man in all wisdom, that we might present every man***

perfect in Christ;"

Having told them that Christ is in them and that this truth is the basis for their hope of glory with Him, Paul now goes on to explain the *kind* of ministry he had and its *purpose.* Speaking of Christ, he says, He is the one we "proclaim" (καταγγελλομεν). This word may have the basic meaning of *distributing a message,* hence the idea of *announcing, making known,* and *publishing.* Its use in some passages suggests that it might be well translated to *talk about, communicate,* or a *more casual conversational sharing of truth* (cf. Acts 16:17, 21; Rom. 1:8; 1 Cor. 2:1; Phil. 1:17-18). The present tense suggests that Paul was *continuously talking about* and *announcing* Christ, using the method suitable for the circumstances. The key thing to see here is that *Paul's message centered in the Person of Jesus Christ* - he continuously talked about Him (cf. Acts 17:3; 1 Cor. 11:26).

As Paul and his associates continuously communicated Christ to others they were admonishing every man. The word translated "admonishing" *(*νουθετουντες*)* is derived from the two Greek words "νους" and *"*τιθημι*"* and literally means *to place or put in the mind;* it conveys the idea of *reminding and warning.* This word is a present participle in this verse which implies that Paul and those with him were *continuously warning* every believer of the dire consequences of not obeying this truth for the Church.

Three times the singular phrase *every man* is used in this verse, emphasizing that Paul is talking about a personal one-to-one ministry here. This word is commonly used in a more *personal counseling* type ministry. At Ephesus Paul admonished each one (Acts 20:31); at Thessalonica the one who disobeyed the Word was to be personally admonished as a brother (2 Thess. 3:14-15).

Next, Paul was continuously involved (present tense) in teaching every man in all wisdom. Paul describes the ideal ministry in the local assembly as one of both mutual *teaching* and *admonishing* (3:16); likewise here he both taught and admonished in his more personal ministry.

The *most important thing* to note here is *what Paul* was teaching, the *content* of his teaching, it was in the sphere of *all wisdom.* The word "wisdom" here is in the singular and it refers to a given body of truth, *the mystery,* which is the subject of this context.

As one studies Paul's epistles it is obvious that he commonly uses the word "wisdom" *(σοφια)* almost synonymously with the mystery (cf. 1 Cor. 2:1, 6-7; Eph. 1:8-9; 3:9-10). The truth contained in the mystery is a special revelation of truth regarding the Body of Christ, the Church, and as such is the *wisdom we are to specialize in teaching* today! It gives believers the *data necessary* for living pleasingly to God in this Church age!

Paul's purpose in proclaiming Christ and admonishing and teaching in all wisdom was that he and his co-laborers might *present every man perfect in Christ.* The word translated "present" *(παραστησωμεν)* is the same word as used in verse 22, where we pointed out that it literally meant to *stand beside, to place beside,* or *to position one before or in the presence of another.* Paul's common use of this word makes it clear that his purpose is to present every man perfect in Christ *before* or *in the presence of God* the Father (cf. Rom. 6:13; 2 Tim. 2:15).

The Greek word translated "perfect" (τελειον) means *to have brought to completion, one who is fully developed,* or *to be mature.* Through admonishing and teaching the truth of the mystery Paul sought to produce spiritual development, maturity, and perfection in Christ before God the Father (Rom. 16:25).

29. ***"unto which end I also labor, striving according to his energy, which powerfully energizes in me."***

The foregoing context indicates that through admonishing and teaching Paul was endeavoring to present every man perfect in Christ. This was the end unto which Paul "labored" (κοπιαω), *toiled,* and *gave himself until he was tired and weary.* Paul also says that he was "striving" (αγωνιζομενος), *struggling,* and *contending.* Our English word *agonize* is derived from this Greek word. The use of the present tense suggests that Paul was *continuously* laboring and striving to teach every man all the wisdom of the mystery, the *truth for the Church,* that he might present every man perfect and mature in Christ (cf. 1 Cor. 2:6-7).

Paul's use of the word "αγωνιζομενος" suggests that lie considered himself as one *contending and striving against Satan* as he taught the truth of the mystery, for the proclamation of this truth is *God's will* for today, and Satan tried to stop it by causing Paul's

imprisonment (cf. Eph. 6:11-12; 19-20; Col. 4:3).

As Paul labored and struggled to present every believer perfect in Christ through the teaching of the mystery, he was not depending upon his own human ingenuity and strength, but upon the working and power of God. He says that his striving was according to God's "energy" *(ενεργειαν), efficacy,* and *working.* The present participles make it clear that God was the one who continuously energized and worked powerfully in Paul.

The words translated "powerfully'" are literally "in power" (εν δυναμει). This obviously refers to God the Holy Spirit, for when we have the power of God transmitted to men, it is accomplished through the Holy Spirit (cf. Rom. 15:13, 19; Eph. 3:16-20). In the sphere of the Holy Spirit, or by means of the Holy Spirit, God energized in Paul enabling him to faithfully teach all the wisdom contained in the mystery to every person. It is very important to observe that *the message was all the wisdom of the mystery,* the *object* was that every man might be *perfect in Christ,* and the *means* was by the power of the Holy Spirit.

CHAPTER 2

1. ***"For I want you to know how great a striving I have for you, and for those in Laodicea, and for as many as have not seen my face in the flesh,"***

In the previous verse Paul wrote about his striving for *all men in general,* whereas here he is striving on behalf of *three specific groups* of believers, namely, those in Colossae, Laodicea, and those in the area who had never seen him. He "wants" (θελω), *wishes,* and *desires* them to know the extent of his strivings and struggles on their behalf *(υπερ υμων).* The extent to which Paul labored and suffered to get the Gospel to them reveals how *important* the Gospel was to him and how *imperative* it was that all men have an opportunity to hear it.

Paul wanted them to know that teaching all the wisdom of the mystery was *the most important thing* in his life. He also wanted them to know, through the example of his own agonizing for them, not only how much he loved them, but also how imperative it was for them to likewise strive to teach the Gospel to others.

Paul taught by both *example* and the spoken and written word; however, if these believers were not present to observe his strivings on their behalf, how could they learn by example? Therefore, in this verse, he informs them of what he had gone through and was going through on their behalf (cf. 2 Cor. 1:8-9; 11:22-29).

The base from which Asia was evangelized was apparently Ephesus. Paul carried on both a public and private ministry there for a period of three years (cf. Acts 20:20, 31). We have no record of Paul personally establishing any of the other Asian churches. It is possible that Timothy and others of Paul's co-laborers may have aided in starting some of these churches; however, we have no record of this.

How many Asian churches there were when Paul wrote this letter we do not know, but there were at least two: Colossae and Laodicea (Col. 4:16). As John writes the Book of Revelation some thirty to thirty-five years later he mentions these two churches plus five others. Apparently all these churches were established relatively early, for by the time John wrote Revelation they have certain marks

of apostasy (cf. Rev. 1:4, 11). In the light of the record we have, Paul obviously did not know many of the Asian believers; however, he still wanted them to know that he was struggling on their behalf.

2 ***"that their hearts might be encouraged, having been knit together in love, and unto all the riches of full assurance of understanding, unto a perfect knowledge of the mystery of God, Christ,"***

The purpose of Paul's striving to teach them the truth of the mystery was threefold. First, that the hearts of all the Asian believers might be "encouraged" *(παρακληθωσιν), exhorted* and *comforted.* It appears to us that the English word *encouraged* most accurately expresses the idea being set forth in this context; through the teaching of the truth of the mystery their hearts were exhorted and encouraged.

We need to recognize that the Greek word translated "hearts" (καρδιαι) is often used with a meaning comparable to our English word *mind,* or contains the idea of a *balance between the intellectual and emotional.* In Romans Paul speaks of the heart as *having understanding* (Rom. 1:21), as being *able to believe* (Rom. 10:9-10), and as *being deceived* (Rom. 16:18). Paul's desire for all the Asian Jews was that their hearts might be encouraged, i.e., as a result of intellectually comprehending what Paul was writing to them that they might be mentally and emotionally encouraged.

Second, Paul's purpose of striving to teach them the truth of the mystery was, as those who had been knit together in love, that they might *know all the riches of full assurance* that belongs to understanding. The fact of "having been knit together in love" *(συμβιβασθεντες),* expressed by the aorist tense in the passive voice, refers to the work the Holy Spirit accomplishes in their lives (cf. Gal 5:22).

Being knit together, brought together, and united together in love is *a prerequisite* to having the full assurance that comes from understanding. Before one can fully understand the truth of the mystery, and as a result enjoy the riches of being fully assured in the truth for the Church today, he *must* be united together with fellow-believers in love. The Greek word for "full assurance" *(πληροφοριας)* conveys the idea of *full conviction,* of *full persuasion.* As those who are united together with other believers in love, as those who

understand the wisdom of the mystery, *we rejoice in the riches that come from being fully assured, convinced, and persuaded in mystery truth!*

Third, Paul's purpose of striving to teach them the truth for the Church was to the end that they might perfectly know the mystery of God, Christ. Here we have the phrase *the mystery of God,* and the name *Christ, in* apposition with each other. The mystery of God *centers in Christ* as Head over the Body, the Church, and it involves our relation to Him and how we are to live in Him. In Ephesians 1:22, Paul says that God the Father gave Christ the position of *sole Head* over the Church and everything that pertains to it.

3. ***"in whom are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge."***

In the preceding verse we observed that the mystery of God, i.e., the mystery that belonged to God, is *in essence Christ.* This mystery centers in and revolves around Christ; He is the very heart of it! As Paul continues to elaborate on this same subject here he says that all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge are "hidden" (αποκρυφοι), *concealed,* and *stored* in Christ. The primary emphasis here is not that the wisdom and knowledge is hidden away and concealed in Christ, but that it is *stored in Christ, deposited in Christ, and laid away in Christ.*

The other two times that this word is used in the New Testament it has the basic idea of something that is stored away and will be manifested (cf. Mark 4:22; Luke 8:17). We have already been told that the wisdom of the mystery had been revealed (cf. Rom. 16:25-26; Eph. 3:3); therefore we understand the Greek word *"αποκρυφοι"* to mean that the wisdom and knowledge revealed is stored and deposited in the Person of Jesus Christ (cf. 1 Cor. 1:24, 30). Apart from Christ and the wisdom for the Church deposited in Him, we live in total ignorance of God's plan and purpose for the present economy of grace!

Now let us consider the comprehensive statement *all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge.* First, the Greek word translated "treasures" *(θησαυροι)* speaks of *valuables which are laid up, that which is very precious,* or *that which* is *stored up* for the future. The Scriptures closely associate the idea of treasures with the place they are stored. Treasures may be stored on *earth* (Matt. 6:19), in *heaven*

(Matt. 19:20), in earthly bodies (2 Cor. 4:7), and in a country (Heb. 11:26). It is most important that we grasp the fact that the exceedingly valuable treasure of truth for the Church is stored in Christ and is available to us only in conjunction with His Person.

Paul describes the treasures he is speaking of as being *wisdom and knowledge.* He uses the word "wisdom" *(σοφιας)* with reference to both *human wisdom and Divine wisdom.* He speaks of the wisdom of *men* (1 Cor. 2:5), of the *world* (1 Cor. 3:19), of the *flesh* (2 Cor. 1:12), and of *false religions* (Col. 2:20-23). On the other hand, Paul uses the word wisdom to refer to the *body of truth contained in the mystery,* truth which was revealed unto him, and which is now deposited in Christ.

In writing to the Romans he speaks of the depth of the riches of God's wisdom and knowledge (Rom. 11:33). Paul tells the Corinthians that the wisdom he speaks is not of this age, but the wisdom of God in a mystery (1 Cor. 2:6-7). Furthermore, the wisdom of this world is foolishness with God (cf. 1 Cor. 1:20; 3:19). Thus we see that God has stored in Christ *all* the wisdom and knowledge that is essential for this Church age, and it has nothing in common with the wisdom of this world. As believers we *need to get our priorities straight,* and above everything *else, bathe ourselves in the wisdom of the mystery* that is stored in Jesus Christ!

4. ***"This I say, in order that no one might deceive you by persuasive speech."***

Paul had a very definite reason for writing what he did about the truth of the mystery and how all its wisdom and knowledge resides in Jesus Christ. The Colossians and Asian believers were under attack from false teachers who were endeavoring to undermine the truth of the Gospel of God's Grace. Paul warns these believers against anyone who might try to *deceive* them.

The Greek word for "deceive" *(παραλογιζηται)* comes from a combining of two words which literally mean *to count beside, to reckon beside,* or *to consider that which is beside and beyond.* These false teachers were actually *adding to Paul's Gospel* by bringing error in beside and beyond what he had taught. Paul warns the Galatians against this same kind of error, namely, those who would preach "beside" or "beyond" (παρα) that which he preached (Gal. 1:8). This has been one of the most common,

insidious methods used to pervert the Gospel of God's Grace, and we warn you to be on guard against it (cf. Gal. 1:7).

Having considered the *method* the false teachers used to deceive the Asian believers, now let us consider the means by which they tried to accomplish it. The means they employed was "persuasive speech" *(πιθανολογια).* This Greek word is derived from two words and literally means *persuasive words, persuasive speaking,* or *speech.* This is the only time this particular word is used in the New Testament; however, persuasive human wisdom words were commonly used, but rejected by Paul (cf. 1 Cor. 2:2-4).

Thus we see that these false teachers used the deceptive method of adding works here and there to the Gospel of Grace, thereby making it an inconsistent and unworkable hodgepodge (cf. Gal. 2:21; 4:9-11; 5:4). Furthermore, the means the false teachers used then and continue to use today to accomplish their diabolical ends is polished, smooth, persuasive, and humanistically logical arguments, but with Paul we must reject all of these and depend on the power of God (cf. 1 Cor. 2:4-5; 4:19-20).

Paul was aware of the fact that there were false teachers working among the Asian believers. This is what stimulated him to emphasize the truth of the mystery; truth pertaining to Christ and the full assurance they could have if they understood the mystery. Paul points out that everything they need is in Christ; He is the embodiment of the wisdom and knowledge of the mystery. There is no need for them to add anything to the Gospel which they already have; they have everything in Christ and are complete in Him (cf. 2:10). A positive presentation of the wisdom and knowledge of the mystery is the *only sound answer* to false doctrine in this present Church age! It was Paul's answer - it must be our answer!

5. ***"For though I am absent in the flesh, but I am with you in the spirit and rejoicing while beholding your order and the steadfastness of your faith in Christ."***

Paul wrote this epistle while he was in prison in Rome (cf. 4:3); therefore he was absent from them in the flesh, in fact, several hundred miles west. In contrast to his absence in body he was present with them in spirit, i.e., in his human spirit he was in Asia with them rejoicing at what he saw. The Greek phrase "the spirit" *(τω πνευματι)* could be interpreted as the Holy Spirit *and Paul looking*

at himself as being present with them in the Holy Spirit.

From the vantage point of being present with them in Asia Paul was *rejoicing* as he saw their "order" *(*ταξιν*)* in its meetings (cf. I Cor. 14:40). Also, from his vantage point with them, Paul saw the *steadfastness of their faith in* Christ. The Greek word translated "steadfastness" *(*στερεωμα*) denotes that which is solid, firm, and constant.* Their faith in Jesus Christ was solid and firm.

The implication of a solid "faith" *(*πιστεως*)* is that *faithfulness will follow it.* It may well be that as Paul looked upon their faithfulness he visualized behind it their genuine faith in Christ. We can't see faith, but we can see the resultant of faith, namely, faithfulness (1 Cor. 15:2; 2 Cor. 13:5). In summary, Paul was rejoicing because of their *orderly walk* in the Lord and because of their *genuine faith in Jesus Christ.* Solid faith in Christ is the prerequisite to an orderly faithful life.

6. ***"As therefore you received Christ Jesus the Lord, walk in him,"***

Paul, having previously affirmed that Jesus Christ is the summation of the mystery of God and that all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge reside in Him, now goes on to emphasize their need to walk in Him. Before getting into details pertaining to their daily walk with Christ, Paul goes back to the basic issue of their relationship to Jesus Christ. Do they truly know Him as their Saviour? Have they received the Person of Jesus Christ as their Lord?

The word translated "received" (παραλαβετε) is derived from two Greek words and literally means to take to one's side, to receive for one's self; hence the idea of taking or receiving as *a possession.* If they have received Christ Jesus the Lord, i.e., if they *possess Him* as *their Lord,* as the one who owns them; then they are to live pleasing to Him. Observe that the word "received" *(*παραλαβετε*)* is in the *aorist* tense; it speaks of an *instantaneous completed transaction;* one either possesses Christ as his Lord or he doesn't.

Paul never tried to tell anyone who had not received Christ how to live. However, on the other hand, the major theme of his epistles is *what* believers are to believe and how they are to live. The person who possesses Jesus Christ as his Lord is in a slave-master relation to Him and is to explicitly *obey* Him in all things (cf. Eph. 6:9). When Paul recognized Jesus as Lord on the Damascus Road, he

immediately said, *"What shall I do, Lord?"* thereby acknowledging his subservient relation to Christ, the one who was now his Lord (Acts. 22:10). We who possess Jesus Christ as our Lord are to "walk" *(περιπατειτε) in Him.*

The Greek word translated "walk" literally means to *walk around, to walk about;* hence it involves all that we do, our total life-style. The locative case indicates that our walk, living, and life-style are to be *in the sphere of Christ* our Lord. As we live, move and have our being we are to be encompassed by the Living Christ in our thinking, speaking, emotional attitudes, and actions.

Since all the treasures of the wisdom and knowledge of the mystery are stored in Him, and we are in Him, it follows that our walk is to be governed by this truth which is *objectively recorded* in the Word of God and *subjectively experienced* in our in-Christ relationship. Of course, we recognize that this surpassing-knowledge in-Christ relationship is spiritually possible through the indwelling Holy Spirit (cf. John 14:17; Rom. 8:9-11).

7. ***"having been rooted and being built up in him and being established in the faith, even as you were taught, abounding in thanksgiving."***

As we keep this verse in context with the previous verse, the thought is that believers are to walk in Christ as those who "have been rooted" *(ερριζωμενοι),* i.e., as those *who are fixed, firm,* and *unmovable* like a deeply rooted tree (cf. Matt. 3:10). It is exceedingly important that we note that this participle is in the *perfect tense,* which means that *at a given point of time* in the past they were rooted, i.e., they received Christ, and the results of this transaction *continue in full effect.* As those who have been rooted they *continue to be rooted.* As those who have received Christ they *continue to possess Christ!* They are to walk in Christ as those who were genuinely rooted new creatures in Him (cf. 2 Cor. 5:17). The fact that they do walk in Christ is evidence of their new creature status.

It is also important to observe that the Greek word for "rooted" *(ερριζωμενοι)* is in the *passive voice.* This means that one other than themselves rooted them, i.e., put down their roots in Christ, which cannot be torn up (cf. Rom. 8:35-39). According to the truth of the mystery God's sovereign purpose has rooted all true believers in Christ, this rooting process goes back to the time before the earth

was created (cf. Eph. 1:4), and these roots will firmly hold through the accomplishment of God's eternal purpose, namely, our glorification together with Christ (cf. Rom. 8:28-30). In summary, God is the one who *roots* believers, God is the one who causes the roots to *hold firm,* and God the Holy Spirit is the empowering one who *enables* those who have been rooted *to walk in Christ.*

As we have already seen, the first thing that a person needs is to be *rooted in Christ.* The next thing a person needs is to be *built up in Christ.* The Greek word translated "being built up" (εποικοδομουμενοι) comes from a combination of three words which literally mean to *build or construct upon.* The implication of this word is that a foundation has already been laid, which in this verse is the picture of a firmly rooted tree, which depicts believers firmly rooted in Christ. This word is a participle in the *present tense,* which indicates that building upon the fixed root-foundation is *a continuous process,* i.e., we must continually be involved in it day by day and year by year.

Furthermore, the *passive voice* used here makes it clear that the outside agent, God the Holy Spirit, is the one doing this building. The Greek language used here totally excludes the idea of humanistic self-improvement; the passive voice is unmistakable - this is a spiritual building process that is *produced by God the Holy Spirit* through the use of the *Word of God.* Again we emphasize, the Holy Spirit *uses the truth of the mystery* as He daily builds the lives of believers who are walking in Christ.

Thus far we have observed that believers who have been rooted in Christ are to walk in Him, they are to continuously be built up by the Holy Spirit, and now we note that they are to *continuously be established in the faith.* The Greek word translated "established" *(*βεβαιουμενοι*)* has the meaning of *making firm, making stable,* or *strengthening* in the faith. The use of the present tense and passive voice indicates that God the Holy Spirit is continuously involved in making believers firm and stable in the faith, i.e., in the truth that constitutes the Gospel, even as it had been taught by Paul through Epaphras and others (cf. Col. 1:7; 4:12).

In the light of the preceding context we would emphasize that the wisdom and knowledge of the mystery is the sum and substance of *the faith,* the body of doctrine for the Church today. Paul tells the

Romans that his Gospel, the preaching of Jesus Christ according to the revelation of the mystery, is that which "establishes" *(στηριξαι)* - *sets fast, settles,* and *confirms* (Rom. 16:25). Paul is specific about what he means by the faith, namely, that which they had been taught, that which he taught, and that which he told Timothy to teach (cf. 2 Tim. 1:12-14; 2:2).

The fourth thing Paul adds to this series is thanksgiving. Their lives are to be characterized by continuously abounding in thanksgiving. The Greek word for "abounding" *(περισσευοντες)* conveys the idea of *going over and above,* of *going beyond* that which is required. The three previous participles were all in the passive voice; the emphasis was on what *God had and was doing* in the lives of these believers. The participle *abounding* is in the present tense and the active voice, which means that the *believers are the actors* here.

In response for all that God has done for them, having rooted them in Christ, continuously building them up and continuously establishing them in the truth of the Gospel, they are to *continuously abound in thanksgiving and* gratitude to God. Paul affirms the same attitude in Ephesians 5:20, where he says, "continuously giving thanks all the time for all things in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ to God even the Father."

8. ***"See to it that no one shall make a prey of you through philosophy and empty deceit, according to the traditions of men, according to the rudiments of the world, and not according to Christ;"***

Paul constantly has on his mind the fact that false teachers are working among the Colossians; therefore he keeps warning them against the various forms that this false teaching might take. They are to "see to it" (βλεπετε), *take heed,* and *be on guard* against those who would make a prey of them. The Greek word translated "make a prey of" (συλαγωγων) is derived from two Greek words, and it literally means *to lead away as prey, to take one a captive,* or *to carry off as spoil.*

Paul sees philosophy as their means of accomplishing this, i.e., subtly stirring them up to love human wisdom and speculative gnostic philosophy. Gnosticism, which emphasized that emancipation from matter came through knowledge, was undoubtedly the destructive

philosophy that Paul had in mind. It is also obvious that the Apostle John had this same type of error in mind as he wrote his first epistle.

Another means that these false teachers would use to make a prey of the Colossians was "empty deceit" (κενης απατης). The word for "empty" means that which is *nothing, void, vain,* and *hollow.* The Greek word for "deceit" means deceitfulness, delusion, or to beguile. Paul uses these two words together to describe what the false teachers offered, and in the final analysis, it boiled down to *nothing.* Those who followed their teaching, with its lofty promises, ended up being deceived and deluded with a hollow nothingness! We can not be certain whether Paul used this phrase to describe the unsatisfying emptiness of philosophy, and its inability to meet man's spiritual need, or whether it refers to additional deceptive religio-philosophical promises. In either case, the sum total added up to a deceptive pie-in-the-sky delusion, a big *zero, nothing.*

With regard to the philosophy and empty deceit being foisted upon the Colossians, Paul says that it is *according to the traditions of men.* The word translated "traditions" *(παραδοσιν)* is derived from two Greek words and literally means to *give beside,* to *give over,* or to hand down. This was usually done orally and also through writing. It represents that which the natural mind of man, in its fallen state, has accumulated in the process of time. Many of the Jews of Jesus' day were more meticulous about keeping the traditions of men than the commandments of God (Mark 7:8-13). Paul himself knew what it was to be engulfed in the traditions of men, and then to be freed from them, and to be controlled only by the inspired Word of God (cf. Gal. 1:14).

Furthermore, with regard to the philosophy and empty deceit at Colossae, Paul says that it was *according to the rudiments of the world.* The Greek word translated "rudiments" (στοιχεια) conveys the idea of basic physical elements, first principles, or basic mundane elements associated with a religious system. Paul seems to use it with reference to basic aspects of the Mosaic Law at times (cf. Gal. 4:3; 9-10). It appears to us that Paul may well have in mind here certain legal aspects of the Mosaic Law, such as circumcision, which the Judaizers were trying to superimpose upon the Colossian and Asian believers.

With regard to the false teaching at Colossae, which involved

philosophy and empty deceit, which were based upon human traditions and worldly rudiments, Paul says that they are *not according to Christ.* The word translated "according to" (κατα) used with the accusative case, has the meaning *conform to, agree with,* or *to be in harmony with.* When used with the negative, as we have it here, the thought is that *nothing* the false teachers are doing conforms to, agrees with, or harmonizes with Christ, i.e., both their message and methods *are not in accord* with what Christ wants said and done.

We have a clear mandate in the New Testament that we are to teach the *Gospel of the Grace of God,* which involves the truth and wisdom of the mystery, the relationship between Christ and His Church (cf. Acts 20:24; 1 Cor. 15:1-4; Eph. 3:2-9). Furthermore, we have explicit orders as to the *method* we are to use, we are not to become involved in philosophy and deceptive schemes, but we are *to teach the Word of God* literally as it is in season and out of season (cf. 2 Tim. 2:2; 4:2).

9. "because in him dwells all the fullness of the Godhead bodily,"

Paul's answer to what the false teachers are teaching is *Christ.* They need to know exactly *who He* is; that He is God who came down to men in human form. Paul begins this verse with the Greek word "οτι" which is most commonly translated *because.* The implication is that the false teachers were teaching that which was very contrary to what Paul has to say about Christ. Paul is literally saying to them that you are wrong, because all the fullness of the Godhead bodily dwells in Him. The Greek word translated "dwells" (κατοικει) means to *live in* or *make its home in.*

Paul has already made a similar statement to this one in Colossians 1:19, where he says, "because He was pleased for all the fullness to dwell in Him." That which Paul adds in this verse, namely, "of the Godhead bodily," may be implied in the earlier verse. The phrase translated "all the fullness" *(παν το πληρωμα)* is also used in Ephesians 3:19, where we may have the same thought, namely, that believers might be filled unto *all the fullness of God.*

The only three times the phrase "all the fullness" *(παν το πληρωμα)* is used in the New Testament is in conjunction

with God, Christ, and believers. The use of the Greek word *"παν,"* translated *all,* makes this an all-inclusive comprehensive statement. It seems to force us to acknowledge, at least in a sense, that *total deity* inhabits the resurrection body of Christ, i.e., that the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, in a manner beyond our comprehension, occupy His present body.

This same truth is substantiated by the Apostle John, namely, the mobility of the Trinity to dwell in believers here on earth. John quotes Jesus as telling His disciples that the Holy Spirit "abides with you, and shall be in you" (John 14:17), and a little later in the same context Jesus continues to say, "If anyone loves me he will keep my word, and my Father will love him, and we will come to him and we will *make our abode with* (παρα) *him"* (John 14:23).

It is important to observe that Jesus, having set forth the fact that the *Holy Spirit would be in the believer,* proceeds to add that we, the Father and Son, will make our abode "with" *(παρα),* i.e., *beside, together with the believer.* Thus we see that when you posit the fact of the Holy Spirit *in believers;* then the presence of God the Father and the Son *with believers* becomes a reality!

In our immediate context we are told that all the fullness of the "Godhead" (θεοτητος), i.e., *Deity, the Trinity,* dwells in Jesus "bodily" *(σωματικως).* This word is used three times in the New Testament, here as an adverb, and it clearly has reference to either a physical or a resurrection body. We understand that while incarnate in human flesh *Deity dwelt in Him* (cf. John 14:9-10); likewise in resurrection body in the heavenlies *Deity "dwells" (κατοικει) in Him as the present tense indicates.* As we observed in John's Gospel, God dwells *with believers;* however, here we see that *God dwells in Jesus Christ,* because He is God, and the integrity of His Person demands this to be true!

10. ***"and you have been made full in him, who is the head of all rule and authority,"***

The pronouns *him* and *who* in this verse refer to the antecedent *Christ.* The message is that believers have been made full in Christ, and that Christ is the Head of all rule and authority. In the previous verse we observed that "all the fullness" *(παν το πληρωμα)* of Deity dwells in Him. Having stated the fact that Jesus Christ represents the

fullness of God, Paul goes on to deal with the significance of this to the individual believer. The thought is that *because* Jesus Christ embodies the fullness of God believers *in Him have been made full.*

According to the Greek text we have the same basic word used in both verses nine and ten; the noun form "fullness" *(πληρωμα)* in verse nine, and the verb form "have been made full" (πεπληρωμενοι) in verse ten. The oneness in family relation between these two words makes the continuity of thought between *what is in Christ and what believers have in Him* very obvious.

Now let us analyze the significance of the statement: "you have been made full in him." First, the meaning of the verb translated "have been made full" *(πεπληρωμενοι)* should be translated so as to *match* the word *fullness* in verse nine and to carry through the thought which limits us to the translation *have been made full.* Behind this translation we have the idea of being made complete, of being filled up, or of having everything we need for perfection in Christ. Even as there is total fullness, completeness, and perfection in God in Christ; likewise believers in Christ share in the same fullness, completeness, and perfection of God. Paul's argument is that since the fullness of God resides in Christ, and because of their *in-position in Christ* they have been made full; therefore it *is ridiculous to try to add* anything to their full and complete position in Christ.

Second, we need to consider the importance of Paul putting this participle in the *passive voice and the perfect tense.* The passive voice indicates that the Colossian believers were the *recipients of the action;* they had not made themselves full in Christ, *but God,* in His sovereignty, who had put them in Christ through the Holy Spirit, was the one who had made them full and complete in Christ. God had provided both their fullness and completeness in Christ, as well as their placement in Christ; therefore both the *fullness* and *obtaining it* were provided by God.

Third, the use of the perfect tense indicates how *secure* they were in their full and complete position in Christ. According to the meaning of the perfect tense, at a given point of time in the past God had sovereignly made the Colossian believers full and complete in Christ and the results of this action performed by God continued in full effect, i.e., *God continued to keep them in the state of fullness* in which he had placed them. The use of the passive voice and the

perfect tense utterly eradicate the naive humanistic idea that a human being can destroy and repudiate that which God has done on his behalf! A finite human being cannot and will not want to destroy that which the infinite sovereign God has wrought on him!

Having stated the fact that all believers have been made full ones, completed ones, and perfected ones in Christ and that this is their standing before God, Paul proceeds to point out that Christ is the *head of all rule and authority.* The words translated "all rule" *(*πασης αρχης) are in the singular and may be translated *every rule;* hence *every ruler,* i.e., everyone who occupies a first position (cf. Eph. 1:21).

We see the word "all" (πασης) as also applicable to the word "authority" (εξουσιας), meaning that Christ is also the head of *all authority,* i.e., of *every authority.* The basic meaning of this word is *right, power, privilege, etc.* Consider all the rights, privileges, and power, behind every authority in the universe; then consider what is said here - that Christ is the Head over every single one of these - and you have a picture of Him as *the Head of every supreme ruler and authority.*

The emphasis here is that Christ is *head of,* i.e., is superior to, every ruler and authority whether good or evil. Thus we observe that God the Father has made Christ the Son the *first Ruler* and *Authority* next to Himself in the universe. As believers, identified with Christ through faith, we are more than conquerors in our all powerful Lord (cf. Rom. 8:37).

11. ***"in whom also you were circumcised with a circumcision not made with hands, in the putting off of the body of the flesh, in the circumcision of Christ,"***

Here Paul says that believers in their position in Christ have been circumcised. The circumcision Paul has in mind here is *a nonhandmade* circumcision, i.e., *a spiritual cutting off of sin* in the flesh (cf. Rom 8:3). Paul's use of the passive voice and aorist tense suggest that in a once-for-all transaction God the Holy Spirit spiritually circumcised the Colossian believers, i.e., identified their bodies of sin with Christ's death (cf. Rom. 6:4; Gal. 5:24).

It appears to us that this spiritual circumcision, which typifies the cutting off of the sinful flesh (cf. Rom. 7:18-20), is the same as that

which Paul typifies by baptism in Romans 6:3-4, namely, *the death of the flesh* through its identification with the death of Christ. As the passive voice indicates, this was *a sovereign work of God* the Holy Spirit, determined before the creation of the world and effected when the Colossians were called to faith in Jesus Christ (cf. Rom. 8:30).

Paul has already referred to this circumcision as one which was *not-made-with-hands.* This statement makes two things evident: (1) no man had anything to do with this circumcision, and (2) it had nothing to do with a man's physical body - it was a spiritual circumcision (cf. Rom. 2:29).

Lastly, Paul refers to this circumcision as being the *circumcision of Christ.* The use of the genitive case suggests that it was a circumcision which *belonged to Christ,* not in the sense that He was the circumcisor, but in the sense that believers are *identified with His death* by it. As circumcised believers we need to recognize that our flesh body has been cut off and put to death by the circumcision of Christ; now we are to live according to the Spirit (Gal. 5:16, 18).

12. ***"having been buried with him in baptism, in whom also you were raised with him through the faithful energizing of God, who raised him out from the dead;"***

Since the circumcision mentioned in the previous verse was a not-made-with-hands circumcision, i.e., it was *not a physical circumcision,* and the baptism mentioned here is in the *same immediate context,* it logically follows that it, too, is *not a physical but a spiritual baptism.* The Greek word translated *having been buried with* him is an aorist passive participle; it is identified to the verb used for *circumcised* in voice, tense, and number. The passive voice indicates that God the Holy Spirit was the one who performed this spiritual baptism *into the death of Christ,* i.e., who *identified* the Colossian believers with the death of Christ. The aorist tense indicates that this baptism took place at *a given point of time* and would not be repeated, it was the perfect work of God (cf. Rom. 6:3-4; 1 Cor. 12:13).

Now let us consider the ramifications of the statement: "having been buried with" *(συνταφεντες)* in baptism. Here we have the participle form of the Greek word *"συνθαπτω,"* which in turn is derived from the two Greek words *"συν"* and *"θαπτω,"* which literally mean to *bury with* or to be identified with another in burial. The key emphasis

is on *identification* between two persons, the Saviour and the one He saves, and this identification is in the sphere of death and subsequent burial. This identification is produced by God, it is *a sovereign act of God* based upon faith, and the body of sin which has been put to death with Christ is *permanently buried.*

This passage is *obviously* teaching the same spiritual truth as we have in Romans 6:3-5. We who have been spiritually identified with Christ's death are to *no longer live in sin!* These two passages mutually reinforce the truth of each other. Romans elaborates on the significance of the baptism and Colossians clarifies the spiritual nature of this baptism.

The basic Greek word for "bury" *(θαπτω)* is used eleven times in the New Testament, and in every instance it refers to burying a dead human body or corpse. It is *never used* to depict covering something or someone with soil or water; whereas our English word bury is broad enough to cover both concepts. The Greek word *"συνθαπτω"* is used only two times in the New Testament. The addition of the prefix *"συν"* does not change the basic meaning of *"θαπτω"* but only adds the idea of *with.* Believers were *buried with Jesus Christ* in His physical death-burial; they were *identified with His death and burial* as His body was placed in Joseph's tomb.

We need to keep clearly in mind that identification with Jesus Christ's burial *implies an earlier predetermined identification with His death* (cf. Rom. 6:3-4; Eph. 1:4-5). Of course, *it is impossible to understand* how believers today could have been identified with Jesus Christ's death and burial in approximately 29 A. D. apart from the fact that God has *sovereignly chosen an elect people for His own name* (cf. Rom. 8:28-30; 9:11-18).

Having considered the fact that the Greek word "bury" *(θαπτω)* is only used in conjunction with the burying of dead human bodies or corpses, now let us turn our attention to the meaning of the word baptism. What does Paul mean when he says that we have been buried with Christ in or by baptism?

First, the word "baptism" *(βαπτισμω)* goes back to the basic word *"βαπτω"* which literally means *to dip* or *to dye.* This particular form is used only four times in the New Testament, and in each case it conveys the idea of *dip,* i.e., to place something in something else;

hence the *identification of one thing with another.*

According to the oldest Greek manuscripts the word "baptism" *(βαπτισμω)* is used three other times in the New Testament in this form. Once it depicts the washing of cups (Mark 7:4), once it speaks of general washings which the Hebrew Christians are to leave behind (Heb. 6:2), and last it refers to various washings associated with the Levitical Priesthood (Heb. 9:10). The one solid and indisputable meaning of this word is *identification* and as used in this verse and in Romans 6:3-4, it speaks of *spiritual identification* with Jesus Christ's death and burial.

Never forget, recognition of the fact that all believers have been spiritually identified with Christ's death and burial is the *basis for all true spirituality! We must know* that we have died with Christ to sin before we can live victoriously with Him over sin!

Even as believers have been identified with Jesus Christ in death and burial; likewise they have been identified with Him in spiritual resurrection. Paul tells the Colossians that they "have been raised" *(συνηγερθητε)* with Christ. The use of the passive voice indicates that *God* effected their resurrection, and the use of the aorist tense indicates that they were raised at a given *point of time* in the past. Paul specifically says that their resurrection was accomplished through the *faithful energizing of God.* Beyond a shadow of doubt, the Greek word "πιστεως," as used in this context, is most accurately translated *faithfulness.*

In our investigation it is an *established fact* that this word *(πιστις* in the nominative case) frequently conveys the *idea of faithfulness* (cf. Rom. 3:3; Gal. 2:16; 3:22; Eph. 3:12; Philemon 5, etc.). The same God who raised Christ out from the dead and thereby displayed His power to raise the dead, is the one who faithfully *works* (ενεργειας) to produce the instantaneous spiritual resurrection of all believers.

Again we emphasize, true spirituality begins *when we recognize* that our old man has been crucified and buried with Christ (cf. Rom. 6:6) and that out of the grave of death to sin *we have been raised with Christ to a new life* to live unto God (cf. Rom. 6:4, 10). This truth, which identifies us with both the death and resurrection of Christ, is *imperative* for a spiritual walk with Jesus Christ!

13. ***"and you being dead in trespasses and the uncircumcision***

of your flesh, he (God) made you alive together with him, having forgiven us all the trespasses,"

Prior to the preaching of the Gospel at Colossae, the inhabitants of that city were all *dead* in their trespasses and uncircumcised flesh (cf. Eph. 2:1). The present participle "οντας" suggests that before they were saved they *existed in a state of spiritual death.* The reason they were spiritually dead was because they were living "in trespasses" *(παραπτωμασιν),* which literally means that they were *falling beside, stumbling beside;* hence *falling on their face* as far as God's standards were concerned (cf. Rom. 1:19-21; 2:12-15).

The fact that the word trespasses is in the *plural* points out that they were daily committing individual trespasses, before the Lord. Observe further, they were not only dead in trespasses, but also in the "uncircumcision" *(ακροβυστια)* of their flesh, which has the idea of *sin of or in the flesh (v.* 11). It is significant that this word is in the *singular,* and indicates that they were *sinners in their nature* (cf. Eph. 2:3). As sinners by nature all that they could produce would be sinful acts and trespasses; likewise their sinful acts and trespasses showed that they were by nature sinners (Matt. 12:33).

While the Colossians were in the hopeless dilemma of spiritual death, unable to extricate themselves, God made them *spiritually alive* together with Christ. The Greek word translated "made alive together with" *(συνεζωοποιησεν)* comes from a combining of three Greek words, which literally mean *make alive with* (Eph. 2:5). In the New Testament this word is used twice, and in the *"ζωοποιεω"* form five times, and in every instance it has the idea of making alive or giving life to. It always refers to the *Divine life* that is in God the Father and Son and is extended to believers (cf. John 6:57). Christ shares this life with those who are *joined with Him through faith.*

Before God could make those who were dead in trespasses and sins alive, they had to be forgiven. Paul uses the aorist participles to express the exact time relation, i.e., "having forgiven" *(χαρισαμενος)* us all the trespasses. The aorist participle refers to *action prior to the leading verb,* i.e., God having forgiven them; then He made them alive in Christ. There had to be the *removal of sin* through forgiveness before there could be the implanting of life with Christ! Are your sins forgiven? Do you have life together with Christ?

14. ***"having blotted out the handwriting in the ordinances that was against us, which was contrary to us, and he took it out of the midst, having nailed it to the cross;"***

The time-setting of this verse is the cross; it speaks of the handwriting of the Law being done away with at Calvary. The main thing Paul is talking about in this verse is the "handwriting" *(χειρογραφον),* which comes from a combination of the two Greek words *hand* and *write,* and basically means that which is written by hand. Paul is obviously using this word here to refer to the *handwritten Mosaic Law.* Also, Paul is apparently using the pronoun "us" *(ημων)* primarily with reference to the Jews, particularly those who were believers. We must always keep in mind that the Law was specifically *given to Israel,* and it had no relevance to the Gentiles unless they were proselytes. Jews, having been under the Law for some 1400 years, were the ones who had to be delivered out from under it, and Paul sees the cross as the basis for that deliverance.

Paul speaks of the handwriting, the Law, as being "against us" *(καθ' ημων)* and *opposed to* us. It is difficult to know exactly what Paul meant by this statement. Was the Law against him and the other Jews, in that when they thought they were living good lives, the Law *revealed* the sinful and lustful nature of their hearts (cf. Rom. 7:7-12)? In addition to the Law being against the Jews, Paul also says that it was "contrary" *(υπεναντιον)* to us, *adverse,* and *set over against us.* The Law was certainly contrary to what the Jews were in the flesh (cf. Rom. 7:17, 23). Thus we see that the Mosaic Law, the handwriting in ordinances, was against, contrary to, and in conflict with the sin that was dwelling in Paul and the Jews (cf. 7:17, 24).

With respect to the handwriting of the Law that was against the Jews, Paul says that it "has been blotted out" (εξαλειψας), *obliterated, expunged,* and *washed away* (cf. Acts 3:19; Rev. 3:5). Furthermore, Paul affirms that it "had been taken" (ηρκεν), *lifted up,* and *carried* "out of the midst" (εκ του μεσου), i.e., *out of the middle, out from among,* or *out of the way.* When this handwriting was removed from the midst, it was "nailed" *(προσηλωσας), fastened with nails to the cross.* The implication is that the Law went up to the cross and that it *ended with the cross,* when the seed had come and died (cf. Gal 3:19), namely, Jesus Christ. Thus we see that the Law was *blotted out* and *nailed to the cross;* it ceased with Christ's death (Matt.

27:51)!

15. ***"having despoiled the rulers and the authorities, he made an open show of them, having triumphed over them in it."***

The subject and the main *actor* in this verse is Jesus Christ. The object of the verse, those *against whom Jesus Christ acted,* was the rulers and the authorities. We raise the question: Who were these rulers and authorities? The word translated "rulers" *(αρχας)* has the basic meaning of *first in time and position;* hence these rulers were those who were first and chief in rank and power, they were the *powerful ones,* the *principle ones.* Paul uses this word four times in this epistle. Once it is used with reference to Jesus Christ (1:18), twice its use does not define the rulers as either good or evil, and its use in this verse obviously applies to *evil rulers* (cf. Eph. 6:12).

Since Paul is talking about both rulers and authorities, let us now consider the meaning of the word translated "authority" (εξουσιας). This word has the basic idea of *right, prerogative,* and *privilege;* hence it is translated *authorities,* namely, those who are exercising their rights, prerogatives, and privileges. An acceptable English equivalent is the word powers; those who have the right to exercise authority are *powers.* Therefore, this can well be translated either authorities or powers.

Paul likewise uses this word four times in this epistle. Twice he uses it in contexts where it could have either a good or evil connotation (1:16; 2:10), and twice, including this verse, he uses it regarding *evil authorities* (1:13). These two words are commonly used together, as in this verse. It is our feeling, even though not always defined, that they are *generally used with reference to evil forces* associated with Satan (cf. 1 Cor. 15:24; Eph. 2:2).

Now let us take a look at what Jesus Christ did to these evil rulers and authorities. First, He has "despoiled" (απεκδυσαμενος) them. The Greek word used here is derived from three Greek words which literally mean to *put off from;* hence the idea *renounced, stripped off,* and *threw off.* The basic word "εκδυω" is commonly used to describe the *putting off of clothing.* In the same manner Jesus put or threw off the evil rulers and authorities.

After Jesus Christ had thrown off these satanic forces, Paul says that He "made an open show of them" *(εδειγματισεν εν παρρησια).*

The basic meaning of the Greek word " εδειγματισεν" is to *point out, show,* and to *exhibit. The* Greek phrase *"εν παρρησια,"* in this context, conveys the idea of *boldness, plainness, openness,* and *frankness.* Looking at this clause as a whole, Jesus Christ pointed out, showed, and exhibited in the sphere of boldness, plainness, and openness the fact that He had *thrown off the satanic forces.* Expressing the correct thought in other terms, Jesus Christ boldly and frankly pointed out and exhibited *His victory over the evil rulers and authorities.* The language used here portrays Jesus Christ as the *all powerful conqueror* utterly destroying the forces of Satan and throwing them off as one strips and throws off a garment!

There are three action words in this verse. First, Jesus Christ *threw off* the evil rulers and authorities. Second, He *openly displayed* the fact that He had *defeated* them. Third, He triumphed over the satanic forces by means of the cross. In a more detailed manner let us focus our attention on this third point. The Greek word translated "triumphed over" (θριαμβευσας) speaks of the triumphal procession following victory over one's enemy.

Jesus Christ *completely triumphed* over Satan and the rulers and authorities associated with Him at a given point in history. After His death on Calvary's cross Jesus could say, "all authority (εξουσια) has been given to me in heaven and upon earth" (Matt. 28:18). Since the Millennial Kingdom was rejected by the nation of Israel, Jesus has *not yet utilized His triumphal authority* and power over Satan, but He will when the times of the Gentiles are full and He comes again to sovereignly establish the Kingdom with power and great glory (cf. Matt. 25:31-32; Acts 1:11; Heb. 2:8).

Lastly, we need to recognize that the *dynamic power* of this verse is the *cross.* The Greek word for triumphed is *an aorist* participle, which indicates that when Jesus died on the cross, *at that Moment of time there was complete triumph over Satan* and his cohorts. John speaks of the fact that "the ruler of this world has been judged" (John 16:11). The perfect tense makes it clear that Satan, the ruler of this world, *was judged* at the cross and *continues under the sentence* of that judgment. We would affirm with Paul, "Thanks to God who always causes us to triumph in Christ" (2 Cor. 2:14).

16. ***"Therefore let no one judge you in food and in drink, or with regard to a feast or a new moon or a sabbath,"***

Having finished a paragraph that has exalted the Person of Jesus Christ and that has informed us of some of the rich provisions we have in Christ, Paul now turns his attention to some of the mundane problems confronting the Colossians. Apparently the Judaizers were criticizing them for not keeping various aspects of the Mosaic Law and were trying to superimpose these legal details on top of their faith in Jesus Christ. Paul's answer is directed toward the Colossians; he tells them the attitude they should take toward the Judaizers, namely, *not to allow themselves to be judged by them.* Paul is really telling them not to pay any attention to nor listen to what these phony religionists have to say.

When the Judaizers try to judge you on the basis of what you eat and drink, as well as on the basis of whether you observe certain feast days, new moon days, or sabbath days, *Turn a deaf ear to them,* Don't be judged by them, Pay no attention to what they say! The Judaizers were apparently trying to foist these five things on the Colossians, but Paul says No, don't listen to them, for these things are not for the Body of Christ, the Church.

In Romans 14:17, Paul says, "For the kingdom of God is not food and drink, but righteousness and peace and joy in the Holy Spirit." In Hebrews 13:9, Paul affirms, "it is good to establish the heart by grace, not by foods, by which those walking have not profited." The Book of Leviticus has much to say about feasts associated with the Mosaic Law (cf. Lev. 23:1-8; 33-37). The new moons also had a distinct role in the Mosaic Law economy (cf. Neh. 10:33; Ps. 81:3: Isa. 1:13-14). The keeping of the Sabbath was a very important part of the Law of Moses and it was the fourth of the ten commandments (Exod. 20:8). ALL these things did have their place during the Mosaic Law period, but since the Law ceased at the cross, they are *not to be observed* by believers today.

17. ***"which are a shadow of things to come, but the body is Christ's."***

With reference to the things mentioned in the verse above, Paul says that they are "a shadow" (σκια), *that which casts a shade or shadow out into the future.* They serve as a shadow of "things to come" *(*των μελλοντων*), of that which is about to come, of future things.*

We must carefully keep in mind that these things are a shadow

of *a very limited area* of truth. The most important single area where we would see the shadow projecting from the Old Testament to the New Testament *would have to do with redemption.* This involves two important aspects: (1) man's incurable *sinfulness;* and (2) God's provision for *salvation.* Then there are also those shadows that pertain to Jesus Christ as the all-sufficient *Saviour* for sin. Certain mundane physical things in the Old Testament *foreshadowed spiritual realities* in the New Testament.

The truth regarding the Church, the Body of Christ, is *not foreshadowed* in the Old Testament! God revealed *nothing* to the Old Testament prophets regarding Christ and His headship over a spiritual organism which is His Body. The person who amazes you with the shadows and types of the Church, which he claims to see in the Old Testament, is *inexcusably ignorant of the Scriptures* and particularly of the Pauline Epistles!

In speaking of the Gospel of the Grace of God, *the mystery,* the truth for the Church today, Paul says that it is *unsearchable,* i.e., it cannot be searched out, tracked, or traced out, and we believe Paul makes this statement with reference to the Old Testament (Eph. 3:8; cf. Rom. 16:25-26; 11:25, 33; 1 Cor. 2:6-9). In summary, remember that *there is no foreshadowing of the Church,* the Body of Christ, in the Old Testament. Any foreshadowing that would be applicable to this Church age would be limited to the *Person* and *redemptive work* of Christ.

Having stated that the foregoing things from the Mosaic Law have a shadow significance for the future, Paul says, "but the body is Christ's." To clarify the meaning let us translate it, "but the body belongs to Christ." It appears to us that Paul is trying to get them to *focus their attention on the Body of Christ,* the Church, instead of on the things being pushed by the Judaizers. The thing that really counts is that we are members of the Body of Christ, and as such, we are directly under the Head, Christ. Paul is literally saying, *Away with these legalistic tenets of the Law,* concentrate on Christ and your position in His Body, the Church.

18. ***"Let no one rob you of your prize willingly by humility and the worship of angels, taking his stand on what he has seen, vainly puffed up by the mind of his flesh,"***

In this verse Paul *warns* them to be on guard against those who

would rob them of their prize. The phrase translated "let no one rob you of your prize" (μηδεις υμας καταβραβευετω) means they are not to allow anyone to *deprive* them of the prize, nor are they to permit anyone *to hinder* them from obtaining the prize. In the light of the context it appears to us that *the prize is being filled with all the fulness of God, being made complete in Christ,* who is the Head of the Body (cf. 9-10). Furthermore, the prize of being made complete in Christ is *a part of ultimate glorification with Christ* (cf. 3:4; Phil. 3:14, 21). Those who are made full and complete in Christ will be glorified together with Christ - the ultimate object and prize for all believers!

Now let us look at the word translated "willingly" (θελων), which in the context reads, "Let no one rob you of your prize willingly by humility and the worship of angels". The word "θελων" is a present, nominative participle. The nominative case indicates that the one willing *is the subject who is acting*; the present tense indicates that this person is *continuously acting;* therefore we have the picture of a persistent Judaizer who is *continuously endeavoring to force his strong legalistic will* on the Colossian believers. In verse 23, Paul is apparently referring to this psychological phenomenon as will-worship.

The false teachers at Colossae were apparently clever propagators of error. They knew how to use subtle and deceptive tricks to persuade and subvert their potential prey. In addition to continuously imposing their will on the Colossian believers, they put on *a humble and lowly-minded front (*ταπεινοφροσυνη*).* This is a highly commendable Christian attribute (Eph. 4:2; Phil. 2:3) which they were feigning in order to deceptively gain converts. Also, they indulged in the "worship" *(*θρησκεια*)* of angels, which supposedly elevated them to a position of high religious prestige, increasing their effectiveness as apostates.

Furthermore, these false teachers took their stand on that which they had seen, in other words, on the basis of what they had seen they *claimed special authority. Paul* describes the legalistic Judaizer as a person *governed by the mind of the flesh,* i.e., controlled by the old sin nature and as such he is vainly puffed up, an *obnoxiously proud person.* Paul's advice: Don't let them deprive you of the Headship of Christ!

19. ***"and not holding fast the head, out of whom all the body,***

through the joints and ligaments is supplied and knit together, growing the growth of God."

The Greek word for "head" (κεφαλην) is used five times to designate Jesus Christ as Head over the Church. It is obviously used in this manner in this verse. It is used once to set forth Jesus Christ as head of every ruler and authority (v. 10). It is used once to depict Jesus Christ as the head of every man (1 Cor. 11:3). According to the Scripture Jesus Christ is the *head of every person* and *everything* and God the Father is the head of Him (1 Cor. 11:3).

Referring to a false teacher he has been warning them against in the preceding verses, Paul says, He is one who is not holding fast the Head. The word translated "holding fast" *(*κρατων*)* conveys the idea of *forcefully possessing someone,* such as *forcefully laying hold of one* to put him in prison (Matt. 14:3). It is also used with the idea of *strongly retaining,* to *adhere to,* or to *cleave to* someone or something such as to adhere to a given teaching (2 Thess. 2:15) or to strongly cleave to a confession (Heb. 4:14).

The point Paul is making here is that anyone involved in the false teaching that was going on in Colossae was not holding fast, was not tenaciously possessing, nor was he strongly cleaving to the Head of the Body, the Church. Looking at what Paul is saying from the positive point of view the implication is that the answer to false teaching is to *hold fast to the Headship of Christ* over the Church. Those who know the mystery truth revealed regarding Jesus Christ and His relation to the Church will, in the power of the Holy Spirit, hold fast to the *fact that He is the Head* of the Church, and will unflinchingly cling and cleave to *His Person as the Head* of the Body! There is *nothing* that can separate the true believer from his Head, Jesus Christ (cf. Rom. 8:31-39)!

Jesus Christ as Head is the *source* from which the increase and ggrowth of the Body comes. The phrase "out of whom" (εξ ου) is "εκ" with the ablative case and as such it speaks of the *source,* the *place of origin,* and the supply which provides what the Body, the Church, needs. *Out of Christ* all the Body, through the agency of the joints and ligaments is continuously being supplied and knit together, continuously grows the growth of God. Simplifying this statement, Paul is telling us that Jesus Christ is the source from which all the Body is growing the growth of God.

As Head of the Body Jesus Christ Himself *provides the spiritual nutrition* which is essential for "all the body" *(*παν το σωμα) to "continuously grow" (αυξει), *increase,* and *be enlarged.* First, observe that Jesus Christ's provision is not for just some of the Body but *for all, for every single member.* Second, the use of the present tense indicates that this growing is *a continuous process.*

Paul refers to this continuous growing as the "growth of God" *(*αυξησιν του θεου*),* i.e., *the growth that belongs to God.* Uncontrolled and unintelligent growth could lead to a monstrous evil spectacle. The growth Paul is talking about here is that of an all knowing, omniscient, and intelligent God. It is a growth which is *determined* and accomplished in accord with God's sovereign will and purpose (Eph. 1:5). It is a growth which is not left to the whims of the polluted, finite mind of man, but was *predetermined by God* even before the creation of the world. This growth is the *actual fulfilling* of God's sovereign purpose as the Church is being built in history (Acts 13:48; Rom. 8:28-30; 1 Cor. 1:30). Before our very eyes we are seeing God the Holy Spirit calling out the elect of God and making them a part of the growing Body of Christ!

Now let us consider the intervening agents through which Jesus Christ accomplishes this growth. It is "through" (δια) the agency or medium of the "joints" *(*αφων*),* which means *a connection* or *juncture,* and through the "ligaments" *(*συνδεσμων*),* which literally means *that which binds with or holds together.* The English word *ligament,* which is a tough band of tissue connecting the articular extremities of bones, is an excellent translation of the Greek word used here. The words translated joints and ligaments are in the *plural,* and as there are many joints and ligaments in the human body; likewise many different members are joined together in the Body of Christ (Rom. 12:5; 1 Cor. 12:12-14).

Now let us consider two important present passive participles in this verse which show *how* the joints and ligaments *contribute* to the growth of the Body. The total Body, through the joints and ligaments is "continuously being supplied" (επιχορηγουμενον), i.e., it is *being super-supplied* or *abundantly supplied.* Also, through the joints and ligaments all the Body is "continuously being knit together" *(*συμβιβαζομενον*), i.e.,* it is *being joined together, merged together, or united together.*

Bringing these truths together we have a picture of the Holy Spirit *abundantly supplying* and *uniting together* the Body of Christ through its spiritual joints and ligaments, i.e., through its members with their different gifts and functions (cf. Eph. 4-16). In summary, Jesus Christ is the *source* of His Body's nutrition and growing. This growing is *accomplished through* the different functions of the members of His Body; this growing is the actual *outworking of God's sovereign purpose* for the Body of Christ, the Church!

20. ***"If you died with Christ from the rudiments of the world, why as though living in the world are you subject to ordinances,"***

The point Paul is making here is that if the Colossians have died with Christ, then in this state of spiritual death, they are *separated from* the "rudiments" *(στειχειων), elements,* and *basic principles of this world.* The concept of having died with Christ is basic to the concept of having died to sin (Rom. 6:2-8). Where there has been spiritual identification with the death of Christ there should be a *death-separation* from the physical ordinances of men (cf. 2 Cor. 5:15).

Observe that these physical, rudimentary, and elementary principles belong to *this "world" (κοσμου);* they are a *part of the world system* and are not to be practiced by the members of the Body of Christ! The use of the preposition "from" (απο) suggests that those who had died with Christ had, as a result of that death, *been drawn away and separated* from the rudimentary religious principles of the world.

Paul's basic argument is that if you have died to physical elementary principles of the world, *why* are you living in subordination to these things in the world? Putting it even more bluntly Paul is saying to them: If you have died to the world, why as living ones are you subject to worldly rules? The Greek word for "living" (ζωντες) is a present, nominative participle. As such it can be translated *living ones, those who are living,* i.e., *those who share the life of God;* hence are spiritually living (John 6:57). We recognize that *all* those who are identified with Jesus Christ in death are also identified with Him in life (Rom. 6:4, 8).

As those who are *spiritually living* in Christ, Paul makes it clear to them that even though they are living in the sphere of this world

system, they are *not to submit to the ordinances* (δογματιζεσθε), rules, and regulations. In other words, Paul is telling them *not to have anything to do with* pseudo religious rules and decrees! They are *complete in Christ,* apart from all physical rites and regulations, and must not get mixed up in such *religious junk!*

21. ***"Do not handle, nor taste, nor touch,"***

The Greek word translated "handle" (αψη) is in the aorist tense and subjunctive mood. Paul literally says that they *should not handle, come in contact with,* or *meddle with these things* of the world. The Jews under the Law were not to handle that which was unclean, and since these things are *unclean for believers today,* Paul confirms this *principle* for members of the Body of Christ (Isa. 52:11; 2 Cor. 6:17). ALL pseudo religious rites, which are added to the finished work of Christ on Calvary, are unclean humanistic scum.

The Greek word translated "taste" *(*γευση*)* is also in the aorist tense and subjunctive mood. Paul tells them that they *should not even taste, try the flavor of,* or *excite the sensory buds* with such forbidden fruit (cf. Gen. 2:17). Through Divine revelation God has pointed out what is good and evil. Because God has spoken we know the bitterness of consummated evil and should not even taste it in its enticing incipient form (cf. 1 Cor. 14:20; 1 Thess. 5:22). Let alone eat, Paul tells the Colossians *not to even taste the man-made commandments* being imposed upon them by false teachers.

The Greek word translated "touch" (θιγης), like the two above, is in the aorist tense and subjunctive mood. Instead of using the imperative mood and saying, don't touch, Paul less authoritatively says *you should not touch, put your hand upon,* or even *rub against* these teachings of men. Paul's *triple negative statement* used here certainly emphasizes the need for believers to *stay away from adding anything to the Gospel of God's Grace!* To add to the Gospel is to *pervert* the Gospel, according to what Paul says to the Galatians, and the person who does this is anathema, accursed (Gal. 1:7-9).

22. ***"all which things are perishing with the using, according to the commandments and teachings of men?"***

Paul uses the preposition "εις" with the accusative case to make clear that all these things are *moving unto the end of "perishing" (*φθοραν*), corruption, decay,* and *utter ruin.* The end of these things is

corruption and decay as they are "used" *(αποχρησει)* or *consumed.* It appears to us that Paul probably has in mind here the food and drink he mentions in verse 16, which associated with feasts, special days, and religious rites, is consumed and its end is *corruption and decay.* This would be in keeping with the use of the Greek word *"αποχρησει"* in the Greek Papyri, where *pastures* are said to have been used up or consumed. The basic meaning of this verb, the prohibition not to taste in the previous verse, and the idea of perishing and decaying with use, all point toward the fact that Paul was probably referring to food and drink used in conjunction with religious rituals.

Paul has been speaking about the admixture of Judaism and Gnosticism that the false teachers are trying to impose upon the Colossians, and he says that these things are "according to the commandments and teachings of men." The word translated "commandments" (ενταλματα) means *precepts, ordinances,* or that which one is charged to do. The word translated "teachings" (διδασκαλιας) *literally means teachings,* but some have improperly translated it doctrines. As far as the Colossians were concerned, they were members of the Body of Christ, the Church, according to God's sovereign choosing and implanting of faith. Those who were trying to force these things upon them were doing it according to *human* commands and teachings. The Lord had never given these physical trappings to Paul as a part of the truth for the Church!

There were probably certain elements of Judaism, which had been taken out of the Old Testament, that were being forced upon the Colossians. When Paul speaks of at least some of these things as being a shadow of things to come (v. 17), he is obviously referring to some things that Israel was to observe under the Law. These were precepts and ordinances that had been given by God to His people, Israel, while under the Law. They were the ordinances and teachings of God *for that particular time,* for that dispensation, and for that legal economy. The Law having been done away with at the cross, with all its physical ordinances, *is no longer God's message for today* (Mark 15:38; Gal 3:19). Those who try to foist the physical rites of the Mosaic Law on the Church today are teaching the commandments and teachings of men according to this verse.

23. ***"Which things indeed have a message of wisdom in will-worship and humility and severity to the body, but are not of any***

value against the indulgence of the flesh."

We need to recognize that false teachers are often well trained manipulators of the human mind. They know that all human beings like to think of themselves as being wise and intelligent; therefore they assume the role of the intelligensia - they are the ones who are in the know. They couch their message in forms that cause the ignorant to admire them for their great *will power,* seeming *humility,* and *severe treatment* of their bodies.

First, Paul says that the commandments and teachings of men have a "message" (λογον) of wisdom *in will-worship.* The word translated "will-worship" *(*εθελοθρησκια) comes from the combining of the two words "εθελω" and *"*θρησκεια*,"* and literally means worship in which the will is involved. It appears to us that this must have been a humanistic type of worship in which *a strong will* and *the ability to concentrate* must have been central.

It is probable that Paul is speaking about the same thing in verse 18, where he warns them against being deprived of the prize "willingly" (θελων) by the imposition of a strong legalistic will. This *will* could be looked at as an *object of worship* or as *a means to force one* to keep legalistic ordinances. Whatever the case, the false teacher was trying to use the outward show of wisdom associated with will-worship to gain converts.

Second, Paul declares that the commandments and teachings of men have a message of wisdom in *humility.* The Greek word for "humility" *(*ταπεινοφροσυνη*)* is derived from the two words *"*ταπεινος*"* and *"*φρην*,"* and literally means to have *a low or humble mind.* Paul uses this word four times to set forth humility as a highly desirable Christian characteristic. He uses it twice in this chapter (v. 18) with reference to false teachers. They were *feigning* this characteristic so as to have a wise and acceptable front to the Colossians, but under this camouflage they were perpetrating the grace-destroying ordinances of men (cf. Gal. 5:4).

Third, Paul indicates that the commandments and teachings of men have a message of wisdom in the *severe treatment* of their bodies. The Greek word for "severe treatment" (αφειδια) has the basic idea of *unsparing;* hence *severe, harsh, and rigorous treatment.* Paul is referring to *their asceticism,* man's effort through self-denial

and self-torture, to discipline himself in order to reach a higher state of spirituality. The natural man sees a great deal of wisdom and merit in this austere treatment of one's self but Paul certainly *did not.*

Regarding these three things, will-worship, feigned humility, and asceticism, Paul says that they are "not of any value (worth) against the indulgence of the flesh." The word translated "indulgence" *(πλησμονην)* means *a filling up, satisfying fully,* or the *gratification of the flesh.* None of these humanly contrived and feigned practices will check and control the flesh (cf. Rom. 8:3). Only God *the Holy Spirit is* able to give us victory over the lusts and desires of the flesh (Gal. 5:16, 25).

CHAPTER 3

1. ***"Therefore if you have been raised with Christ, seek the things above, where Christ is sitting on the right hand of God."***

In verse 20, Paul spoke about their having died with Christ, and as a result, being separated from the rudiments of the world. In verses 21-23, Paul deals with some of the things that they are to be separated from because they died with Christ. In this verse we have a continuation of the same thought; those who have died with Christ have now *been raised with Christ* (cf. Rom. 6:5, 8). ALL the characteristics of the new man in Christ should be put on (cf. Eph. 4:24). Previously, we were looking at how believers are *not to live,* but now we are going to see how believers *are to live.*

If the Colossians were true believers they had died with Christ; likewise if they were true believers they *had been raised with Christ.* Paul considered that his job was to preach the *Gospel,* to tell men *how* they could be identified with the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ through *faith,* and not to spend his time counting converts (1 Cor. 1:17; 15:1-4; Eph. 2:8). He recognized that God perfectly knows those who belong to Him, those who are true members of the Body of Christ; therefore he says "if" (ει) you have died with Christ and "if' (ει) you have been raised with Christ, these are two parts of a whole spiritual transaction.

The Greek word translated "you have been raised with" *(συνηγερθητε)* Christ is derived from two words, namely, *"συν"* and *"εγειρω"* and literally means to *raise up with* or to *raise up together* with (cf. Eph. 2:6). The aorist tense indicates that it took place at a given *point of' time* in the past. The passive voice indicates that this resurrection was produced not by the Colossians, but by God on their behalf (cf. 2:12). This, of course, is speaking of a past *spiritual* resurrection, which according to God's sovereign purpose identified the elect with both the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ and was personally *realized in history when the elect were justified* (cf. Rom. 8:30). In the mind of God death and resurrection with Jesus Christ go back to *the cross and the empty tomb.* In the experience of believers in history their death and resurrection with Jesus Christ go back to the time *they believed and were justified* (cf. Acts 13:48;

Rom. 4:25).

Now let us turn our attention to *what* believers are to do when they have been raised with Jesus Christ. First, they are to "seek" *(ζητειτε)* the things above, which literally means that they are to pursue after, strive for, and endeavor to attain unto these things. Since the verb "seek" *(ζητειτε)* is a present imperative, it means that believers are *commanded to continuously seek* the above things.

We must understand that Paul *is not* giving us believers an option *to be* or *not to be* spiritually oriented! He had *ordered* and *commanded* us to continuously focus our minds upon things above. The alternatives are either things above, Christ, or things upon the earth, Satan (cf. 2 Cor. 4:4). We cannot serve both simultaneously; it will be either *obedience* or *disobedience* to the command of Christ through Paul. In Matthew 6:33, Jesus promises physical necessities if they seek the earthly Kingdom first; however, Paul promises no physical rewards but future manifestation *with Christ in glory!*

Having told the Colossians to seek the things above, Paul makes a very significant identifying statement, namely, "where Christ is sitting on the right hand of God." This gives us the much needed clue to what the things above are, for it *identifies them with Christ!* The *things above* are *where Christ is sitting,* namely, on the right hand of God. It is interesting that Stephen observed Jesus *standing* (εστωτα) on the right hand of God (cf. Acts 7:55), as He waited for the nation of Israel to repent and receive Him as their King (cf. Acts 3:19-20). On the other hand, here we see Jesus Christ having been rejected as King but now *seated as Head over the Body,* the Church. The next thing on the prophetic horizon will be Jesus Christ *rising from His seated position* to come for His Church (cf. Col. 3:4; 1 Thess. 4:13-17).

2. ***"Think on the things above, and not on the things upon the earth."***

The key word in the first part of this verse is "think" *(φρονειτε).* This verb is an expression of the *mind in action;* hence has the idea of *thinking, reasoning, cogitating, meditating, reflecting, and contemplating.* Our minds are to be *actively engaged* in thinking, intellectually comprehending, and reasoning through the things which are above, namely, concentrating on Jesus Christ. The emphasis here is on an intelligent, objective, and non-emotional, continuous

concentration on the revelation of *truth* pertaining to Jesus Christ, the Head of the Body.

As we have already observed, to think on things above is to think on Jesus Christ, and to think on Jesus Christ is to think on that truth which reveals and makes Him known, and to think on the truth which reveals Christ as Head of the Church, is to *concentrate on the Word of God revealed* through the Apostle Paul (Gal. 1:12; Eph. 3:2-9; Col. 1:25-26).

Since the Greek word translated "think" *(*φρονειτε*)* is in the present tense, the implication is that we are to *continuously be thinking* about Him in His Headship relation to us in His Body, the Church. Following Paul's advice with respect to some of the main areas in which we should be thinking about Jesus Christ (in this Church age), let us consider three categories.

First, we need to *think* about Him as the one who restored us to *a right relationship with God.* Under this heading He is our *Saviour,* the one who has saved us from the *curse* and *power* of sin (Acts 13:23; cf. 2 Tim. 1:10; Tit. 1:4). He is our *righteousness,* the embodiment of the righteousness of God (1 Cor. 1:30; cf. Rom. 10:4). He is our *redemption,* the one who has ransomed us from sin (1 Cor. 1:30; cf. Rom 3:24). He is our *sanctification,* the one who has set us apart as perfect before God (1 Cor. 1:30; cf. 2 Thess. 2:13). He is our *wisdom* the truth for the Body of Christ, the Church (1 Cor. 1:30; Col. 2:3).

Second, we need to *think* about the *daily relationship* we have with Jesus Christ. He is the *Head* of the Body of which we are a part (1 Cor. 11:3; Eph. 1:22). He *loves* us with an eternal love (Rom. 8:35-39). He continuously *intercedes* for us (Rom. 8:34). We have the privilege of continuous *fellowship* with Him (1 John 1:3, 7). He is always ready to *cleanse away* and *forgive* our sins (1 John 1:7-9; Eph. 1:7).

Third, we need to *think* about our *future relationship to Jesus Christ.* He *is coming* again (1 Thess. 1:10). We will *share eternity with Him* (1 Thess. 4:13-17). He is going to give us *new resurrection bodies* like His, one suited for eternal existence (Phil. 3:21). All believers will have the *privilege of standing before Him* and being judged on the basis of their service record (1 Cor. 4:5). As Paul *thought* about Christ's coming again, and all that is associated with it,

he called it the *Blessed Hope* (Titus 2:13).

In summary, keep in mind, thinking on things above is *thinking about Jesus Christ,* and the only way we can effectively do this is by *thinking our way through the New Testament epistles!* To think about Jesus Christ is to *become like Him* (1 John 3:2). In contrast, to think upon the things of the earth is to *increasingly become engulfed and drowned in them* (Phil. 3:19).

Our emphasis has been on the positive thrust of this verse, concentrating on the Person of Jesus Christ, instead of on the negative things upon the earth. Observe that the word "things" *(τα)* is a neuter *plural* and is broad enough to include every single thing that is upon the earth. The natural man is *totally engrossed* in thinking about the things upon the earth (Phil. 3:18-19). The fact that the Spirit of God focuses the believer's thinking on the Person of Jesus Christ is utter *foolishness* to the unsaved man, it is impossible for him to understand it (I Cor. 2:14). Natural men measure value and success in terms of the things upon the earth (Luke 12:16-21).

Spiritual men, on the other hand, do not belong to themselves, they have been bought with the price of the precious Blood of Christ, and their main object should be to *glorify God* in their bodies (1 Cor. 6:19-20). They measure value and success in terms of a *right relationship with God in Christ* that expresses itself in doing the *good works pleasing to God* (Phil. 1:21; 3:9-10; Eph. 2:10). There is *no room* for true spiritual believers to be focusing their attention on the things of this earth, on materialism, on possessing things, beyond that which is necessary for food and shelter while they serve the Lord in the body (Phil. 4:11-13; 1 Tim. 6:6-10; 2 Tim. 2:3-7).

*3. **"For you died, and your life has been hidden with Christ in God."***

The word translated "you died" *(απεθανετε)* is the same word as used in verse 20, where it speaks about their having died with Christ. Paul's argument here is that since they have spiritually died with Christ to the old man (Rom. 6:6), now they are to recognize that their life has been hidden with Christ in God. The Greek word translated "has been hidden" *(κεκρυπται)* is a perfect passive verb and speaks of that which *was hidden* at a given time in the past and continues to be hidden, concealed, or secretly laid up in Christ. Paul expresses this same idea in Romans 6:8, where he says, "If we died with Christ,

we believe that we shall also live with him." In other words, in our life which is hidden in Christ we live together with Christ!

At this point it is important that we distinguish between two Greek words which are translated *life,* the word *"βιος"* refers to the *physical life* and that which is necessary to sustain it (Mark 12:44; 1 Tim. 2:2). When we died with Jesus Christ we *spiritually died* to the "βιος" life and all that is associated with it *as far as it being the object, aim, and purpose of our living* (cf. 2 Tim. 2:4; 1 John 2:16). As believers in our physical bodies we have *basic "βιος" life needs* and the Scripture holds family heads responsible to provide these basic requirements (cf. 1 Tim. 5:8). However, to make these things the object of our lives is *sin,* which we were supposed to have died to in our death with Jesus Christ (cf. Rom. 6:2).

Our life which has been hidden with Christ in God is "ζωη" life. This is the life that God the Father, Christ the Son, and believers have in common. In John 6:57, Jesus says, "Even as the Living *(~ων)* Father sent me, I also live (ζω) because of the Father, and the one eating me, that one shall live *(ζησει)* because of me." Furthermore, other passages make clear that Jesus Christ was the embodiment of this life. In John 1:4, we read, "in him was life In John 5:26, we read, "For even as the Father has life in himself, likewise also he gave to the Son to have life in himself." Over and over again John makes it clear that Jesus Christ distributes this life to those who believe on Him (John 3:15-16, 36). ALL believers have died to the *"βιος"* life, the old man, and to the body of sin (Rom. 6:6), and as they are raised they are *made alive with Christ* with the life (Rom. 6:8).

4. ***"Whenever Christ might appear, who is your life, then you also with him shall appear in glory."***

We feel that the Greek conjunction *"οταν"* is most accurately translated *whenever.* The thought is that when He appears, regardless of the specific time, something else is going to take place - their appearing with Him in glory. The translation *whenever* expresses most fully the idea of contingency inherent in *"οταν"* and obvious in the context. The verb translated "might appear" *(φανερωθη)* is an aorist subjunctive passive. The aorist tense indicates that Christ will come at a given *point in time.* The subjunctive mood indicates that the point in time He will come is *indefinite.* The passive voice indicates that *God the Father* will be the

one bringing about Christ's coming (cf. Matt. 24:36). As we follow the literal meaning of the Greek in this statement it is *quite indefinite* when it comes to the *time* of Christ's appearing, manifestation, or second coming (cf. 1 John 2:28).

The Person of Christ, who might appear at any time, is referred to as being *your life,* i.e., the life of the Colossians. An alternate reading, which is of comparable manuscript value, refers to Christ as being *our life.* Both translations add up to the same thing, namely, that *Christ is the life of all believers!* At a time when all men were dead in trespasses and sins, hopeless sinners in their very nature, God *loved* them, had *mercy* upon them, and extended His *grace* toward them in *giving them life together with Christ* (Eph. 2:1-5). It is impossible for us as believers to have "ζωη" life, the life of God, apart from a together-with-Christ relationship.

Whenever God the Father might cause Jesus Christ to appear; then we believers shall *appear with Him in glory.* The verb translated "shall appear" *(*φανερωθησεσθε*)* is a future passive, and the thought is that *whenever* Jesus Christ might be caused to appear, at that particular time we believers *shall be caused to appear* with Him in glory. Our appearing with Christ in gory is *contingent* upon the time -- whenever Christ appears. Furthermore, the passive voices indicate that the same God who *times* and *effects* Christ's appearing *will also effect our appearing with Nim in glory.* Observe, that even as we now *have life* (ζωη) in our with-Christ relationship; likewise in the future we *shall have glory* in our with-Christ relationship. The fact that we are *now living* is because of Christ, and the fact that we *shall he glorified* is because of Christ.

5. ***"Put to death therefore the members which are upon the earth, fornication, uncleanness, passion, evil desire, and covetousness, which is idolatry."***

Paul has already made it clear that as believers we have been spiritually identified with the death of Jesus Christ. Likewise, as believers we have been spiritually raised to a new life with Christ. The fact that we have spiritually died with Christ and are now alive with Him is the basis for Paul's plea: "Put to death therefore the members which are upon the earth."

The word translated "put to death" *(*νεκρωσατε*)* means *to kill, to mortify,* or *to destroy.* In as much as this verb is an aorist imperative it

is *a command* to once-and-for-all put to death, kill, and destroy the wayward members of the flesh-body. According to Romans 8:13, the practices of the body are to be put to death by the *power of the Holy Spirit.* Paul uses the word "members" (μελη) in this verse synonymously with the word "practices" (πραξεις) in Romans 8:13; therefore he is talking about putting to death *that which the members do and practice.*

The first thing to be put to death is "fornication" *(πορνειαν).* This involves *illicit sexual relations* between two unmarried persons, between one married and an unmarried person, or sometimes between two married persons. All such faulty relationships are unconditionally *condemned* by the Scriptures (cf. 1 Cor. 6:18; Eph. 5:3).

The second thing to be put to death is "uncleanness" *(ακαθαρσιαν).* Paul is using this word here with reference to *sexual uncleanness, impurity, lewdness,* and *immoral motives.* It is commonly associated with fornication (cf. Gal. 5:19; Eph. 5:3).

The third thing that is to be put to death is "passion" (παθος). It is a feeling which the mind suffers; hence *strong affection and longing* for something (in this case evil). This word is used three times in the New Testament and every time it is used in conjunction with evil, i.e., to be absorbed in an evil passion or desire (cf. Rom. 1:26; 1 Thess. 4:5).

The fourth thing that is to be put to death is "evil desire" *(επιθυμιαν κακην).* It literally speaks of that which the *heart is set upon.* When used with the word *evil* it speaks of a desiring, lusting, and wanting of that which is evil (cf. Eph. 4:22; Tit. 2:12).

The fifth thing that is to be put to death is "covetousness" (πλεονεξιαν). This word has the basic idea of *having more than another, to take advantage of another, to over-reach another,* or *to have an inordinate desire for money.* This is a sin that is strongly condemned in the Scriptures (cf. Rom. 1:29; Eph. 5:3). It is idolatry!

6. "because of these things the wrath of God is coming upon the sons of disobedience."

On account of the five things Paul has mentioned above, namely, fornication, uncleanness, passion, evil desire, and covetousness, Paul says that the wrath of God comes. The preposition "δια" is used

with the accusative here and expresses the idea of *cause,* which is commonly translated *because of* or *on account of.* Involvement in these sexual and greedy sins is the cause or reason for the wrath of God coming upon them.

The verb translated "is coming" *(*ερχεται*)* is in the present tense and is the strongest possible affirmation of God's wrath against those committing these sins. The implication of the present tense is that this wrath will *begin immediately* following the committal of these sins and *continue* to the final outpouring of God's wrath. Before one becomes engrossed in the sins of sex and greed he had better consider both the immediate and longrange sour-pill of Divine retribution!

The Greek word translated "wrath" (οργη) conveys the idea of a *mind-set against, indignation, punishment* and *anger.* The use of the genitive case indicates possession, i.e., it is wrath that belongs to God, God's anger and indignation against those practicing such sins. Those who are committing these sins are referred to as "the sons of disobedience." We must keep in mind that God has a standard by which His people are to live and failure to live according to this standard puts one in the category of a son of disobedience. Again we want to emphasize the fact that God's wrath and punishment is something that is taking its toll at the present time (cf. Rom. 1:18; Eph. 5:6). Also, in a consummating sense, God's final wrath will be poured out against all sinners at a given point of time in the future (cf. Rom. 2:5; 5:9).

7. ***"In which also you yourselves once walked when you were living in these things."***

This verse might also be translated, "Among *whom* also you yourselves once walked when you were living among these." The antecedent of the relative pronoun "οις" can be either *these sins,* and translated *which,* or it may be *those who have committed these sins,* namely, the sons of disobedience, and translated *whom.* We prefer to translate the pronoun "υμεις" as adding emphasis, i.e., in which you *yourselves* once walked. As those who have been identified with the death of Christ, they are now dead with Christ to those practices which are a part of their past life that is *never* to be repeated! In keeping with our two translations of this verse, we observe that the unsaved Gentiles wallow in the *same sins of the flesh* and *mutually reinforce* one another in their corruption. This is what takes place in

the world.

The time when the Colossians walked in these sins and lived among those practicing them was "when" (οτε) they *lived in them or among those practicing them.* The key word that we need to examine in the last part of this verse is translated "were living" (εζητε). It comes from "ζαω" which means *to live, to exercise the functions of life,* or *to have living vitality.* This word is commonly used to depict believers in their living relation with Jesus Christ (cf. Gal. 2:20). Obviously, this meaning does not fit this context, for Paul is speaking about a time prior to their coming to know Christ. The use of the imperfect tense takes us back to a time when they were *habitually practicing these sins* of the flesh (cf. Rom. 7:2; 8:13).

8. ***"But now you yourselves put off all things, anger, wrath, malice, slander and shameful speaking out of your mouth."***

The previous verb in verse 5 emphasized the fact that they were to put to death the things associated with their members upon the earth. The main verb in verse 8 emphasizes the need to "put off' *(αποθεσθε),* to *place from* or to *lay aside* all sinful characteristics. Paul goes on to mention five particular sins which are expressed through the language that comes out of their mouths. First, they are to put away "anger" *(οργην), violent emotional outbursts, temper tantrums* and *indignation.* There is a place for believers to be angry and indignant against sin according to Ephesians 4:26; however, what is said here condemns the *uncontrolled expression* of this anger.

Second, they are to put away "wrath" *(θυμον), a boiling tip,* and the tendency to become *enraged.* The two words for anger *"οργην"* and wrath *"θυμον"* are sometimes used synonymously. The former *(οργην)* is commonly associated with God in the Gospels and in Paul's epistles. The latter word *"θυμον"* has no association with God except in the Book of Revelation and this from the twelfth chapter on where God's wrath falls upon an unrepentant people.

Third, they are to put to death "malace" *(κακιαν), evil* and *wickedness.* In the light of the context we understand Paul to be telling them to lay aside malicious, evil, and wicked speaking.

Fourth, they are to put off "slander" *(βλασφημιαν), reviling,* and *blaspheming (cf.* Eph. 4:31). This is a language and mouth sin which

they are to lay aside.

Fifth, they are to put off "shameful speaking" *(αισχρολογιαν), vile, obscene,* and *foul talking.* We interpret the Greek phrase "out of your mouth" (εκ του στοματος υμων*)* as applying to all five of the foregoing sins. Paul is literally telling them to stop their angry, wrathful, malicious, slanderous and foul speaking.

9. "Do not lie to one another, having put off the old man with his practices,"

The Greek word translated "lie" (ψευδεσθε) conveys the idea of being *false or deceiving,* and we get our English word pseudo from it. Paul is telling them that as members of the Body of Christ they are not to be false and deceptive in their mutual relations with each other. The fact that Paul mentions this sin, and uses the reciprocal pronoun, suggests that Epaphras must have told Paul about some lying and deception in their midst. This prohibition is in keeping with the ninth commandment, "Thou shalt not bear false witness against thy neighbor" (Exod. 20:16).

The moral basis for Paul's plea that they not continue lying to one another is the fact that they have put off the old man. The Greek word translated "having put off" (απεκδυσαμενοι) is an aorist participle, and as such, it refers to that which took place *prior* to Paul's command. In other words, because they had died with Christ, and because their old man had been crucified with Christ; therefore Paul tells them not to lie to one another.

In Romans 6, Paul speaks of the old man as having been crucified; in this verse he speaks of the old man as having been put off; and in Ephesians 4:22, he commands believers to put off the old man. Ideally speaking the old man was crucified with Christ at Calvary, he is to be accounted as having been put off, but in actual practice Paul finds it necessary to continue commanding them to do what they should have done.

The phrase the "old man with his practices" suggests that the old man represents a given way of life, a sinful life style, of which lying and deception were a part. Here again we have a clear example of Paul's approach to morality. He never commanded or instructed anyone to live morally unless that person had first been identified with the death of Christ through faith.

10. ***"and having put on the new (man), which is being renewed unto a perfect knowledge after the image of Him who created him."***

In the previous verse we looked at the negative side of the transaction which is involved in a person's removal from Satan's domain and placement in the Body of Christ. The old man, fashioned after the image of Satan, is looked upon as one who has been crucified, put off, and no longer has right of expression. Paul looks at the total past life of the sinner, who has been saved, as having been *identified with the death of Christ* on Calvary. What the person was prior to being saved was nailed to the Cross with Christ (cf. 2:14).

If we interpret this to mean that the old man is passive and inactive in the lives of believers we exceedingly deceive ourselves. Believers have *two natures,* the old nature which is synonymous with the old man, and the new nature which is synonymous with the new man. Paul's instructions to put off the old man would be irrelevant if believers have only one nature (Eph. 4:22; cf. Rom. 13:12; Eph. 4:25).

Now let us turn our attention to the positive side of the transaction, when one is delivered out of death unto life in Christ. The Greek words translated "having put on the new" *(*ενδυσαμενοι τον νεον*),* in the light of the context, obviously speak of the new man in contrast to the old man. This is the only time Paul uses the Greek word "new" *(*νεον*)* to depict a new man.

He does use another Greek word for *new* (καινος) several times with reference to man as being a new creature or a new man. Observing some of these references we observe that the believer "in Christ is a new creature" (2 Cor. 5:17). In writing to the Galatians Paul says that the only thing that counts is a "new creature" (Gal. 6:15). In Ephesians 2:15, Paul uses the words "new man" with apparent reference to the Body of Christ. In Ephesians 4:24, believers are instructed to put on the "new man" which has the characteristics of God.

Paul makes a very important descriptive statement regarding the new man. It is in the process of continuously being renewed. The literal meaning of the Greek language used here indicates that the new man, as it relates to the individual believers, is in a state of continuous spiritual maturation and development. This implies that

the new man is closely associated with *the minds* of believers, for we cannot conceive of spiritual and intellectual growth apart from the mind. The Greek word translated "being renewed" (ανακαινουμενον) means to *make new again, to reinstate to a new condition,* or to *restore to an original or new position.* The use of the present tense indicates that this is *a continuous process* that begins when believers are saved and continues throughout their lifetime.

Now let us consider the nature of this renewal process, or the *end* and *goal* that God is trying to reach through this continuous renewing. First, observe that the use of the passive voice makes it clear that God the *Holy Spirit* is the one producing this spiritual renewing. The Spirit of God, through the use of the Word of God, daily seeks to mature the new man of believers. The use of the passive voice *excludes all self-effort;* the development of the new man is totally the work of God the Holy Spirit!

Second, this development is unto the end of perfect knowledge or perfect knowing that is according to the image of God who created the new man. Paul's use of the word "perfect knowledge" (επιγνωσιν) emphasizes the important place the mind plays in the maturity of the new mail. Furthermore, it is impossible to conceive of the Spirit of God maturing the new man in knowledge apart from the Word of God. In a parallel passage in Ephesians 4:24, we see the new man as one who has been created in “righteousness and holiness of the truth."

In the verse before us it seems that Paul may be taking us back to the original creation of man, when he makes the statement, "after the image of Him who created him." It is possible that the process of continuously renewing the new man has as its ultimate goal restoration to the state of his original creation, namely, one with a knowledge conforming to the image of the one who had created him. The main difference we would see between the new man and Adam and Eve would be that the new man, a part of God's sovereign purpose, Would *be confirmed* in "righteousness and holiness of the truth" (Eph. 4:24).

11. ***"Where one is not a Greek and a Jew, circumcision and uncircumcision, a barbarian, a Scythian, a slave, a free man, but Christ is all things and in all.”***

As we approach this verse our first question is what does the

word translated "where" (οπου) really mean? There is no question about tile meaning of this word; its prevalent use favors the translation *where.* In view of the context the *where,* the *place* that Paul has in mind, is obviously *the Body of Christ,* the Church. There is only one place where racial, national, social and economic distinctions are erased, and that is in the Body of Christ (cf. Rom. 1:14-16; 10:12-13: 1 Cor. 12:12-13; Gal. 3:27-29). As the Holy Spirit continuously matures the new man it is made to *conform to the image of God.* In the same manner the new man is the Body of Christ and is filled unto all the *fullness of God* (Eph. 3:19; cf. 1:23). It appears that being renewed unto the *knowledge of the image of God* and being filled with the *fullness of God* come together, join, and we synchronize in the *Body of Christ.*

In the Body of Christ there are no distinctions between a Greek and a Jew. The word translated "Greek" (Ελλην) basically speaks of one who was a Greek by race, a Gentile. Paul undoubtedly used this word to refer to all the Gentiles under the influence of Greek culture (cf. Acts 11:20; 14:1). Paul commonly used this word to include all races apart from the Jews (Acts 20:21; Rom. 3:9). Paul's main emphasis here is that there is *no distinction* between those he depicts as Greeks and the Jews, the descendants of Abraham (cf. Eph. 2:14-22).

Paul's statement that there is no difference between the circumcision and the uncircumcision is another way of saying that there is no difference between the Jews and the Gentiles. As a part of mystery truth the Gentiles were made equal with the Jews in the Body.

The barbarian looses his distinction in the Body of Christ. This word is used only six times in the New Testament. Those living on the Island of Melita were called barbarians (Acts 28:2). They were those who were not categorized as Greeks (Rom. 1:14). They were a people who lacked the ability to communicate in the common language (I Cor. 14:11).

The Scythian lost his racial identity in the Body of Christ. The Scythian was an inhabitant of Scythia, which is the land of modern Russia. They were looked upon as the wildest of the barbarians. The Holy Spirit amalgamated them into the Body of Christ.

There are no slave and free man distinctions in the Body of

Christ. All social and economic barriers are obliterated! They have a common Master, Christ (Eph. 6:8-9).

For believers who have their new man daily renewed by the Holy Spirit, through spending time in the Word of God, there are no racial, national, and cultural differences in the Body of Christ! ALL things and in all is Christ. In other words, the Person of Jesus Christ is the *all-important* one. He deserves the position of the *FIRST ONE* in our lives (Col. 1:18).

12. ***"Therefore as God's elect, holy and beloved, put on merciful compassion, kindness, humble thinking, meekness, longsuffering,"***

In translating this verse we have gathered the three words together, which constitute the subject, and placed them at the beginning according to common English practice. Paul addresses them as those who are elect, holy, and beloved ones. These words are nouns used as names that describe *what they were* in God's sight. These names were not given to them on the basis of what *they had done,* for the context makes it clear that they had many imperfections, but they were named on the basis of *what God had sovereignly done for them.* In essence they were God's *elect ones, holy ones, and beloved ones.*

First, in view of the current humanistic approach to the Scriptures we need to pay close attention to the exact meaning of the Greek word translated *election.* We must not underestimate the extent to which many of our minds have been subtly brainwashed in favor of humanism, and this diabolical thinking has consciously and unconsciously controlled our interpretation of the Word of God!

The word translated "elect" (εκλεκτοι) has its derivation from the preposition "εκ" and the verb "λεγω." As these two words combine, their basic meaning is to *speak out,* to *pick out,* to *choose,* or to *select.* The noun form of this word "εκλεκτος," which is arrived at in accordance with Greek grammar, refers to persons who have been spoken out, picked out, chosen, or selected. From the standpoint of both etymology and usage this word clearly means *elect ones.*

Let us briefly look at some passages in the New Testament in which this word is used. Jesus speaks about the small number called, "but the *elect ones* are few" (Matt. 20:16). Speaking regarding the

tribulation period, Jesus says, "Except the Lord shorten the days, no flesh would be saved, but on account of the *elect* whom He has elected (chosen) he will shorten the days" (Mark 13:20). Paul speaks of "enduring all things on account of the *elect,* in order that they might obtain the salvation in Christ Jesus" (2 Tim. 2:10). The call of the Gospel goes forth to all men, only the elect believe, those who were chosen in Christ before the creation of the world (cf. Eph. 1:4).

Second, Paul calls the Colossians *holy ones.* The word "holy" *(*αγιοι*)* speaks of those who have been *separated* from the common condition of the human race. Negatively, believers are separated from being dominated by Satan and those associated with him. Positively, believers are separated unto a position with Christ in the heavenlies and their lives are to be centered in Him (cf. 3:1-3; Eph. 2:5-6).

We need to carefully guard against a pseudo flesh-separation which is produced by the flesh, leaves *a void,* and makes a person vulnerable to the *terrible sin of spiritual pride* (cf. Luke 11:26). True Biblical separation has its origin in God, is produced by the Holy Spirit, and is seen in a *likeness to Christ,* the one to whom believers are separated (cf. Rom. 15:16).

Third, Paul calls the Colossians *beloved ones.* The significance of this name goes back to a proper understanding of the Greek grammar. The word translated "beloved" *(*ηγαπημενοι*)* is a perfect passive participle. The passive voice indicates that they were the *recipients* of the love of God. God was the one who had sovereignly extended His love toward them; they were the objects, beneficiaries, or those upon whom the love was bestowed. The perfect tense indicates that at a given point of time in the past God reached out to *make* them His beloved ones and He continues to *keep* them as His beloved ones.

Paul corroborates this same truth in Romans 5:5, where he says, "the love of God is poured out in our hearts through the Holy Spirit who has been given to us" (cf. Eph. 2:4). We have the same in First Thessalonians 1:4, where Paul says, "knowing, brethren, beloved ones by God, Your election" (cf. 2 Thess. 2:13). The preceding verse makes it clear that *because* they were elect and beloved ones they had accepted the Gospel in the power of the Spirit.

Now that we have considered *what* the Colossians were before God, what God had sovereignly made them to be, and its

ramifications for their life style, we need to took at some of the details. As those who are elect, holy, and beloved ones Paul commands them to "put on" (ενδυσασθε), *to put on as clothing (v.* 10), seven characteristics that are essential for happy fellowship in the Body of Christ. As those who have had bestowed upon them election, holiness, and God's sovereign love, they are now *responsible* to live lives which *conform to what God has made them* in Christ. The Gospel begins with making men *new creatures,* according to election, with the *characteristics of God* and in the *image of God (v.* 10). Because they are new creatures, and because they have been renewed in the knowledge of God's image, this is why Paul pleads with them to put on seven tremendous Christian characteristics.

First, they are to put on the characteristic of *merciful compassion.* Two Greek words are behind this translation, namely, *"*σπλαγχνα*,"* which literally means *a gut feeling or a feeling of tenderness;* and *"*οικτιρμου*,"* which basically has the idea of *pity* or *mercy.* This is the only time these two words are used in the New Testament with an interlocking meaning. They speak of the *tender pity* or the *compassionate mercy* believers are to display in their relations with others. These two each have their own separate meanings.

Second, they are to put on the characteristic of "kindness." This word comes from *"*χρηστοτετα*"* and has the idea of *providing that which is useful, necessary, and pertinent* for a person. It is commonly used to depict *God's kindness* in His rich provision for His children (cf. Eph. 2:7; Titus 3:4). It is listed as one of the fruits of the Spirit in Galatians 5:22. Believers are to put on this gracious characteristic, i.e., they are to show kindness through supplying that which is *useful* for spiritual and physical growth.

Third, they are to put on the characteristic of *humble thinking.* The Greek word used here comes from the two words "ταπεινος" and *"*φρην*"* which respectively mean that which is *low or humble* and the *mind or thinking* processes. They are to have *a humble, modest, and non-opinionated* mindset of themselves. Paul used this word to describe his own attitude as he ministered at Ephesus (Acts 20:19). We have an excellent commentary on the meaning of this word in Philippians 2:3, where Paul says, doing "nothing according to strife neither according to vainglory, but *in humble thinking counting one*

another superior to yourselves." The opposite of this is pride, an attitude of mental superiority, which must be put off.

Fourth, they are to put on the characteristic of "meekness." This word comes from *"πραυτητα"* and speaks of one who is *nonaggressive* in human relations; hence seems to convey an attitude *between meek and gentle,* perhaps closer to *mild.* It is one of the characteristics which Jesus Christ had (cf. 2 Cor. 10:1). It is one of the fruits of the Spirit listed in Galatians 5:23. It leaves *no room for* confrontation and clashes with others.

Fifth, they are to put on the characteristic of "longsuffering." The Greek word used here comes from the two words "μακρος" and "θυμος" which mean *long* and *passion or anger.* Believers are to be *a long time in coming to passion and anger;* hence they are to be *slow in getting passionate or angry.* They are to *put up with much* for a long time - not to loose their cool.

13. ***"supporting one another and forgiving yourselves, if anyone might have a complaint against anyone; even as also the Lord forgave you, so also you (forgive)."***

As we have previously observed Paul is dealing with seven things that believers are to put on. He listed five of these in the preceding verse, namely, mercy, compassion, kindness, humble thinking, meekness, and longsuffering. In this verse he lists the last two, namely, *supporting* one another and *forgiving* yourselves. It is important to observe that all seven of these things are *positive characteristics* according to the Greek text.

Contrary to the positive nature of this list some translators have used the negative word *forbearing,* and others have merely followed them, with respect to the sixth characteristic. This English translation comes across very negative to us, i.e., we as believers are to *put up with* one another, we are to *bear with* one another, etc. The negative spirit of this translation is very foreign to the Apostle Paul.

Sixth, Paul is telling them to put on the characteristic of *supporting* one another. The Greek word translated "supporting" *(ανεχομενοι)* is derived from the words "ανα" and "εχω," which combined have the basic idea of to *have or hold up, to uphold, to sustain,* and *to bolster.* There is a tremendous difference between

negatively forbearing one another and positively *holding up one another.* From the standpoint of both etymology and usage this word expresses the idea of holding up, supporting or sustaining.

In First Corinthians 4:12, Paul says, "being reviled we bless, being persecuted we *support,* being defamed we encourage." In this context Paul's reaction is the *opposite* of that which they have done to him. When they persecuted him he *bolstered* and *supported* them. This meaning perfectly fits the context. Likewise, in Ephesians 4:2, Paul says, "supporting one another in love," which is in perfect harmony with the surrounding positive context (cf. 2 Tim. 4:3; Heb. 13:22). As believers we have the mutual responsibility of holding up one another both spiritually and physically. It is thrilling to get back to just what the Word is saying on our responsibility to fellowbelievers. We don't walk alone, but we are to mutually sustain one another in the Lord!

Seventh, Paul tells the Colossians to put on the characteristics of *forgiving* themselves. The use of the subjunctive mood indicates that if anyone of them might have a "complaint" *(μομφην)* or grievance against another person the method used to solve it should be *forgiveness.* The use of the indefinite singular pronouns "τις" and *"τινα"* make it clear that Paul is referring to grievances between individuals.

The Greek word translated "forgiving" *(χαριζομενοι)* comes from the word "grace" (χαρις) with a verb ending added to it. It basically means to *show grace,* to *bestow grace upon,* or to *extend unmerited favor* upon sinners. The idea of extending grace naturally flows into the idea of forgiving. To be gracious to one who has a complaint or grievance is to forgive the complaint or grievance. Where there is grace plus sin there is forgiveness.

Paul's use of the nominative present participle in this verse is significant. Fiist, the nominative case puts the emphasis on the Colossian believers as the *subject.* Second, the participle brings the subject and action together in terms of persons who are doing the acting. As believers we are to be *showing grace ones* and *forgiving ones.* In essence and in person *we are to be* gracious and forgiving people. Third, the use of the present tense indicates that normal Christian living will *continuously involve giving grace* and *forgiving* (cf. Eph. 4:32).

Paul makes a very important statement in this verse that deals with the reason why believers are to forgive one another. He says, "even as also the Lord forgave you, so also you (forgive)." As Jesus sets forth the governing principles for the Kingdom in the Synoptic Gospels, He says: "If you forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you; but if you do not forgive men, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses" (Matt. 6:14-15). Jesus makes it very clear here that forgiveness in the Kingdom will depend upon forgiveness of one's fellowmen.

On the other hand, as Paul sets forth Jesus Christ's message for the Church (cf. Gal. 1:12), we are to forgive *because we have been forgiven.* In the same manner in which Christ forgave us and made us members of His Body; likewise we are to forgive others in this Church age. Kingdom law says forgive in order that you might be forgiven. Church grace says since you have been forgiven now you are to forgive. The competent Bible interpreter will carefully guard against confusing *legalistic Kingdom principles* with the *principles of Grace* that govern the Church!

14. ***"And upon all these things the love, which is the bond of perfection."***

Paul, having delineated the seven things that believers are to put on, now suggests that they put on top of all these *love.* The Greek preposition *"επι"* is used to describe what the relation of love is to be to the foregoing characteristics. Since the basic meaning of this preposition is *upon,* and this meaning blends in with the context, it appears that Paul was telling the Colossians to *place upon, to put upon,* or *to cap off* all the foregoing things with love. It is possible to emptily practice many admirable Christian characteristics, but unless one is motivated by love it is to no profit (cf. 1 Cor. 13:1-3; 2 Cor. 5:14).

Paul now goes on to declare that love is the bond of perfectness. The Greek word translated "bond" (συνδεσμος) comes from the two words *"συν"* and "δεω" and means to *bind with* or to *bind together.* Love is that which binds all the isolated parts into a perfectly synchronized whole. The word translated "perfectness" (τελειοτητος) expresses the idea of *completeness* or that which is *fully mature.* Love is the bond that *belongs to perfectness.* Love is that which binds together all the Christian attributes into a mature

new man being renewed according to the image of God (v. 10).

15. ***"And let the peace of Christ rule in your hearts, unto which also you were called in one body; and be you thankful."***

In writing to the Colossians Paul reminds them that they have put off the old man, and that they have put on the new man who is continuously being renewed. This involves putting on merciful compassion, kindness, humility, mildness, longsuffering, holding up one another, forgiving each other, and capping all these off with the binding cement of love. As we look back we see that Paul has laid a solid foundation for individual and corporate spirituality among the Colossian believers. Building upon this foundation, Paul now introduces another very important Christian attribute, namely, *peace.*

Paul has several things to say about the peace he is talking about. First, it is the peace of Christ, i.e., the peace that *belongs to Jesus Christ* (cf. John 14:27). Second, this peace is to have the dominant position of *ruling in their hearts.* Third, they have been *sovereignly called* unto this position of peace, not on the basis of their works, but by God's grace. Fourth, the sphere in which this peace is found is *the Body of Christ,* the Church, over which Jesus Christ is the *sole Head* and *Pastor.*

Since the word "peace" expresses the *craving* and *longing* of every human mind and heart, we want to examine very carefully just what Paul has to say on the Subject in this fifteenth verse. The Greek word translated "peace" *(*ειρηνη*)* conveys the idea of *freedom from conflict, a nonfrictional state, undisturbedness,* a state of quietness and tranquility and harmony. The specific peace that Paul is writing about is that which *belongs to Christ.* The use of the genitive case makes it clear that He is the *possessor,* the owner and the *Lord* of this peace. He alone owns it and He alone dispenses it to others (cf. John 14:27; Eph. 2:14). The peace of which Jesus Christ is the possessor and the dispenser is *based upon His death on Calvary's Cross.* Paul tells the Colossians that God the Father was pleased to reconcile all things unto Himself, "having made peace through the blood of his cross" (1:20; cf. Eph. 2:14).

Now that we have defined what this peace is and the fact that it belongs to Jesus Christ, let us consider how it affects the lives of

believers. Paul tells the Colossians that they are to let this peace *rule* in their hearts. The Greek word translated "rule" *(βραβευετω)* has the basic idea of *deciding between* contending forces in a game. The peace of Christ is the *subject,* that which acts as the *arbitrator* in the hearts of believers, and as such this peace *administers, governs,* and *directs* the hearts in accordance with the Word. Even as a referee or umpire is bound by the rules of the game; likewise the peace of Christ must govern according to the Divine rules for the Church.

In the next verse Paul specifically speaks about the need for the Word to richly indwell them. Paul's consistent use of the plural here suggests that in the background there was some disunity among the Colossians, there were some differences of opinion among them, and he is asking them to *submit their differences to arbitration by the peace of Christ.* We must keep in mind that peace is one of the fruits of the Spirit (Gal. 5:22); therefore the Spirit of God using the Word of God arbitrates peaceful relations in hearts of believers. In view of the language used we do not see the emphasis here on personal peace but on *mutual peace* between fellow-believers in the Body of Christ (Heb. 12:14; Rom. 14:19).

Paul tells the Colossian believers that they were *called unto peace.* Again, reminding them that they were called unto peace, he implies a lack of peace in their midst which he is endeavoring to correct. We need to consider this call in the light of God's total sovereign purpose. According to Romans 8:29-30, we have the following order: (1) foreknowledge (cf. Eph. 1:4), (2) foreordination, (3) the call, (4) justification, and (5) glorification. The call is made effectual by the Holy Spirit in the process of history.

The use of the passive voice and aorist tense makes it clear that these Colossian believers had nothing to do with their being called. God the Holy Spirit was the *active agent,* who a; a given point of time *called them to a position of justification in Christ,* and in due time will glorify them with Him. To the extent that the Colossians were believers Paul could speak of them as those who *had been called. In* other words, the fact that the Colossians were saved was *evidence* indicating that they were a part of God's total sovereign purpose (cf. 1 Cor 1:24, 26ff).

Having observed that the Colossians were called unto peace, let us now consider the *place* where this peace is found. Paul's

statement is that they were called unto peace "in one body" *(εν ενι σωματι).* Against a background of some disunity among the Colossians, Paul obviously selected the words "one body" *(ενι σωματι)* for their unifying impact. The preposition "in" (εν) is in the locative case, and as such indicates that the *location* of the peace is in the one body. Looking at the locative from another point of view, the peace of Christ is limited to the *sphere inside the Body of Christ.*

The fact that believers are called to peace is inseparable from the location of that peace, namely, inside the Body of Christ, the Church. The call to peace is not complete until believers end up in the Body of Christ with fellow-believers and in this position have mutual peace. Jews and Gentiles created into one new man, the Body of Christ are at peace with each other (Eph. 2:15). In Ephesians 4:3, Paul tells the Ephesians to be diligent "to keep the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace." The "bond" *(συνδεσμω),* that which binds together in peace, is the Body of Christ.

Having adequately dealt with the fact that they have been called to peace in the one Body of Christ, Paul now tells them to be *thankful.* The Greek word translated "thankful" *(ευχαριστοι)* is derived from the words "ευ" and "χαρις." It basically means *good grace,* i.e., *to give good grace,* to express *gratitude* and to be *thankful.* The present tense indicates that believers are to *continuously* be expressing an attitude of grace, gratefulness, gratitude, appreciation, and thankfulness to God (cf. Eph. 5:20).

"Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly, in all wisdom teaching and admonishing yourselves; with psalms, hymns, spiritual songs, singing with grace in your hearts to God."

Does Paul use the phrase *the Word of Christ as* comparable to the Word of God? In examining Paul's writings on this issue he commonly speaks of the Word of God. On several occasions he refers to the Word of the Lord, which could refer to either God the Father or the Son (cf. 1 Thess. 1:8; 4:15; 2 Thess. 3:1). In First Timothy 6:3, Paul refers to the sound *Words of our Lord Jesus Christ,* and (even) to teaching according to godliness. In Galatians 1:12, Paul affirms that he received his Gospel from Jesus Christ, i.e., it was indeed the *Word of the Lord* Jesus Christ. It appears to us that Paul uses the Word of Christ as *comparable* to the Word of God. The Word of God for the Church, which is God's program for today, has at

its heart the truth of the mystery which Paul received directly from Jesus Christ (Gal. 1:12; Col. 1:25-26), and it would be most logical to refer to it as the Word of Christ even as it is called the Gospel of Christ (cf. 2 Cor. 2:12; 10:14).

The relation between the Word of Christ and a given church, such as the church at Colossae, is subject to the spiritual status of the church. Paul commands them to "let the Word of Christ dwell in you richly." The Greek word translated "dwell in" *(ενοικειτω)* means to *live in,* to *make its home in* or to *inhabit.* Of course, Paul is talking about the Word of Christ being given access to live in believers and to *inhabit their minds.*

It is one thing for the Word of Christ to have a passive place in the minds of believers, but something distinctly different for the Word of Christ to *richly occupy* their minds. The Greek word translated "richly" (πλουσιως) speaks of the *lavish* and *abundant* provision God has made available to believers (cf. 1 Tim. 6:17; 2 Peter 1:11). It is impossible for the Word of Christ to richly, lavishly, and abundantly dwell in the minds of believers apart from the *Holy Spirit.*

In Titus 3:5-6, Paul speaks about the Holy Spirit being poured out *richly* (πλουσιως) upon believers. In Ephesians 5:18-19, Paul emphasizes the need for believers to be filled with the Spirit. Since the *result* of being filled with the Spirit is the *same as the result* of the Word of Christ dwelling in richly; therefore we conclude that the Holy Spirit is the one who *richly activates* the mind with the Word. The Word of God and the Spirit of God *complement* one another! The Word of God apart from the Spirit is *dead dogma;* likewise the Spirit of God apart from the Word of God leaves believers vulnerable to *lack of direction.*

Having commanded the Colossians to let the Word of Christ dwell in them richly, Paul now adds, "in all wisdom teaching and admonishing yourselves." The Greek phrase *"εν παση σοφια"* may be translated *in all wisdom,* i.e., in the locative case, or *by means of all wisdom,* i.e., in the instrumental case. Whether we interpret the emphasis to be in the sphere of all wisdom or by means of all wisdom, the important thing is that the *all wisdom* is the *message* or *that which is to be taught.* As we have already observed the Word of Christ constituted that *special revelation* of truth which Christ had given to the Church (cf. Gal 1:12). The phrase *all wisdom,* as Paul

uses it here, speaks of the same truth pertaining to the Body of Christ, the Church.

The word "wisdom" (σοφια) is a very special word in Paul's vocabulary. He uses it some twenty eight times in his epistles. His most common single use of it is with reference to the *mystery,* truth which had not previously been revealed, but was revealed to him for the Church (cf. Rom. 16:25-26). In writing to the church at Corinth Paul says: "But we speak a wisdom among the mature, a wisdom which is not of this age neither of the rulers of this age who are coming to nought; but we speak *a wisdom of God in a mystery,* that which has been hidden, which God foreordained before the ages unto our glory" (1 Cor. 2:6-7).

First, observe that Paul's wisdom message was *for the mature* in Christ. Second, it was a message which had *nothing to do with this godless age* and its rulers (2 Cor. 4:4). Third, it was a wisdom which *belonged* to God, that was God's possession. Fourth, it was a wisdom which *had been hidden* prior to the Apostle Paul. Fifth, it was a wisdom which had been foreordained before the creation of the world unto our glory. In short, this is the truth which Paul is instructing the Colossians to teach and admonish among themselves (cf. Eph. 1:8; 3:10).

Thus far we have been dealing with the *specific truth* that is to be taught in a local church. We have seen that this involves a special revelation of truth, which Paul calls the mystery, which was not revealed in the Old Testament. It is significant that Paul commands the Colossians to teach "all wisdom" *(*παση σοφια*)* and not just some or part of the wisdom for the Church. According to Paul's own account this is exactly what he did when he was at Ephesus, for he *did not shrink* from teaching them everything that was advantageous for them to know (Acts 20:20). In the 27th verse Paul makes an even stronger statement to the Ephesian elders, for he says, "Wherefore I bear witness to you on this very day that I am pure from the blood of all men, for I did not shrink from announcing all the counsel of God to you" (Acts 20:26-27).

Paul had a deep sense of responsibility to teach *all the truth of the mystery* to the believers of his day. His faithful teaching of all the mystery truth, which had been Divinely revealed unto him (cf. Gal. 1:12), caused him to be thrown into prison (cf. 4:3; Eph. 6:19-20).

Why are there so few today who are willing to identify themselves with Paul in teaching all the wisdom of the mystery? Is it because they are not willing to suffer with him for the mystery of the Gospel? God help us, above everything else, to faithfully and accurately teach the *Word of Christ, all the wisdom of the mystery,* to believers today, regardless of the cost!

The *method* the Colossians were to use to make known all the wisdom of the mystery was *teaching and admonishing.* Paul used these same two words "teaching" (διδασκοντες) and "admonishing" (νουθετουντες) as he endeavored to present every man mature in Christ (1:28). "Teaching" (διδασκοντες) is a more general communication of the truth, and in this case it is used of believers *mutually instructing one another* (cf. Eph. 4:11-16). "Admonishing" (νουθετουντες) means to *put in the mind* or to *warn,* and it may be used in a public sense or in a more private one-to-one setting (cf. Acts 20:31; Rom. 15:14; 2 Thess. 3:15). Even as Paul both publicly and privately taught the Gospel of God's Grace (cf. Acts 20:24; Col. 1:28-29); likewise all believers are to publicly and privately make known the truth of the Gospel through teaching, admonishing, and warning each other.

The use of the present participles makes it clear that believers are to *continuously* be teaching and admonishing "themselves" (εαυτους). Paul's use of the *plural* participles and the word "yourselves" (εαυτους) emphasizes the fact that not just one or two, but that *many of the believers* in a local assembly were to be doing this teaching and admonishing (cf. Eph. 4:12; 5:19). There is a direct *correlation* between learning and teaching. Believers who have an opportunity to teach in the local assembly will have *a greatly increased incentive* to learn! This *was the way* the New Testament churches worked.

Now that we have seen how the Holy Spirit causes the Word of Christ to *richly occupy the minds* of believers, and how that believers are to *continuously be involved in teaching and admonishing* themselves in all the wisdom of the mystery, let us turn our attention to another aspect of an assembly meeting. First, we need to acknowledge that there is *a break* between "teaching and admonishing yourselves" and "psalms, hymns, spiritual songs." Second, as this speaks of a typical meeting in a local assembly there

were three things that were to take place: (1) the Word of Christ was to dwell in them richly, (2) they were to teach and admonish themselves, and (3) they were to sing psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs.

The Greek word translated "psalms" (ψαλμοις) conveys the idea of *striking the chords of a stringed instrument;* hence *a psalm or a sacred song.* It is clearly used some four times in the New Testament with reference to the Psalms of David (cf. Luke 20:42; 24:44; Acts 1:20; 13:33). It is used three times in Paul's epistles, and in these instances it could refer to the Davidic Psalms or to Christian messages set to music.

The Greek word transliterated "hymns" (υμνοις) has the basic idea of *praise,* which in a Christian sense would be praise to God, Jesus Christ, etc. The Greek words translated "spiritual songs" (ωδαις πνευματικαις) convey the idea of *spiritual odes.* Since this was a common word for all kinds of songs, Paul defines what is acceptable as spiritual songs (cf. Eph. 5:19).

Having considered what they were to sing, such as psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs, let us now consider their mental and heart attitude toward God as they sang. First, their singing was to be "in the sphere of grace" (εν χαριτι*).* Grace here speaks of them freely and voluntarily *giving themselves* in worship and praise to God. Their singing grows out of an attitude of *gratitude toward God* for His unspeakable gift the Lord Jesus Christ (cf. 2 Cor. 9:15).

Not only was their singing to be a gracious expression of *gratefulness* and *thankfulness* to God but it was to be *in their hearts.* Out of hearts that were richly occupied with the Word of Christ, out of hearts that had not seen Christ but loved Him (cf. 1 Peter 1:8), there was to be a natural rising of *praise* and *thanksgiving* unto God (cf. Eph. 5:20).

17. ***"and everything whatever you do in word or in work, do all things in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him."***

The emphasis here is on believers having the correct attitude behind what they say and do. "Everything" *(παν), every single thing,* "whatever it is" *(ο τι εαν), regardless of what it might be,* believers should do it in a manner so as to give the Lord the credit and the

thanks. According to what Paul says here there are two ways in which believers express themselves. First, "in word" *(εν λογω),* i.e., *through what they say* in their private conversations with others, and *through public discourse* such as preaching, teaching, exhorting, and encouraging. Second, "in work" *(εν εργω),* i.e., *producing with their hands* that which is essential for the welfare of mankind, as well as *providing for the needs* of themselves and of others (Eph. 4:28; 2 Thess. 3:10-12).

Every individual thing (singular in the Greek) that believers say and do adds up to a sum total of many things; therefore Paul says "do all things (plural in the Greek) in the name of the Lord Jesus." The emphasis of the Greek language is that *every single thing* and *all things* are to be done in the name of the Lord Jesus. Paul leaves no room for believers to say or do a single thing which cannot be said or done in the name of the Lord Jesus. The application of this Christ-honoring principle should cause us to be slow and careful before we speak and act (cf. James 1:19). The supreme test is whether or not what we are about to say or do can be done in the name of the Lord Jesus (cf. Eph. 6:7).

Specifically, what does it mean to do all things in the name of the Lord Jesus? First, the words "in the name" *(εν ονοματι)* are in the locative case, and as such, convey the idea of in the sphere of or in the location of something. Second, the words "Lord Jesus" (κυριου Ιησου) are in the genitive case and indicate possession, belonging to, and ownership. The thought here is that *the name belongs to the Lord Jesus.* To do all things in the sphere of the name that belongs to the Lord Jesus appears to be synonymous with doing all things in the *sphere of the Lord Jesus* (cf. Eph. 5:20; Phil. 2:10). Stating what we have here in another way, they are to do all things in the one designated and entitled Lord Jesus, i.e., in His Person. His designation, title, and name is superior to that of every other being (Eph. 1:21).

Individually, every single thing believers say and do, and collectively, all things that believers say and do, are to be done in the name of the Lord Jesus. Having said this, Paul adds, "giving thanks to God the Father through him." Not only is everything we say and do to be identified with the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, which as we have seen is identification with His Person, but through Him we are to

continuously be giving thanks to God the Father.

As we have observed before the word translated "giving thanks" (ευχαριστουντες) expresses the idea of *giving good grace, of gratitude, and grateful appreciation to* God the Father. The picture we have here is that of believers prayerfully overflowing in gratitude toward God, and it is important that we observe that they express this gratitude to God the Father through the agency of Jesus Christ.

It is our conviction that in verses 16 and 17, Paul is giving us a brief sketch of how a meeting or service should be conducted in a local assembly (cf. Eph. 5:18-20). First, we are thrilled with the important place the *Word of God* is given: it is to richly dwell in all the believers. Second, it is exciting to see that the *wisdom of the mystery* is the basis of all teaching and admonishing of one another. Third, the content of the songs that are sung should have a *Scriptural message,* that which builds up believers, and exudes grace and praise to God. Fourth, everything that is said and done should be in accord with the *will of the Lord Jesus,* i.e., that which is in keeping with His perfect Person. Fifth, permeating all believers there should be a spirit of *continuous thanksgiving and gratefulness* to God the Father.

18. ***"Wives, be subject to the husbands, as is fitting in the Lord."***

The word translated "subject" *(*υποτασσεσθε*)* comes from the two Greek words "υπο" and *"*τασσω*,"* which respectively mean *under* and *arrange;* hence it has the idea to arrange under, to be subordinate, or to submit. It is significant that the middle voice is used here which means that the subject acts upon itself. Paul is speaking to the wives here, the subject of this verse, and he commands (imperative mood) them to arrange themselves under their husbands, to assume a subordinate position in relation to their husbands, and to submit themselves to their husbands.

It is of course understood that believing wives are not to arrange themselves under their husbands to do that which is contrary to the will of God (cf. Acts 4:19). Obedience to the Word of God takes precedence over obedience to another human being or human institution if there is a conflict between the two!

Having stated the fact that wives are to voluntarily subordinate themselves to their husbands, Paul adds, "as is fitting in the Lord."

The Greek word translated "fitting" *(ανηκεν)* comes from the two words *"ανα"* and "ηκω," which respectively mean up and *come;* therefore it has the basic meaning of *to come up to, that which is becoming,* or *what is proper and suitable.* The specific meaning of this word is determined by the phrase "in the Lord." Wives who are believers are to come up to the Lord's standard in their submissive relation to their husbands (cf. Eph. 5:24). Christian wives are to be governed by that which is becoming, proper, and suitable according to the Word of God and are not to be influenced by what is acceptable in this Satan dominated age (2 Cor. 4:4).

19. ***"Husbands, love the wives and do not be bitter against them."***

In view of the flippant way our English word "love" is used today, let us consider the meaning of the Greek word *"αγαπαω"* as it is used here and in the New Testament. First, there is a direct correlation between love and a willingness to *forgive* (cf. Luke 7:47). Second, love causes one to *give himself* for others to the point of death (cf. John 3:16). Third, true love is not something transient and changeable but *permanent* (cf. John 13:1). Fourth, love shows itself in *mercy* (Eph. 2:4). Fifth, love disciplines and *trains* a person to make him more like the Lord (Heb. 12:6). As we apply these meanings to the husband's relation to his wife we have something that is very tangible. Husbands who love their wives will always be ready to *forgive* them, to *give themselves* for them, to be steady and *unchangeable* in their love, to *show mercy* toward them, and to *help train* them to be more like the Lord.

Positively speaking, husbands are to love their wives; negatively speaking, husbands should "not be bitter against them." The word translated "bitter" *(πικραινεσθε)* most literally means *bitter, sour, and harsh.* According to Ephesians 4:31, there is no room for bitterness in the lives of believers. In Hebrews 12:15, the Hebrews are warned against a root of bitterness springing up in their midst. An attitude of bitterness tends to *destroy* both the one who harbors it as well as those against whom it is directed!

20. ***"Children, obey the parents in all things, for this is well-pleasing in the Lord."***

Having told the wives what their relation is to be to their husbands, and having told the husbands what their relation is to be to

their wives, Paul now proceeds to tell the children what their relation should be to parents. They are to give unreserved obedience in everything. The Greek word translated "obey" (υπακουετε) comes from the two words "υπο" and "ακουω," which mean *under* and *hear;* hence it means to *hear under, to hear submissively, to obey that which is heard, and to obey.* In usage this word involves two aspects, children are commanded to listen to what their parents say and to obey the same. Attentive listening is the initial part of the obedience process and discerning parents will take this into consideration in disciplining their children.

Now let us consider Paul's all-inclusive statement: "Children, obey the parents in all things." The Greek word translated "all things" *(παντα)* is an accusative plural and broad enough to encompass all things that the parents might say. Ultimately, the clear meaning is that children are to listen to and obey all instructions from their parents!

In Ephesians 6:1, Paul makes a similar statement, "Children, obey your parents in the Lord, for this is right." Here Paul specifically tells children to obey their Christian parents. Even though Paul does not add the words "in the Lord" in the verse before us; yet it is clearly understood that his instructions here are limited to Christian parents and the children in their homes. The scope of Paul's command is that children obey their parents who know the Lord, and the implication is that the parents are to require this obedience. Paul never instructs unsaved people how to live!

Having told the children to fully obey their parents, Paul adds a statement to support his instruction, "for this is well-pleasing in the Lord." The word "well-pleasing" (ευαρεστον) comes from the two Greek words "ευ" and *"αρεστος,"* and literally means *well* and *pleasing;* hence, the idea of *well-pleasing, very acceptable,* and *highly satisfactory.*

Observe that for children to obey their parents is well-pleasing and very acceptable "in the Lord" *(εν κυριω).* The phrase "in the Lord" is in the locative case and has the idea of *in the sphere of the Lord or in a position in the Lord.* It seems quite obvious that Paul is talking about parents and children who occupy a position in the Lord, are in the sphere of the Lord's family, and as such, the Lord is pleased to have the children obey their parents. In a parallel passage in Ephesians Paul uses the word "right" (δικειον) to express the same

idea, i.e., it is right and just before God for children to obey their parents (Eph. 6:1).

21. ***"Fathers, do not provoke your children, that they might not be discouraged."***

We have already considered the fact that children are to obey their parents, which means both their father and their mother. Now Paul goes on to caution fathers about maintaining a proper balance in dealing with their children, but he gives no such advice to the mothers. Why does Paul single out the fathers? Is it because they are more likely than mothers to lose their cool in dealing with the children? We suppose a case could be made for the mother's greater tenderness toward her children; hence the tendency to under discipline rather than over discipline.

In the light of the entire Scriptures we believe the reason Paul singles out the fathers is because they are *God's appointed heads* of their respective homes. As the head of the home they were directly responsible before the Lord for proper conduct in their home. This does not mean that the fathers were to personally do all the disciplining and training, but it does mean that they were responsible to see that it was done, whether through the mother or other qualified persons.

We recognize that some children can sorely test the patience of those who have the responsibility for their discipline. Paul lived and moved among parents and their children, and he had seen how exasperated some fathers had become with their unruly children. Some fathers had become extreme disciplinarians, not only themselves, but also required their wives and others responsible to exercise the same extreme measures of discipline on their children.

There is one thing that comes through clear and strong in all of Paul's epistles: he was not an extremist! He tenaciously held to the total truth of the Gospel of God's Grace which was revealed to him, but he never became imbalanced in nonessentials on either the right or the left (1 Cor. 14:40). In Philippians 4:5, he says, "Let your moderation (gentleness) be known to all men." As a man who hated fanatical extremism and who desired moderate justice for all members of the family, Paul warns against discipline that can cause psychological problems.

Now that we have laid some background for this verse, let us

consider exactly what Paul says. He uses the present tense and imperative mood to *order* the fathers not to continue provoking their children. The Greek word translated "provoke" *(ερεθιζετε)* means to *stir up, agitate, or irritate.* It may be used in a good sense regarding believers being stirred up to give liberally to the Lord's work (cf. 2 Cor. 9:2), or it may be used in a bad sense, such as in this verse, to depict a feeling of irritation and anger because one did not deserve the punishment he received.

There should be a correlation between the act of disobedience and the corrective punishment. Children raised under proper discipline will expect to receive punishment *commensurate* with their disobedience. When a small act of disobedience receives disproportionate, harsh punishment, children will feel that injustice has been done and they will be stirred up and agitated. Continuous over punishment usually calls forth a spirit of *giving up* or a spirit of *rebellion.*

The reason why Paul commands the fathers not to provoke their children is "that they might not be discouraged." The Greek word translated "discouraged" (αθυμωσιν*)* conveys the idea of *to lose heart, give up, or become despondent.* As we have already observed incommensurate severe punishment can produce the attitude that Paul is describing here. On the other hand, when children try to obey their parents, according to their understanding of what their parents want, and are constantly reprimanded for their efforts, this can cause children to give up trying to please them.

Perhaps one of the worst results of improper discipline is for children to develop the feeling that they can never do anything right. This negative self-evaluation can result from continuous parental reprimanding, inadequately interspersed with compliments, when the children do that which is pleasing to the Lord.

May our Lord give grace and wisdom to the head of every Christian home, and those associated with him, to have a balanced disciplinary program that will encourage, not discourage, the children to love Jesus Christ and to live for Him! The responsibility that rests upon the head of the Christian home is awesome, but let us keep clearly in mind, with the responsibility *the Lord gives the wisdom, patience, and balance* necessary for the most healthy spiritual, mental, and physical development of the children in the home (cf.

Phil. 4:13; 1 Cor. 10:13).

22. ***"Slaves, obey in everything the masters according to the flesh, not in eye-service, as men-pleasers, but in singleness of heart, fearing the Lord."***

It is interesting to observe the likeness between the terminology used here and in conjunction with the children. Even as the children were to "obey" *(υπακουετε)* their parents; likewise the slaves were to "obey" *(υπακουετε)* their earthly masters. Furthermore, as the children were to obey "in all things" *(κατα παντα);* likewise the slaves were to obey "in all things" *(κατα παντα).* We have already observed that the children were to be obedient to their parents in every single thing, i.e., total obedience. In exactly the same manner, slaves are to be obedient to their earthly masters in every single thing, i.e., total obedience. The only difference is that the children were to be obedient to their parents and the slaves were to be obedient to their earthly masters.

Keep in mind that the relation of children and slaves to their superiors was entirely different from the relation of wives to their husbands. As we have already observed wives were to be "arranged under" *(υποτασσεσθε),* second in command or subordinate to their husbands.

Paul specifically states that slaves are to obey their "masters according to the flesh." Since the Greek word *"κυριοις"* is used in the plural to designate masters and in the singular to designate Jesus Christ; therefore Paul felt that it was necessary to describe the earthly masters as being "according to the flesh" (κατα σαρκα*)* or in the flesh. During New Testament times a master and slave relation was a part of the economic structure. There were undoubtedly many reasons why a person would be in the slave category, such as subjugation resulting from war, indebtedness, voluntary submission in exchange for security, etc.

One of the best examples we have of this master-slave relation in the New Testament is that of Philemon and Onesimus (Philemon 1:1-22). The Gospel did not attack this master-slave relation as such, for this is not its purpose, but it endeavored to bring all men, regardless of their socio-economic status, into a saved relation to God (Luke 19:10; 1 Tim. 1:15). Slaves were not to be concerned about their

status, but if the opportunity to be free arose, Paul suggests that they make use of it (1 Cor. 7:21). The first priority for the Christian slave was to count his master worthy of all honor so that the name and teaching of God would not be blasphemed (1 Tim. 6:1).

Paul was well acquainted with the various ways slaves took advantage of their masters. In view of this he tells them their obedience is not to be "in eye-service, as men-pleasers." The Greek word translated "eye-service" (οφθαλμοδουλια) means *service rendered to please the eye,* i.e., serving faithfully while the master is watching. The Greek word translated "men-pleasers" *(*ανθροπαρεσκοι*)* defines the slave who works hard while his master is watching. He does not have a genuine interest in what he is doing, but is only interested in making a good impression when the master or overseer is present.

In Ephesians 6:6, Paul uses these same two words, and points out that instead of serving in this deceptive manner they should serve "as slaves of Christ doing the will of God from the soul." Paul pleads with every believer, regardless of his station in life, to be honest, faithful, and to work up to his full potential!

Instead of trying to put up a good front and please men, Paul exhorts them to be believers who "in singleness of heart, are fearing the Lord." The Greek word translated "singleness" *(*απλοτητι*)* has the basic idea of *single, attention directed toward one object, or focusing on a given Purpose.* The strong adversative "αλλα" emphasizes contrast between eye-service and singleness of heart. Paul is telling them that instead of putting up a false front before the eyes of men their heart should be singly focused on the Lord.

The Greek word translated "fearing" (φοβουμενοι) conveys the idea of being afraid of the judgment of the Lord against sin. On the other hand it has the idea of reverencing the Lord, of highly respecting the Lord, and of regarding His majestic Person with awe. In contrast to pleasing men they are to fear God's judgment against their disobedience, and they are to esteem Him with the highest reverential awe (cf. 1 Peter 2:17). The relation of Christian slaves to their masters was to be governed by their relation to the Lord. Slaves who had a single heart focused on the Lord, and who continuously feared the Lord, would meet Paul's qualifications for continuously obeying the Lord.

23. ***"Whatever you do, work it out of the soul, as to the Lord and not to men,"***

In this verse Paul continues to set forth the proper basis for motivating Christian slaves. The phrase "whatever you do" (ο εαν ποιητε*)* is in the subjunctive mood, the mood of probability, and it may be translated "whatever you might do." Again, this statement can be interpreted as being open-ended, i.e., inclusive enough to contain some evil doing with the good doing. The question is, however, not what is possible to crowd in under this statement, but what is Paul's intended meaning behind the language used?

In the light of the total teaching in Paul's epistles the "whatever" has to be limited to that which is good and acceptable according to Christian standards. In cases such as this Paul assumes that the master will not ask the Christian slave to do that which is evil, and that what the slave does will not be evil. Furthermore, it may be that the masters of the slaves in Colossae were all believers, and if so, we assume that they would ask their slaves to do only that which is good (cf. Col. 4:1). There is no justification for believing slaves to disobey God in order that they might obey their masters (cf. 2 Cor. 13:8; 10). Obedience to God always supersedes obedience to men and their laws (Acts 4:19; 12:6-17).

Whatever the believing slaves do they are to "work out of the soul." The Greek word translated "soul" (ψυχης) is the *seat of physical life;* it is that aspect of life that man has in *common with the animal world* and it might be identified with man's ego. Paul uses it here to represent man's deepest innermost being; the motivating center stimulating the slaves to do their work as to the Lord. The word "work" *(εργαζεσθε)* is well translated *energize* and *produce.* The present tense and imperative mood indicate that these slaves were commanded to continuously, out of the depth of their soul, obey their masters by working and producing as to the Lord.

Thus we see that as these slaves obeyed their masters, their motivation was to spring from their innermost being because their obedience was to be "as to the Lord and not to men." In the immediate situation these believing slaves were obeying the orders of their earthly masters; however, in the light of the larger God-man relation, they were really serving the Lord. As those who had been redeemed and purchased by the Blood of Christ, they are now slaves

of Christ together with Paul, and whatever they do they are to do heartily as Unto the Lord. The fact that they were temporarily slaves was incidental. The all-important thing was that they belonged to God, their bodies were the temple of the Holy Spirit, and zealously they were to energetically serve Him (1 Cor. 6:19-20).

24. ***"knowing that from the Lord you shall receive the reward of the inheritance; you serve the Lord Christ."***

In the previous verse Paul told them that whatever they do they were to eagerly work as to the Lord. In this verse Paul gives the reason why they were to directly serve the Lord, namely, because "the reward of the inheritance" will be received directly from the Lord. Paul's use of the participle "knowing" (ειδοτες) indicates that they have *prophetic knowledge of future rewards.* They looked forward to receiving a certain "reward" *(*ανταποδοσιν*),* which literally means *a repayment for what they had done, an equitable retribution, or a proper recompense.* This reward will be proportionate to what they have done (cf. 1 Cor. 3:12-15; 4:5).

Now that we have established the fact that they *knew* they had a reward waiting for them, let us now consider what this reward was. Paul speaks of it as the "reward of the inheritance" or, as the genitive case would imply, the reward that belongs to the inheritance or that is the inheritance. The word translated "inheritance" (κληρονομιας*),* as used here, speaks of that which is to be given to or received by believers.

In Acts 20:32, Paul says that God gives the inheritance "among (or with) all those who have been sanctified." We have this same thought in Ephesians 1:18, where Paul speaks of the "riches of the glory of his inheritance among (in or with) the saints." Grammatically speaking, these two verses can be equally well translated "among" or "in" those sanctified (locative case) or "with" the sanctified saints (dative case). These passages emphasize the truth that all believers have awaiting them a future inheritance.

Specifically, the believer's inheritance involves the *receiving of his glorified resurrection body* (Eph. 1:14; cf. 2 Cor. 1:22). In Ephesians 5:5, the implication is that all true believers have "inheritance in the kingdom of Christ and of God." According to Hebrews 9:15, those who have been called will receive "the eternal inheritance." In First Peter 1:4, Peter speaks of believers as having

been begotten "unto an incorruptible and undefiled and unfading inheritance, having been reserved in heaven for you." In summary, this inheritance *belongs to all saints;* it includes our *glorified bodies,* and it is referred to as the *kingdom of Christ, an eternal inheritance, that which is perfect and eternal in the heavens.*

In view of the fact that the Colossians were going to receive an inheritance as a reward from the Lord; therefore they were to render their service to the Lord. In the previous verse they were to render their service "as to the Lord" (ως τω κυριω), but in this verse there are no qualifiers, they' are to directly serve the Lord. It is very significant to observe that the name "Christ" is added to the word "Lord" in this verse. As we have already observed the word "Lord" (κυριος) is used in this verse with reference to both earthly lords or masters and also with reference to our Lord and Master, Jesus Christ.

Paul's argument here is that instead of being absorbed in their physical slave circumstances, grating and chafing in them, they need to have a proper spiritual orientation to the Lord, Christ. They need to recognize that Christ is truly the Lord and Master over their entire lives, and that lie is the one who will give them the true wages, recompense, and reward for what they do on earth!

25. ***"For the one doing wrong will receive back the wrong which he did, and there is no respect of persons."***

The word translated "the one doing wrong" (αδικων) is a present participle which speaks of one who continues to do that which is wrong. The basic meaning of this word depicts a person who persists in doing that which is unjust, unrighteous, or that which is opposite of what is right. Paul says that the one who continues in this course of action "will receive back" *(*κομισεται*), will have brought back,* and *will have conveyed again upon him* the wrong he has done.

Paul is here talking about God's sure retribution against all injustice and wrong that a slave might do against his master, and since this is disobedience before God, the Lord will punish according to the wrong which has been done. Paul is trying to make it clear to the believing slave that he can't get away with any wrongdoing before God. He might deceive his earthly master as an eye-service slave, but he can't deceive his supreme Master, Christ. He will be equitably punished for every act of injustice, unrighteousness, or that which is wrong.

Just in case any of the Colossians might have thought they had an inside track with God, Paul warns them that "there is no respect of persons" with the Lord. In Ephesians 6:9, Paul warns the masters that they had better treat their slaves right for there is no respect of persons with their Lord in the heavens. In Romans 2:11, the Jews are warned that there is no "respect of persons beside God." God judges all men equally in this present Church age irrespective of whether they are masters, slaves, Jews, or Gentiles. He does not "receive the face of any person" *(προσωπολημψια),* which is the basic meaning of this word.

CHAPTER 4

1. ***"Masters, provide that which is just and equitable to the slaves, knowing that you also have a Master in heaven."***

In terms of quantity, that which Paul had to say to the masters is brief in comparison to what he said to the slaves. The implication is that the Christian slaves had a difficult time being subservient to their masters, and Paul attempts to lift them to a spiritual dimension, the same dimension on which he operated, where all believers recognize that they are slaves of Christ.

Disobedience on the part of Christian slaves must have put the Christian masters in a difficult position, particularly, before their unsaved slaves. On the other hand, when Christian slaves were obedient, and unsaved slaves were disobedient, it would be very easy for the Christian master to show partiality, and even though he did not, to be criticized for this by his unsaved slaves.

We have translated the main verb of this verse "provide" (παρεχεσθε). It is derived from the two words *"παρα"* and "εχω," and means to *hold beside, to hold out to,* or *to offer.* The masters were to hold out to their slaves, i.e., they were to deal with them in a way that was just, right, and acceptable to God. Likewise, the masters were to treat their slaves equally, in an equitable manner, and in a fair impartial way. According to Ephesians 6:9, masters were not to use the principle of the "threat" in managing their slaves.

Paul reminds the Christian masters that they "have a Master *(*κυριον*)* in heaven." The implication is that they, too, with Paul were slaves of the Master, Christ, in heaven. The fact that they were slaves on this spiritual dimension, and had been mercifully treated by Christ, should stimulate them to show mercy toward their own slaves. Apart from the mercy of God in Christ they would still be lost and without hope (cf. Eph. 2:4).

2. ***"Continue in prayer, watching in it with thanksgiving;"***

Having completed his instructions to various groups in the Colossian church, Paul now turns his attention to the subject of prayer. They are to persistently continue in prayer. The Greek verb translated "continue" *(*προσκαρτερειτε) is derived from the words

"προς" and "καρτερεω," and means *to persevere or persist in a given course of action* (cf. Heb. 11:27). Believers are to persevere, persist, and to constantly be engaged in prayer. The use of the present tense further emphasizes continuous perseverance in prayer.

This word is used twice in the Book of Acts to explain their persistence in prayer. In Acts 1:14, Luke says, "These all were persevering with one accord in prayer." According to Acts 6:4, the Twelve Apostles said, "but we shall persevere in prayer and in the ministry of the word." In Romans 12:22, Paul instructs all believers to "continuously persevere in prayer." In all the above instances where this word is used in conjunction with prayer it is in the present tense and is most accurately translated *continuously persevering or persisting in prayer.*

In the light of all Paul's epistles and what he says about prayer, he obviously means that believers are to Continuously persevere in *a communicative prayer-mind-set* with God. Their *lines of communication are to be open* so as to moment by moment converse with the Father.

We must never conceive prayer as being primarily a time of asking but rather a time of *personally communicating* with God the Father, and involved in this is "watching . . .with thanksgiving." The Greek word translated "watching" *(γρηγορουντες)* means to be *awake, alert,* and *vigilant.* As a present participle it means that believers are to continuously be watching, on the alert, and vigilant in their prayer communication with God. We should be mentally and spiritually alert as we communicate with our majestic God and Father.

Thanksgiving ought to be one of the most important aspects of our prayer. The Greek word translated "thanksgiving" *(ευχαριστια),* as we have already observed, has the basic meaning of *good grace;* hence it has the idea of *gratitude, gratefulness,* and *appreciation.* God loves to hear His children express their gratitude, gratefulness, and appreciation for all that He has done for them. According to Ephesians 5:4, believers are not to waste their time in foolishly talking, "but rather in giving thanks." In Philippians 4:6, we are told to let our requests be known to God "with thanksgiving." May our Lord help us to mature in our appreciation of Himself, our omniscient and omnipotent God!

3. ***"praying also at the same time for us, that God might open***

to us a door for the word, to speak the mystery of Christ, on account of which also I have been bound,"

The thought that Paul is setting forth here is that "while they are praying" (προσευχομενοι), "at the same time" (αμα) he wants them to pray for him. In other words, Paul wants to be included in their continuous persevering in prayer. It is interesting to observe that Paul never asks for prayer that he might gratify the personal needs of his flesh. His requests for prayer are not subjective, for something centering in himself, but are always objective, that something beyond himself might be accomplished through him.

The ultimate purpose of Paul's request for prayer was that the Word, the truth for the Church, might go forth. He asks them to pray "in order that God might open to us a door for the word." The Greek word for "door" *(*θυραν*)* refers to an *opening, an entrance,* and sometimes *a gate* (cf. Mark 1:33). In Acts 14:27, while Paul was at Antioch of Syria, he says that God "opened to the Gentiles a door of faith." In this case the open door represents the removal of a barrier; hence an opportunity for the Gentiles to believe.

Also in First Corinthians 16:9, Paul speaks about a great door being opened to him in Ephesus, i.e., the barrier had been removed and he had a great opportunity to teach the Word. Even though in prison, a major barrier to the progress of the Word, Paul asks them to pray that barriers might be replaced by opportunities for the Word (2 Cor. 2:12). Paul recognized that God was the one who opens doors, who removes barriers, and who gives opportunities for the teaching of His Word (Acts 16:6-10). An open door can involve the opening up of a given area to the Word as well as opening individual hearts in the area to listen to the Word (Acts 16:14; cf. 13:48).

The object of Paul's request for prayer was the *Word, the mystery of Christ,* which he desired to speak through an open door. It is exceedingly important that we lay hold of the literal meaning of this verse; the Word of God for today, for this present Church age, *is the mystery of Christ.* The Word of God for the Jew who lived between Sinai and Calvary was the Mosaic Law. The Word of God for the Messianic Kingdom, which was rejected, but ultimately will be established, has its core in the Synoptic Gospels as well as the Old Testament. The Word of God for this present dispensation of grace, for the Body of Christ, the Church, is the truth of the mystery (cf.

Rom. 16:25-26).

Now let us consider briefly the essence of the mystery of Christ. First, it was truth which cannot be "searched or tracked out" *(*ανεξιχνιαστον*)* in the Old Testament, i.e., it was not revealed in the Old Testament (Eph. 3:8; cf. Rom. 11:25, 33). Second, it was "not made known to the sons of men" in previous generations (Eph. 3:5). Third, it had been kept silent through times eternal, i.e., it had never been talked about from the beginning of time (Rom. 16:25).

Fourth, it was revealed to and through the Apostle Paul by Jesus Christ through the Holy Spirit (1 Cor. 2:7-10; Gal 1:12). Fifth, the truth of the mystery constitutes Paul's Gospel, which he often refers to as *my Gospel* (Rom. 2:16; 16:25; 2 Tim. 2:8). Sixth, neither the Twelve Apostles nor any other human being *made any contribution* to the Gospel which was preached by Paul (Gal. 1:11-12; 16-17; 2:6).

Seventh, according to the Gospel of the mystery of Christ all believers are made members of the spiritual organism which is the Body of Christ, the Church (1 Cor. 12:12,27; Rom. 12:5). Eighth, Jesus Christ is the sole Head over this spiritual Body, which is referred to as His Body, the Church (Eph. 1:22-23; 5:23-32). Ninth, individual Gentiles have the same privilege as individual Jews to become members of this spiritual Body, the Church (Eph. 3:6; cf. Acts 13:46; 18:6). Tenth, those who believe in Jesus Christ are baptized into His spiritual Body by the Holy Spirit (1 Cor. 12:13; Gal 3:27).

As a result of teaching the Word, the mystery of Christ, truth pertaining to God's program and purpose of the Church, Paul ended up in prison. As he asks the Colossians to pray for him that he might have an open door "to speak the mystery of Christ," he adds, "on account of which also I have been bound" (Col. 4:3). In dealing with the mystery of the Gospel in Ephesians 6:19-20, Paul says, "on behalf of which I am an ambassador in a chain." It is very clear, Paul's bold proclamation of the *mystery of the Gospel* caused him to be bound and imprisoned. This truth is *God's Word for today!* It presents God's spiritual Church program for today! To teach it is to do God's will; therefore Satan persecutes even unto prison and death (cf. Phil. 1:17; Acts 21:31; 23:12).

4. "that I may make it clear as it is necessary for me to speak."

In the previous verse Paul asked the Colossian believers to pray that God would give him an opportunity to speak the mystery of Christ, that he might make it clear to others. The Greek word translated "make it clear" *(*φανερωσω) means to *bring to light, to manifest,* and *to make plain.* The clause emphasizes the fact that Paul's purpose was to speak the mystery of Christ in such a way as to make its meaning clear, plain, and understandable. Those who understand the mystery and literally teach it are aware of Satan's blinding tactics (cf. 2 Cor. 4:4) and can readily identify with Paul in needing prayer to make its meaning clear and obvious.

Making known the Gospel of the mystery was *a life and death issue* with the Apostle Paul. It was *necessary* for him to manifest it through bold, plain, and clear speaking that others would have an opportunity to know about it as well as to comprehend its contents. The Greek word which we have translated "necessary" (δει) basically means *necessary, must, needful,* and almost to the point of being imperative. We believe the translation "ought" is too weak, and fails to adequately express Paul's sense of responsibility to clearly set forth the mystery (cf. Eph. 3:9). May our Lord help us to *take His Word literally* and to recognize that it is *necessary and imperative* for us to clearly teach the mystery of Christ!

As members of the Body of Christ, the Church, we need to begin taking seriously what God says in His Word about the mystery of Christ. The responsibility rests upon us to accurately study the epistles of Paul in order *that we might know the truth of the mystery of Christ!* Furthermore, we need to assume our responsibility to clearly and plainly make this mystery truth known unto others. We need to identify with what Paul says in First Corinthians 9:16: "for necessity rests upon me; for woe is to me if I do not preach the gospel." The Gospel which Paul preached and the mystery of Christ are one; therefore woe *to us if we do not preach the Gospel revealed unto the Apostle Paul* (cf. Gal. 1:12; Eph. 3:2-4)!

5. ***"Walk in wisdom toward those outside, redeeming the time."***

Since Paul has been dealing with the subject of the mystery, which he often associates with the word "wisdom" *(*σοφια*)* in his epistles, it appears to us that the wisdom here may well be the revealed truth of the mystery. In as much as the mystery is revealed

knowledge pertaining to the Church, it is logical to refer to this knowledge as wisdom. In First Corinthians 2:7, Paul ties together wisdom and the mystery, for he says, "we speak the wisdom of God in *a mystery (*μυστηριω*),"* i.e., in the sphere of the mystery. The number of passages that combine the mystery and wisdom suggest a strong identification between the two, for at times they are apparently used interchangeably (cf. 1:26-28; 2:2-3; Eph. 1:8-9; 3:9-10).

In the light of our identification of wisdom with the mystery of Christ we feel that Paul is telling the Colossians to walk in keeping with the truth of the mystery before those outside. The Greek word translated "walk" *(*περιπατειτε) comes from two words, which combined literally mean to walk around; hence the idea is that they are to live and conduct themselves according to mystery wisdom or according to Church truth. The wisdom that belongs to the mystery has *only one thing to say to the person outside,* namely, "that Christ died for our sins according to the Scriptures" (1 Cor. 15:3).

God's sole interest in and desire for those outside is for them "to be saved and to come unto a perfect knowledge of the truth" (1 Tim. 2:4). In view of the wisdom of the mystery, we believers should sense our responsibility to share the Gospel of salvation with those outside, but we should not waste our time telling those who are "dead in trespasses and sins" (Eph. 2:1, 5) how to live. We need to recognize that those outside have one desperate need - to be "made alive together with Christ" (Eph. 2:5)!

The use of the word "outside" (εξω) implies that there is an inside. Paul uses this word some four times in this manner in his epistles (cf. 1 Cor. 5:12-13; 1 Thess. 4:12). It appears to us that Paul's point of reference for what is inside and outside is the *Body of Christ.* All believers have been baptized into the Body of Christ (1 Cor. 12:13); hence all have put on Christ and are in Christ (Gal. 3:27-28). The Body of Christ is at the heart of the truth of the mystery! It is God's haven for those who are His own in this dispensation of grace. Those who are in it are safe and secure for all eternity. Those who are outside the Body are without God, dead in their sin, without hope, and destined to eternal punishment.

As believers walk according to the truth of the mystery, realizing what it has to say about the plight of those outside of the Body of Christ, they will have a sense of urgency to redeem the time. The

word translated "redeem" (εξαγοραζομενοι), as used in this verse, means *to buy, acquire,* and *purchase* the time for sharing the Gospel with those outside. In Ephesians 5:16, believers are to be "redeeming the time, because the days are evil." Paul is literally telling us to buy up and utilize all time and opportunities to reach those outside - the lost - for Christ.

6. ***"Let your speech always be with grace, seasoned with salt, that you may know how it is necessary to answer each one."***

The Greek word translated "speech" (λογος) conveys the idea here that *believers' words, talk, and conversation* are to "always" *(παντοτε),* at all times, be in grace, i.e., in the sphere of grace. The word "grace" *(χαριτι)* suggests that all that believers say should *give help and contribute* to the spiritual needs of others. Certainly, the speech of believers should always be gracious, but Paul has something more in mind here. It should be in the sphere of the grace of God which is *giving and giving ourselves* to meet the needs of others. We give ourselves to the end of giving the lost the Gospel of salvation and of giving fellow-believers the Gospel of the mystery.

What does Paul mean when he says that what we say should be "seasoned with salt?" This is the only time Paul uses the word "salt" (αλας) in his epistles. Jesus speaks of His disciples as being the salt of the earth (Matt. 5:13). In Mark 9:50, Jesus says that "salt is good," and then He commands His disciples to "have salt in yourselves, and be at peace among yourselves" (cf. Luke 14:34). From these quotations it is obvious that salt represents an essential spiritual ingredient for those serving the Lord.

Since the phrase "seasoned with salt" is immediately followed by the words "that you may know how it is necessary to answer each one," the implication is that salt gives *variety and a keen spiritual edge* to witnessing for Christ. In verse 4, we saw that it was "necessary" (δει) for Paul to speak forth the mystery of Christ; likewise here we see that it is "necessary" (δει) for believers to know how to answer each individual. If believers are going to effectively serve Jesus Christ as evangelists to the lost and as teachers to the saved, *they need to accurately know the Gospel of the mystery.* They need to have answers from the Word of God, not canned, artificial testimonies!

7. ***"Tychicus will make known to you all things pertaining to me, the beloved brother and faithful minister and fellow slave in the Lord,"***

According to Acts 20:4, Tychicus was an *Asian.* In this verse he is associated with Trophimus who was an Ephesian (Acts 21:29). Since they are both referred to as "Asians" *(*Ασιανοι*),* and we know that Trophimus was from Ephesus, it is possible that Tychicus was also from Ephesus. Considering the length of time Paul spent in the city of Ephesus it is reasonable to think that some of his co-laborers may have come from there. In writing to the Ephesians Paul speaks of Tychicus as "the beloved brother and faithful minister in the Lord" (Eph. 6:21).

In writing to the Colossians in the verse before us Paul uses the same words to describe Tychicus as he did in writing to the Ephesians, with the additional description "a fellow slave" (συνδουλος). It is also possible that Tychicus may have been from Colossae, or one of the other Asian cities, and that he had become associated with Paul while he was in Ephesus. We must keep in mind that from Ephesus "all those dwelling in Asia heard the word of the Lord" (Acts 19:10, 26). Ephesus was the central hub from which Paul had evangelized Asia.

Paul describes Tychicus as being "the beloved brother" (αγαπητος αδελφος) here and in Ephesians. Every time the word "beloved" is used in the Synoptic Gospels it has direct or indirect *reference to Jesus Christ as the beloved Son of God.* It is used regarding those who are the *recipients of God's love* (Rom. 1:7). Paul uses it very commonly to designate those who are the *recipients of his own love,* i.e., those God is loving through him. Tychicus was a very special person whom Paul dearly loved.

Paul refers to Tychicus as being a "faithful minister" *(*πιστος διακονος) both here and in Ephesians. Paul speaks of Epaphras as also being a faithful minister of Christ (Col. 1:7). Faithfulness is a prime requisite for a gospel minister (1 Cor. 4:2). The evidence indicates that Tychicus was one of the few who *remained faithful* to Paul unto the end. Approximately five years after this epistle was written Paul sends faithful Tychicus to Ephesus (2 Tim. 4:12). Also, about this same time (66-67 A. D.) Paul plans to send either Artemas or Tychicus to replace Titus on the island of

Crete (Titus 3:12). It would have taken *a faithful minister* to replace a competent and experienced person like Titus.

Paul also describes Tychicus as being a "fellow slave" (συνδουλος). This literally means *a slave together with* or *one in bonds with.* Paul looked at himself as being *purchased, owned, and possessed by Jesus Christ* (cf. 1 Cor. 6:19-20); hence he consistently speaks of himself as a "slave" (δουλος). Like Paul, Tychicus had all the marks of one who was truly owned by Jesus Christ; therefore he is designated *a fellow slave with Paul.* This title is extended to only one other person, Epaphras, who was from Colossae (Col. 1:7).

Observe further that the *place* in which Tychicus was a "beloved brother and faithful minister and fellow slave" was "in the Lord" (εν κυριω). The use of the locative case makes it clear that Tychicus was these three things to Paul *in the sphere of the Lord,* in their *relationship in the Body of Christ,* and in their *mutual fellowship with Christ* (cf. 1 John 1:3). Paul and Tychicus were totally dependent upon the Lord for their *position in grace* before Him (Rom. 5:1-2). All that they *were* to one another was dependent upon the *past and present sovereign grace of God.*

Now that we have considered the subject and the actor in this verse, let us turn our attention to *what he was going to do.* Tychicus was going to "make known" *(γνωρισει), reveal,* and *declare* to the Colossians all the things *relating to, surrounding, and regarding (τα κατ' εμε παντα)* the Apostle Paul. This Greek phrase is an idiom and the general idea is that Tychicus would declare unto them all the *information, news,* and *things about Paul.* It may have been months or even years since the Colossians had direct information from Paul; therefore the news Tychicus was going to share with them would be extremely important.

8. ***"whom I have sent to you for this very purpose, that you may know the things concerning us and that he may encourage your hearts,"***

The two primary reasons for Paul sending Tychicus to them were: (1) that he might personally *give them the latest news* about Paul, and (2) that through teaching, that in which Paul was involved, the Gospel, *he might encourage their hearts.* Paul knew that the Colossian believers *were concerned* about his spiritual, emotional, and physical welfare. He deeply appreciated this concern and wanted

them *to know how things were going with him.* He was also concerned about their spiritual needs and desired to meet these through this epistle and through the ministry of Tychicus.

With respect to Tychicus, Paul says, "whom I have sent to you." Since Paul puts the word "sent" (επεμψα) in the aorist tense, *a past tense,* he is identifying himself with his readers *in time.* He would have written this epistle *weeks before* they received and read it. It appears that Paul must have sent this epistle, the one to the Ephesians, and the short one to Philemon *with Tychicus at this time.* This is in full accord with the almost identical statements about Tychicus in Ephesians 6:21-22, and what Paul says about having sent Onesimus back to Philemon at Colossae (Philemon 12).

The statement ¯That you may know the things concerning us" has *wide ramifications.* It would be very superficial to limit this statement to the physical aspects of Paul's life. In fact, Paul knew nothing about a life divided into physical and spiritual compartments. His total life - physical, emotional, intellectual, and spiritual - was *integrated around the Person of Jesus Christ!* To know the things concerning Paul would involve the *Gospel of the mystery which he taught* (1:25-26), *his uncompromising stand to teach what had been revealed to him* (Gal. 1:7-12), and *his readiness to sacrifice even unto prison and death to make this Gospel known* (4:3; Eph. 6:19-20; Acts 20:24).

As we have already observed, Paul's second purpose for sending Tychicus to them was that he might "encourage" (παρακαλεση) their hearts. This Greek word is also commonly translated *exhort* or *comfort.* ALL three of these words are accurate English equivalents, and which one to use in a given verse *depends upon the context.* The basic premise on which the meaning of this word rests is *instruction.* Encouragement, exhortation, and comfort are given to others *through instructing them* in the Word of God. Tychicus had the job of instructing the Colossians in the Gospel of the Grace of God. As a result of this teaching ministry those who needed encouragement would be *encouraged,* those who needed exhorting would be *exhorted,* and those who needed comforting would be *comforted.*

9. ***"with Onesimus, the faithful and beloved brother, who is one of you. They will make known to you all things happening here."***

Paul now informs the Colossians that Onesimus is going to

accompany Tychicus to Colossae. Paul had been instrumental in the salvation of Onesimus during his Roman imprisonment (Philemon 10). Onesimus had probably been thrown into prison in conjunction with his being a run-away slave or for some misdemeanor associated with it. Previously he had been *a useless slave,* but now that he is saved Paul considers him *very useful* (v. 11). Paul had developed a strong attachment to Onesimus and refers to him as his "deepest feelings" or "heart" *(σπλαγχνα;* Philemon 12). Paul asks Philemon to receive him "no longer as a slave but above a slave, as *a beloved brother"* (Philemon 16).

Paul refers to Onesimus as being "the faithful and beloved brother." The word "faithful" *(πιστω)* speaks of *one who can be trusted, relied upon,* and *depended upon to obey.* Faith in Jesus Christ is the basis for growth in faithfulness. Paul's very positive statements about Onesimus in his epistle to Philemon lead us to conclude that this man *must have been saved long enough to prove his faithfulness under testing* (cf. 1 Cor. 15:2). Furthermore, for Paul to have confidence in the faithfulness of Onesimus was to *breed faithfulness* - after all Paul had said about his faithfulness he *could not let him down.*

There is no doubt about Onesimus being *a beloved brother* to Paul. This is the same phrase as used with regard to Tychicus, and the thought is that Onesimus was the *recipient of Paul's love.* Paul looked on him as being his *spiritual child* (Philemon 10), and he loved him as his very own. He *wanted to keep Onesimus* with him to minister to him in prison, but legally he belonged to Philemon and had to be returned to him (Philemon 13-14). Paul's love for Onesimus is seen in his *readiness to assume any obligations* that Philemon might have against him (Philemon 18-19).

In speaking to the Colossians Paul says that Onesimus "is one of you." A very literal translation would be "who is out of you." The "you" *(υμων)* is in the plural, and it may represent all the Colossians, *all you who live at Colossae,* of which Onesimus was formerly a part. On the other hand, since Onesimus is now a believer, a part of the total Body of Christ, and at the same time a resident of Colossae, perhaps Paul is looking at him as being "out of" *the Body of Christ as manifested at Colossae.*

The statement, "They will make known to you all things happening

here" is similar to the statement in verse 8: "that you may know the things concerning us." According to verse 8, the full responsibility of relating the news about Paul rested on Tychicus; he is the sole spokesman mentioned. According to this verse both *Tychicus and Onesimus* have the responsibility of giving the Colossians the news about Paul. With both reporting all that they individually knew there would be *broader and more comprehensive news coverage.*

10. ***"Aristarchus my fellow prisoner salutes you, and Mark the cousin of Barnabas (concerning whom you received commandment, if he may come to you receive him),"***

Aristarchus sends his greetings to the Colossians through Paul. He was *a Macedonian* from the city of *Thessalonica* (Acts 19:29; 20:4; 27:2). He accompanied Paul from place to place as *a traveling companion* (Acts 19:29). He is with Paul as he writes this epistle and Paul refers to him as *a fellow worker* (Philemon 24). The references here and in Philemon are the *last two times* the name of Aristarchus is mentioned in the New Testament.

In the verse before us Paul refers to Aristarchus as a "fellow prisoner" (συναιχμαλωτος). This Greek word most literally means *a captive together with,* hence, *a fellow captive* or *a fellow prisoner.* The implication is that Aristarchus was in prison with the Apostle Paul. His imprisonment may have been imposed on him by Roman law or it may have been *voluntarily assumed* so he could minister to Paul's needs. In Romans 16:7, Paul says that Andronicus and Junias are fellow prisoners. According to Philemon 23, Epaphras was a fellow prisoner with Paul in prison when Paul was writing this epistle.

Mark also sends his greetings to the Colossians. He was *a cousin of Barnabas.* His *name was John* and he was *surnamed Mark* (Acts 12:12, 25). He defected on the first missionary journey at Perga and returned to Jerusalem (Acts 13:13). Paul's refusal to take him on the second missionary journey caused a rift between him and Barnabas (Acts 15:39). At this time Mark is *with Paul in Rome* and Paul refers to him as *a fellow worker* (Philemon 24).

Paul had *previously written* (aorist tense) to the Colossians and had *ordered them to receive Mark* if he might come to them. Prior to the time Paul was writing this epistle Mark had obviously been *fully restored to his favor.* In Second Timothy 4:11, Paul wants Mark to come to him, for he says, "he is *very useful* to me for the ministry."

The evidence indicates that when others were deserting Paul toward the end of his earthly ministry - *Mark remained faithful to him.*

11. ***"and Jesus who is called Justus, those being of the circumcision, these only are fellow workers unto the kingdom of God, who have been made a comfort to me."***

The phrase "and Jesus who is called Justus" is the *last item in the series* which began in the preceding verse. This series includes the names of *Aristarchus, Mark, and Justus.* Since the original name of the latter was "Jesus" (Ιουστος), which would have been very confusing, he was designated by the name "Justus" (Ιουστος). According to Acts 1:23, this was the *surname of Joseph,* one of the candidates for Judas Iscariot's position. According to Acts 18:7, the church at Corinth met in a house that belonged to a man by this same name, Titius Justus. Thus we see that the name which was given to this fellow worker of Paul was relatively common at that time.

With reference to the foregoing series of these three men, Aristarchus, Mark, and Justus, Paul speaks of them as "those being of the circumcision." We know, of course, that Mark was a Jew. As already observed, the two who were called by this same name were obviously Jews, which suggests that this was *a common Jewish name.* According to the information available to us in the New Testament we know that Aristarchus was from the city of Thessalonica which was located in the country of Macedonia. He has a *Greek name,* which could be common for a Jew under the influence of Hellenistic culture. He was probably a Jew who had formerly attended the synagogue in Thessalonica (cf. Acts 17:4).

What Paul says here is *a clear declaration* that all three of these men were Jews. If we had no other information than this statement, it would settle the issue - *they were Jews.* When the Holy Spirit states a fact one time in the Scriptures *it is as true as if it had been stated one hundred times!*

With reference to the three Jews mentioned in verse 10, Paul says that "these only are fellow workers unto the kingdom of God." First, observe that Paul designates these three men as "fellow workers" *(*συνεργοι*;* cf. Philemon 24). Second, their laboring is *unto* the kingdom of God. The preposition "εις" used with the accusative case may be literally translated *"unto the end* of the kingdom of God." A literal interpretation of this would be *unto the furtherance and*

building up of the kingdom.

Third, Paul's statement "these *only* are fellow workers" limits the number of Jews helping him to the above three. The Greek word translated "only" *(μονοι)* is equivalent to the English words *alone, by themselves,* and *without help from others.* As far as Paul was concerned these three men *without help from other* Jews, by themselves, and alone sought to further the kingdom of God. The word "kingdom" *(βασιλειαν)* is apparently used here with reference to the Body of Christ, the Church (cf. 1:13). It appears that the strong opposition of the Asian Jews (Acts 21:27) may well have caused some believing Jews to defect from Paul.

It certainly *was not easy for Paul* to see his own people, the Jewish converts, drawing back and failing to stand with him in the front lines for the advancement of the Gospel. Against the background of those who did not dare to stand with him, these three faithful Christian Jews *were all the more precious to him.* Paul says these (plural) "have been made a comfort to me." The word translated "comfort" *(παρηγορια)* has the idea of *exhortation, consolation,* and *solace.*

When Paul may have tended to become discouraged on the basis of the response of his own Jewish people, he was *exhorted, consoled, and comforted* by the steadfastness of these three faithful Jews, namely, Aristarchus, Mark, and Justus. The use of the passive voice suggests that *God had made these men a comfort to Paul.* When things get rough and it seems like the roof is going to cave in. *God is always there* with His one, two, or three precious saints to sustain and comfort!

12. ***"Epaphras, who is one of you, a slave of Christ Jesus, salutes you, always striving for you in the prayers, that you may stand perfect and fully assured in all the will of God."***

Epaphras stands out in the epistle to the Colossians as a very important person, *the main link between Paul and the Colossian church.* He was apparently the key person who had originally preached the Gospel unto the Colossians (1:7). He was the one who had gone to Rome and who had *informed Paul about the conditions in Colossae,* how the believers were doing and of the undermining heresies of legalism and gnosticism (1:8).

In writing to the Colossians Paul says that Epaphras "is one of you." The most literal translation would be that he is "one out of you" (ο εξ υμων*).* The use of the preposition "εξ" with the ablative case indicates that Colossae was the *source and place from which Epaphras had come.* This could entail the fact that he was a native Colossian in the broader sense of the word "you" *(*υμων*),* or more particularly that he was a part of the Body of Christ as manifested in the city of Colossae. The important thing is that *he was a part of the Colossian church,* had a genuine concern for them, and he takes this occasion to send them his greetings.

Furthermore, Paul says that Epaphras is "a slave of Christ Jesus." Here again, as we have observed before, the Greek word "δουλος" used with the genitive case speaks of Epaphras as being *owned and possessed by Jesus Christ.* The idea of *belonging to Christ* is most accurately expressed by the use of our English word *slave* and it should be *consistently* translated in this manner (cf. Rom. 6:16; 1 Cor. 7:21-22).

Paul gives us a glimpse into the *deep spiritual nature of Epaphras* through his statement to the Colossians: he is "always striving for you in the prayers." The word translated "striving" *(*αγωνιζομενος*)* more literally means *struggling, contending,* and *agonizing.* Our English word *agonize* is a transliteration of this Greek word. The use of this word certainly depicts Epaphras as almost *contending with God on behalf of* (υπερ) the Colossians. This great struggling, striving, and agonizing for them in prayer implies the *seriousness of their sin in turning away* from the truth of the Gospel of Christ.

The fact that Epaphras was "always" *(*παντοτε*), at all times, and every time possible* striving in prayer for them must have been against a background of *great spiritual need.* Observe further that Epaphras was striving "in the prayers." First, the word *his* is not in the Greek text. Second, the word *prayers is in the plural.* The strong implication is that every *time* Epaphras prayed, every time he gave himself to a *time of prayer,* he strivingly prayed for the Colossians. Some or all of these times of prayer could have been *together with Paul,* times when they jointly prayed; hence the literal translation is *the prayers* and *not his prayers.*

We have already suggested some of the dire problems in the

background that spurred Epaphras to struggle in prayer for them. Now let us turn our attention to the positive side, to the *specific purpose* which he desired to accomplish through prayer. Briefly, he prayed that *God would establish them as perfect ones and fully assured ones* in His will.

First, we will consider the Greek phrase translated "that you may stand" *(ινα σταθητε).* This verb is an aorist passive and means that you may be caused or *made to stand,* that you may be *made to stand fast,* or that you may be established. The passive voice makes it clear that *one outside of themselves produces this standing.* God the Holy Spirit is the *only one* who can *enable* believers to stand as perfect and fully assured ones!

Second, the Greek word translated "perfect" (τελειοι) conveys the idea of that which is *brought to completion,* that which is *fully developed,* hence that which is *mature, complete,* and *perfect.* In Matthew 5:48, it is used of God. According to Paul's epistles it is God's will that all believers be *perfect in their daily lives* (cf. Eph. 4:13; Col. 1:28). Paul's desire here is that the Colossians may be brought to a place of *maturity,* to a position of *full development,* and *completeness in knowing and doing the will of God!* This has reference to *God's perfect goal for believers* and nothing is said about the degree to which they attain this goal.

Third, the Greek word translated "fully assured" (πεπληροφορημενοι) is a perfect participle and would be better translated "having been fully assured," having been *carried through to the end,* hence having been *fully convinced, persuaded, and assured.* Paul wants the Colossians to stand as *those who are perfect ones* and as *those who have been fully convinced and persuaded, hence assured ones* in the total will of God. Paul wants them to *know and have full confidence* in the will of God.

13. ***"For I bear witness to him that he has much labor on behalf of you and those in Laodicea and those in Hierapolis."***

Paul now adds his own personal testimony regarding Epaphras. He was continuously involved in much "labor" *(πονον), anguish,* and *pain* "on behalf of" (υπερ) all the believers in Colossae, Laodicea, and Hierapolis. Not only was Epaphras agonizing for the Colossians in prayer, as we have observed in the previous verse, but here we have added the fact that he was anguishingly laboring also for those in

Laodicea and Hierapolis. This statement suggests that Epaphras probably had an important part in both the starting and ongoing of all three of these churches.

The cities of Colossae, Laodicea, and Hierapolis were located relatively close together in the Lycus Valley. Colossae was the farthest south, Laodicea was northwest of it, and Hierapolis was primarily north of the latter. Laodicea is mentioned four times in this epistle. John mentions it two times in the Book of Revelation. As John writes to the church there some thirty years later he describes it as being lukewarm and indifferent (Rev. 3:16).

This is the only time the city of Hierapolis is mentioned in the New Testament. The name comes from the combining of the two Greek words "ιερος" and "πολις," which literally mean *a holy or divine city.* It is probable that this name was originally given to this city because it was the center of some pagan temple, shrine, or deity. Granting that this was true, it meant that the Gospel had penetrated another stronghold of Satan (cf. Acts 19:23-27).

14. ***"Luke the beloved physician and Demas salute you."***

Paul briefly mentions to the Colossians that both Luke and Demas also send greetings to them. What do we know about Luke? His name is found only *three times* in the text of the New Testament. In the verse before us he is referred to as a "beloved" *(αγαπητος)* "physician" *(ιατρος).* He was a doctor, one involved in bringing about healing, who was the recipient of Paul's love and concern, i.e., there was a close filial bond between Paul and Luke.

In writing to Philemon at the same time as he writes to the Colossians, Paul refers to Luke as one of his "fellow workers" *(συνεργοι).* We would interpret this to mean that Luke had labored together with Paul in all his missionary travels and that he was now working with him in prison in Rome (cf. Philemon 24). It is generally understood that Luke was the one who wrote the Gospel of Luke, the Book of Acts, and probably served as Paul's secretary in the writing of many of his epistles (cf. 2 Thess. 3:17; Gal. 6:11; 1 Cor. 16:21).

Some six years later, when many of those who had been associated with Paul had either left him or were involved in the Lord's work in other areas, Luke is still faithfully working with Paul. In writing to Timothy, Paul says, "Luke only is with me" (2 Tim. 4:11). ALL the

evidence indicates that Luke was *a well educated person,* probably in a sense Paul's personal physician; yet the few times that his name is mentioned suggests that he was a humble man. In other words, Luke seems to have combined scholarship, as observed in his *masterful handling of the Greek Language,* with a non-self-exalting humility (cf. Luke 1:1-4; Acts 1:1-2).

The other person who sends greetings to the Colossians is Demas. When Paul was in prison the first time at Rome, Demas is referred to in the same manner as Luke, as one of his *fellow workers* (Philemon 24). Some six years later, however, Demas is spoken of as having "forsaken" (εγκατελιπεν) Paul. This word literally means that Demas had *let Paul down* in a given place, i.e., he had apparently *abandoned him* during the second imprisonment (2 Tim. 4:10). The reason Demas deserted Paul was because he "had loved the present age."

15. ***"Salute the brethren in Laodicea, and Nympha and the church in her house."***

With the previous verse Paul completed the list of those sending greetings from Rome to Colossae. He now instructs the Colossian believers to convey his greetings to the brethren in Laodicea. The distance between these two cities was approximately ten miles. The implication is that there was a very close relationship between the believers in these two sister cities. They knew nothing of ugly sectarianism that contradicts the unity of the Spirit in the visible Church.

The Colossians were also to greet Nympha and the church which met in her house. Since there is textual uncertainty in the latter part of this verse some translations refer to the church as meeting in "her house," "his house," and "their house." The textual evidence favors the *feminine proper name "*Νυμφαν*"* which would logically be followed by the *feminine* possessive pronoun "αυτης." Paul is telling the Colossians to greet both the Laodicean woman, Nympha, and the church that meets in *her home.*

Observe that Paul is sending his greetings to the *brethren, Nympha,* and *the church* in Colossae. It appears that the "brethren" (αδελφους) may represent a larger group of believers in Laodicea, and that Nympha and the church in her house may represent a smaller segment. On the other hand, the word "brethren" could

represent those who were leaders in the Lord's work in Laodicea (cf. 1:2). Whatever the case, the Laodicean church may have met as one or more groups, but according to the next verse it is looked at as *a single church.*

16. ***"And when the epistle has been read among you, cause that also it be read in the church of the Laodiceans, and that you also read the epistle from Laodicea."***

Paul expects this epistle which he is writing to the Colossians to be *publicly read* to all the Colossian believers. This is the *first thing* that he instructs them to do. Second, he commands the Colossians to see *to it* that this epistle is read in the church of the Laodiceans. Third, he instructs them to read the epistle which he had written to the Laodiceans which he refers to as "the epistle from Laodicea." The important thing to observe is that Paul wants *all the epistles* he had written to these two churches to be *publicly read to all the believers* in both churches. This is in accord with his emphasis on *literally teaching the Word* (cf. 1:28; 1 Tim. 4:11; 6:2).

17. ***"And say to Archippus, Take heed to the ministry which you have received in the Lord, that you fulfill it."***

Archippus is mentioned only twice in the New Testament. Paul addresses him as *a fellow soldier* in his epistle to Philemon (v. 2). In the verse before us Paul says that he is *responsible to fulfill a ministry* which he has received in or by means of the Lord. Archippus was apparently *a teaching elder* in the Colossian church who needed to be *stirred up* to do a more effective job of teaching.

18. "The salutation in my hand, Paul. Remember my bonds. Grace be with you."

Paul apparently took the quill and personally wrote the final greeting as *a mark of the genuineness* of this epistle. He uses this identical phrase, "the salutation in my hand, Paul," in writing to both the Corinthians and Thessalonians (1 Cor. 16:21; 2 Thess. 3:17). In writing to the Thessalonians, referring to his handwriting, he says, "which is a sign (σημειον) in every epistle," i.e., it is that which identifies the epistles with Paul (2 Thess. 3:17; cf. Philemon 19).

In making the statement, "remember my bonds," Paul is urging them to remember his plight in prison. For them to reflect on his imprisonment was to reflect on the reason he was in prison - because

of his bold *preaching of the Gospel of the mystery* (Eph. 6:19-20; Col. 4:3-4; 2 Tim. 2:9). Furthermore, Paul may be using the word "remember" (μνημονευετε) with the idea of *remembering him in prayer* (cf. Eph. 6:18-19; Col. 4:2-3).

Paul's closing words, "grace be with you," are common in all of his epistles in various forms. This is the briefest form that he uses (cf. 1 Tim. 6:21; 2 Tim. 4:22). The next shortest form is "grace be with all of you" (Titus 3:15; Heb. 13:25). The most used form includes the name of Jesus or Jesus Christ, for example, "the grace of our Lord Jesus be with you" (Rom. 16:20; cf. 1 Cor. 16:23; Gal. 6:18). Paul's final desire for them is that God will give them grace through Jesus Christ, the full expression of the grace of God (John 1:17).

INTRODUCTION

In our introduction to this short epistle we want to consider three practical aspects which will help us better understand its contents. First, we want to consider the *purpose* Paul desired to accomplish in writing to Philemon. Second, we'll consider some of the most *significant truths* taught in this epistle. Third, we will regard the questions: *when* was it written, and what is its relation to the other prison epistles?

PURPOSE

The overall purpose of this epistle is to *plead the case of Onesimus* (10). Everything that Paul writes is geared to winning this case. Things which may seem like extraneous details on the surface are important *parts of a whole* persuasive plan to gently lead the mind of Philemon into submission to the mind of Christ.

Now that we understand Paul's main purpose, let us consider the sub-purposes involved in it. First, in order to get Philemon's mind to conform to his request, Paul had to lay *a psychological bridge* between himself and Philemon. He does this by expressing his *praise and appreciation* for Philemon's love and faithfulness toward both Christ and fellow believers and for his spiritual refreshing of the saints (4-7).

Second, in fulfilling his purpose Paul points out that the short time Onesimus had been gone as a runaway slave was not necessarily all bad (15). The more important thing is the *change that had been wrought* in him during this time. The short time of separation is insignificant in the view of the fact that Philemon will now *have him forever!*

Third, in fulfilling his purpose Paul encourages Philemon to take a new attitude toward Onesimus. He is to look at him as *a "beloved brother"* instead of a slave (16).

Fourth, in fulfilling his purpose Paul asks Philemon to express the same *warm fellowship* toward Onesimus that he would give to him (17). The fellowship, sharing, and all things common that Philemon had with Paul should be given to Onesimus.

Fifth, in fulfilling his purpose Paul tells Philemon that if Onesimus owed him anything that he would *personally repay it* (18-19). At the same time Paul subtly reminds Philemon that he owes himself to him (Paul).

Sixth, in fulfilling his purpose Paul makes it clear that *his joy* is dependent upon Philemon doing what is right by Onesimus (20). Philemon certainly wouldn't want to be guilty of robbing Paul of his joy in the Lord.

Seventh, in fulfilling his purpose Paul tells Philemon that lie is *confident* he will do even more than what he has asked (21). It is not likely that Philemon will prove himself unworthy of the confidence Paul has placed in him.

Eighth, in fulfilling his purpose Paul tells Philemon that he *expects to come to Colossae soon* and that he should have the guest room ready for him (22). Philemon would certainly not want Paul to find him mistreating Onesimus when he comes.

SIGNIFICANT TRUTHS

First, all thanksgiving and prayer should be *addressed to God the Father (4).* There is no precedent for directing prayer to Jesus Christ.

Second, believers are to have *love and faithfulness* toward both Jesus Christ and their fellow believers. The Greek word *"πιστιν"* is most accurately translated *faithfulness* in this verse (5).

Third, *faithfulness needs to be directed* in channels that are according to the absolute Word of God (6). Faithfulness in that which is good requires the Divine standard for determining what is good.

Fourth, instead of commanding and compelling Philemon to do that which is right, Paul *encourages* him to do it (8-9). Law works on the basis of force and, compulsion; grace works on the basis of encouraging and urging.

Fifth, the Gospel has the power to make a useless person very *useful (11).* Apart from Christ man is disoriented, disintegrated, and useless to God; in Christ man is oriented and integrated around his Creator and is useful to God.

Sixth, the doing of good, obedience to God's Word, should spring from *a free spontaneous desire* and should not be the result of pressure and coercion. Paul refused to coerce Philemon to do that

which was right.

Seventh, Paul *rejected squeeze tactics* as a legitimate means for reaching spiritual ends (13-14). He repudiates the practice of putting one into a spiritual corner!

Ninth, to tell a person that you are *confident that he will obey* a given truth of the Word of God is to *propel him forward in that obedience (21).* Paul commonly used this principle to accelerate obedience among believers.

Eighth, Paul leaves no *room* for Christian masters to have Christian slaves. The only relation he acknowledges between believers to a *"beloved brother" relation (16).*

DATE OF WRITING

This is the shortest of the four epistles Paul wrote while he was in prison in Rome. The similarity between Ephesians and Colossians suggests that they were probably written about the same time. The evidence indicates that *Tychicus* was the one who had the responsibility of delivering these epistles to both Ephesus and Colossae (cf. Eph. 6:21-22; Col. 4:7-8).

It is clear that Paul sent Onesimus back to Colossae with Tychicus (Col. 4:9). They both had the responsibility of giving the Colossians the news about Paul's circumstances in prison (Col. 4:9). All facts indicate that the Epistle to Philemon was written at about the same time as the Epistle to the Colossians. It was obviously delivered to Philemon by Tychicus and Onesimus at the same time they delivered the Colossian epistle. It was probably written during the first half of Paul's Roman imprisonment, approximately A. D. 60.

PHILEMON

1. ***"Paul, a prisoner of Christ Jesus, and Timothy the brother, to Philemon our beloved and fellow worker"***

Paul is the writer of this epistle. He also associates Timothy with himself as in Philippians and Colossians (Phil. 1:1; Col. 1:1). He addresses the epistle to Philemon, a Colossian, in whose house a church met.

First, let us take a look at the writer, Paul. His original name was Saul (Acts 7:58). He was born in the city of Tarsus in Cilicia (Acts 22:3). He was brought up and educated in Jerusalem at the feet of Gamaliel (Acts 22:3). He was a Jew, an Israelite, a Hebrew, and of the tribe of Benjamin (Acts 22:3; Phil. 3:5). In strict accordance with the Law he was circumcised on the eighth day, and he was a Pharisee (Phil. 3:5). As a Pharisee he violently persecuted the early disciples (Acts 9:1-2).

Paul was miraculously confronted by Jesus Christ on the Damascus Road, saved by grace, and commissioned to go to the Gentiles (Acts 9:419; cf. 22:6-16; 26:12-18; 1 Tim. 1:15-16). His early ministry was rejected by the Jews both in Damascus and in Jerusalem; they were determined to kill him (Acts 9:20-23, 29-30). He spent three years after his conversion in Arabia, Damascus, Jerusalem, Tarsus, and in unknown parts in relative seclusion (Gal. 1:16-18). Apparently during this time the Lord was revealing to Paul the great truth of salvation by grace through faith and incipient truth pertaining to the mystery (Gal. 1:12).

There was another period of fourteen years in Paul's life oil which we don't have much information (Gal. 2:1). We do know that during part of this time he was associated with the church at Antioch in Syria. During this same period he and Barnabas went on the first missionary journey to the Galatian country. It appears, however, that during the first part of these years he may well have spent a great deal of time in relative seclusion in Tarsus (Acts 11:22-26). *Time* must have been an exceedingly important ingredient as the Lord reoriented Paul and prepared him to preach and teach the *Gospel of the mystery!*

Second, at the time Paul is writing this epistle he says that he is a "prisoner" (δεσμιος), literally one bound with a cord, chain, etc. We know that there were times when Paul was actually bound with chains (Acts 21:33), or by some other means (Acts 26:29), but in Rome the imprisonment itself may have been the bonds (Acts 28:30-31).

Further, Paul says that he was a prisoner of Jesus Christ. The genitive of possession indicates that he was a prisoner who *belonged to Jesus Christ.* It was Paul's relation to Jesus Christ, the fact that he belonged to Jesus Christ, that got him into trouble and caused him to be put in prison.

The thing that caused Paul more trouble than everything else was the *message which he proclaimed* (2 Tim. 2:8-9). Furthermore, since this message was *given to him by Jesus Christ,* the only way he could have stayed out of prison would have been by not preaching it. The particular message that brought the wrath of the religionists down on him was the *mystery.* He asks the Ephesians to pray for him that he might open his mouth and "boldly make known the mystery of the gospel *on behalf of which I am an ambassador in a chain,* that in it I might speak boldly as it is necessary for me to speak" (Eph. 6:19-20).

In writing to the Colossians Paul also attributes his imprisonment to his message, the *mystery of Christ.* He asks them to be "praying always also concerning us, that God may open to us a door of the word, to speak the mystery of Christ, *on account of which also I have been bound,* that I may manifest it as it is necessary for me to speak" (Col. 4:3-4). These passages certainly make it clear that Paul was in prison *for faithfully teaching the message of the mystery* which Jesus Christ had revealed unto him (cf. Gal. 1:12; Eph. 3:2-11). He was indeed a prisoner on *account of Christ,* hence, one who *belonged to Christ.*

Third, Paul mentions Timothy as being associated with him at this time. We have already observed that Paul specifically mentions Timothy in all the prison epistles except Ephesians. It is possible that Ephesians was *written first* of the three epistles (Ephesians, Colossians, and Philippians), and at this particular time Timothy was off on a given assignment for the Apostle Paul. On the other hand, there may have been some local situation at Ephesus, such as a

personality conflict, which caused Paul to feel that it was inadvisable to mention his name.

There was no one who was closer to the heart of Paul than Timothy. Paul chose him as a fellow worker when he was still a young man (Acts 16:1-3). He had been personally trained by the Apostle Paul. He was *well balanced* in the Lord. He was concerned about the *whole man,* both physical and spiritual needs. In commending him to the Philippians, Paul says, "For I have *no one of equal-soul* who is genuinely anxious for the things concerning you, for all seek their own things, not the things of Christ" (Phil. 2:20-21). The implication is that Timothy's primary concern was the things of Christ and this involved the things of others, their spiritual and physical welfare.

Fourth, Paul addresses this epistle to Philemon. This is the only time this proper name is used in the New Testament. Paul speaks of him here as being one who was "beloved" (αγαπητω), i.e., he was one who had gained his respect and was *a recipient of his love.* Also, Paul speaks of him as being a "fellow worker" (συνεργω). This indicates that Philemon was *actively engaged* with Paul in making known the Gospel of the Grace of God. We know that a church was meeting in his house (v. 2) which would in itself suggest very active participation in the work of the Gospel.

It is obvious that Philemon lived in Colossae. He had apparently gone to Ephesus during the time Paul was there and had come to know Christ. He, together with Epaphras and perhaps others, was undoubtedly responsible for beginning and carrying on the church at Colossae. Paul speaks of his love and *faithfulness* toward all the saints (v. 5), of his *refreshing* the saints spiritually (v. 7), and was counting on his *prayers* to make a future visit to Colossae possible (v. 21).

2. ***"and to Apphia the sister, and to Archippus our fellow soldier, and to the church in your house:"***

The second person Paul addresses this epistle to is Apphia. This is the only time her name is mentioned in the New Testament. Paul refers to her as "the sister" (τη αδελφη), which is probably to be understood in a spiritual sense, i.e., as *a sister in the Body of Christ.* Considering the immediate context it is logical to think that Apphia may have been the wife of Philemon or a prominent woman in the

Colossian church. It is also possible that another church may have met in her home as we have in Nympha's home in Laodicea (Col. 4:15).

The third person Paul addresses this epistle to is Archippus. His name is mentioned only two times in the New Testament. Paul refers to him as being a "fellow soldier" *(συστρατιωτη).* This word conveys the idea of one who is *joined in battle with,* a fellow combatant, and a co-militant. The only other time it is used in the New Testament is with reference to Epaphroditus (Phil. 2:25). Its use may well depict Archippus' *readiness to do spiritual battle* for the Lord, i.e., a tendency to be over-aggressive, or it may describe him as one who *had gone through unavoidable battles* for the Lord.

Fourth, Paul addresses this epistle to the church meeting in Philemon's house. If Philemon was a prominent person in Colossae, which he may well have been, it is logical to think that he may have had a large house. This being the case his house may well have accommodated a considerable number of people. In other words, it may have been an ideal meeting place for the early Colossian believers.

On the other hand, we must keep in mind that *more than one house* may have been used for all the believers in Colossae. There would be *one church* which consisted of all the Colossian believers but *one or more meeting places.*

3. ***"Grace and peace to you from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ."***

Paul uses the words "grace" (χαρις) and "peace" *(ειρηνη)* in the introductions in thirteen of his epistles. This certainly establishes the fact that this was *a common formula* used by Paul to greet those to whom he was writing. There is no justification for giving these words a specific meaning in any particular epistle. They represent a *general greeting* applicable to all believers. In writing to Timothy Paul adds the word "mercy" (ελεος), giving it a particular significance in relation to Timothy (1 Tim. 1:2; 2 Tim. 1:2).

The full formula that Paul uses here is the *same* as that used in the majority of his epistles, namely, "Grace and peace to you from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ." The preposition "from" (απο) has the idea of that which *comes forth from,* that which is

derived from, or that which has its *origin from* God as in this context. Paul associates "grace" with both God the Father and God the Son, however, *most consistently with God the Father* (Rom. 15:15; 1 Cor. 15:10). In general we think of God the Father as the one *from whom* the grace comes forth and Jesus Christ as the one *through whom* the grace is expressed (Rom. 5:15; 7:25). He is the very *manifestation* of the grace of God (John 1:14).

As we examine the Scriptures we observe that "peace" is *associated with both* God the Father and God the Son, Jesus Christ. Paul refers to God as "the God of peace" (Rom. 15:33; 16:20; 1 Thess. 5:23). He refers to Jesus Christ as "our peace" (Eph. 2:14). He speaks of "the peace of Christ" that is to rule in the hearts of believers (Col. 3:15). Paul makes it clear that the only way men can have peace with God is *through the agency* of Jesus Christ (Rom. 5:1). Again we observe, God the Father is the *author* and originator of peace, Jesus Christ has made this peace *available* to believers through His *death* on the cross (Col. 1:20), and it is *communicated* to believers through the Holy Spirit (Gal. 5:22).

Thus we see that it is *impossible to separate* the grace that originates with God from the expression of that grace, the coming into this world of the incarnate Son of God, Jesus Christ. Likewise, it is impossible to separate the peace that *originates with God* from the death of Jesus Christ that *provides the basis* for giving it unto men. Truly, the grace and the peace are from both God the Father and God the Son!

4. "I thank my God always, making mention of you in my prayers,"

The word translated "I thank" *(ευχαριστω)* means to *have good grace,* to be *grateful,* and to *express appreciation* to God. Everything that a believer *is* and *does* that is good or right is the *work of God* and thanks and gratitude should be expressed to God for it. The present tense suggests that Paul was continuously thanking God for what He had done in Philemon's life. This is emphasized further through the use of the adverb "always" *(παντοτε)* which literally means *all the time.* Paul was incessantly telling his *personal God,* to whom he refers as "my God," how much he appreciated what He was doing for his good friend Philemon.

This verse makes it clear that Paul prayed for *specific individuals.*

He tells Philemon that he personally mentions his name every time he prays. Likewise, Jesus prayed for Peter's faith (Luke 22:32). Since the word translated "prayers" *(προσευχων)* is in the *plural,* Paul is saying that when he has a *time of prayer,* which could be once or several times a day, he thanks God for what He has *already done* through Philemon and he prays that in the future he *might do that which is right.*

5. ***"hearing of your love and the faithfulness which you have toward the Lord Jesus and unto all the saints,"***

Paul speaks here of having *heard* that Philemon was exercising two important Christian characteristics. According to Colossians 1:8, Paul had obviously learned about Philemon through *Epaphras.* He was from Colossae, Philemon's home town, and was not with Paul in Rome (Col. 4:12). Paul refers to him as "a faithful minister of Christ on behalf of" them and as his "beloved fellow slave" (Col. 1:7). As Paul writes he speaks of Epaphras as being a fellow captive (συναιχμαλωτος) with himself in Rome (Philemon 23).

The first fruit of the Spirit that was evident in Philemon's life was "love" (αγαπην). This love was a *tangible characteristic* that Epaphras was able to observe in Philemon's attitude and conduct. Paul defines this love as that which spiritually *edifies* and builds up fellow believers (1 Cor. 8:1). Where this love is present a person *does not get angry fast* but is kind (1 Cor. 13:4). True love motivates believers to *serve one another* (Gal. 5:13). Epaphras had seen Philemon helping believers to mature in Christ, he had seen him maligned and provoked without getting angry, and he had seen him stoop to serve other believers. As Epaphras informed Paul about Philemon's life-style, Paul describes it as *love* toward Christ and all the saints.

The second fruit of the Spirit that was evident in Philemon's conduct was "faithfulness" *(πιστιν).* The most common English equivalent for this word is "faith." It is very obvious, the Greek writers of the New Testament used the word *"πιστις"* with *both* the idea of "faith" and "faithfulness" (Rom. 3:3; Gal. 5:22; Tit. 2:10). Genuine faith in Christ will result in faithfulness to Christ!

A dichotomy between faith and faithfulness was *foreign* to the Biblical Greek mind. These two were parts of a whole. Faith identifies one with *reality in Christ* and faithfulness is the *expression* of that reality. Philemon's abstract faith in Christ was verified by his

faithfulness to Christ and to all the saints (Titus 1:16; 1 Cor. 15:2).

The emphasis in this verse is obviously on *what* Philemon's faith in Christ produced, that which Epaphras could *actually see,* namely, edifying others, not becoming angry, being kind, and serving others. Since Philemon's attitude and actions were the *manifestations of love;* thus Paul speaks of his love toward Christ and all the saints. Also, since Philemon faithfully obeyed Christ and was faithful in his relations with all of the saints; thus Paul knew that he had true faith in Christ that produces faithfulness.

6. "that the fellowship of your faith may produce in a perfect knowledge of all good that is in us unto Christ."

Paul here expresses the purpose of his prayer, i.e., that the "fellowship" *(κοινωνια), sharing,* and *partnership* of Philemon's faith (faithfulness) may produce good that will exalt Christ. The word translated "faith" *(πιστεως),* as we have already observed, may also be translated "faithfulness" in this verse. Paul is praying that Philemon's faith in Christ may "produce" *(ενεργης), energize, work, and effect* the good thing that he wants Philemon to do, i.e., that he might be faithful.

It is Paul's desire that Philemon's faithfulness may be in the sphere of a "perfect knowledge" *(επιγνωσει), complete knowledge,* and *mature knowledge* of everything that is good. The specific good thing that Paul wants Philemon to do is to *receive back* Onesimus as a "beloved brother" (v. 16).

It is important to observe that Paul desires Philemon's faith to produce that which is right in the sphere of a *perfect knowledge of everything that is good.* Before Philemon could do that which is good he needed *a standard* by which he could measure and determine good from evil. The immediate issue at stake is *how* should a Christian master treat a Christian slave. Paul wrote this epistle to Philemon in order that he might have *a perfect knowledge of God's standard* pertaining to the issue of slavery.

Now let us examine the statement, "a perfect knowledge of all good that is in us." The textual evidence is in favor of the reading "in us" *(εν ημιν)* instead of "in you." Paul was endeavoring to set God's standard before Philemon and to work out a God-pleasing basis on which he was to receive Onesimus back. *Both* Paul and Philemon

were involved in uniting Onesimus with his master. Paul had the responsibility of *setting forth* God's "perfect knowledge" standard for this reunion and Philemon had the responsibility of *acting* according to God's standard. In view of the mutual responsibility the "us" reading makes good sense.

The phrase "unto Christ" *(εις Χριστον)* must not be slighted as meaning only "in Christ." The preposition "εις" used with the accusative case conveys the idea of *unto the end of Christ.* Paul's prayer is that Philemon and Onesimus might be united on the basis of the knowledge of God's standard, which having been accomplished will be *unto the end of the glory of Christ.*

7. ***"For I have much joy and encouragement based on your love, because the hearts of the saints have been refreshed through you, brother."***

This verse revolves around Philemon's "love" *(αγαπη).* As Paul reflects back he thinks of how much "joy" (χαραν), *gladness,* and *happiness* Philemon's love had given him. Also, Paul remembers the many times he had been "encouraged" *(παρακλησιν)* and *comforted* by Philemon's love. The verb "have" (εσχον) is in the aorist tense, which suggests that in the *past* Paul had experienced this joy and encouragement *on the basis of (επι)* the love of Philemon. Paul may be referring back to some *previous time* when he was encouraged by Philemon's love toward the saints, or he may be speaking of his reaction *when Epaphras more recently reported* how much Philemon loved the saints.

As we have previously observed, Paul saw Philemon's love *for the saints* in that which he *did on behalf of the saints.* Philemon "had refreshed" (αναπεπαυται), caused to *pause,* give *rest* to, and set at *ease* the hearts of the saints. When the saints in Colossae were under severe tension and pressure from false teachers and the enemies of the Gospel, Philemon had put them at *ease* and *rest* in the Lord.

The Greek word translated "hearts" *(σπλαγχνα)* literally means the intestines, viscera, and bowels. Metaphorically, it speaks of the *deep internal feeling in the pit of the stomach* that one experiences under shock and extreme distress. It is commonly called a "gut feeling." The implication is that in the midst of emergencies, and

possibly the death of loved ones, Philemon was there to help carry the burden and *ease the pain* and suffering. His actions showed how much he loved the fellow saints in Colossae.

8. "Wherefore, having much boldness in Christ to command you to do what you ought,"

Paul reminds Philemon that as an apostle of Christ he has *adequate boldness* to command him to do what is right. The Word translated "boldness" *(παρρησιαν)* has the idea of *frankness, openness,* and *authority* in this context. It is important to observe that this boldness is *in Christ.* In Ephesians 3:12, Paul reaffirms the fact that he has this *boldness in Christ.* In Ephesians 6:18-19, Paul asked for prayer that he might *boldly make known* the mystery of the Gospel. In Philemon's case, however, even though he has authority to order him to accept Onesimus as a beloved brother; yet he does not use this authority.

Now let us consider *what* Paul had boldness and authority to do in relation to Philemon. He had the authority to "command" *(επιτασσειν),* to *place an arrangement upon* him, to *charge* him, and *to order* him to do what he ought. The phrase translated "what you ought" (το ανηκον*)* has the basic idea of what is *owed,* what is *due,* and what is *suitable.* In other words, Paul could have boldly told Philemon to take Onesimus back as an *equal brother,* which was the position owed to him, but he did not take this approach.

9. "on account of love rather I beseech, being such a one as Paul the old man, and now also a prisoner of Christ Jesus - "

Instead of using his authority to *force* Philemon to do God's will in relation to Onesimus, Paul *prefers to use the way of love,* i.e., *to beseech him.* Love was that which motivated Paul *not to use force* but to *use the method of beseeching.* The word translated "beseech" *(παρακαλω),* as used in this context, basically means to *entreat, appeal to, admonish,* and *encourage.* Paul appealed to Philemon's conscience, which had the Word of God fed into it, to treat Onesimus according to the will of God revealed in this epistle.

Paul reminds Philemon *who he is, who the person is* making this request on behalf of Onesimus, he is *"such a one* as Paul the old man." The word translated "such a one" (τοιουτος) emphasizes the *quality* of Paul, i.e., the *kind, sort,* and *status* of his person. It was not

some immature upstart who was appealing to him, but the *Apostle Paul,* his *long-time friend* who had been tried and tested and not found wanting.

Furthermore, he uses *age* as α factor in his appeal to Philemon. He was one who had been around long enough to have gained experience. He *knew* what he was talking about - his request was legitimate. Also, the thought that he was an aged one, an old man, would *appeal to Philemon's emotions* to respond positively.

In addition to the facts of *who he was* and his *old* age, Paul calls to Philemon's attention that he is "now also a prisoner of Christ Jesus." As we have already observed he was a prisoner who *belonged to Christ* and because of his obedience to Christ. While many men are prisoners because they were caught serving their own self-interests, Paul was a prisoner because he was uncompromisingly *serving the interests of Jesus Christ.*

Again we would emphasize the fact that Paul was a prisoner of Jesus Christ because of his bold proclamation of the "mystery of the Gospel" (Eph. 6:19-20). In writing to the Colossians he says the same thing in slightly different words, namely, he was in prison because he had spoken the "mystery of Christ" as was necessary (Col. 4:3). The key word in these two statements is the word "mystery" *(μυστηριον),* which is the *message for this present Church age,* which was revealed to and through the Apostle Paul (cf. Rom. 16:25-26).

Paul obviously felt that mentioning his imprisonment would strengthen his appeal to Philemon. This would face him with the fact that he, Paul, had sacrificed everything for Christ to the place of being in prison, and the *least he could do* would be to receive Onesimus back as a "beloved brother."

10. ***"I beseech you concerning my child, whom I beget in my bonds, Onesimus."***

We observed in the previous verse that Paul was motivated by love to "beseech" (παρακαλω), *appeal to, and encourage* Philemon to take Onesimus back on the right terms. Paul refers to Onesimus as being his "child" *(τεκνου), son, and descendant.* The reference here obviously refers to the fact that Onesimus was Paul's *spiritual child* or son in the faith. Paul is making a very special appeal to Philemon, it is for a spiritual son who is very close to him, and he wants him to be

treated *as a fellow brother* in the Body of Christ.

Onesimus was *spiritually born* in Paul's Roman prison cell. Apparently Paul spiritually "beget" *(εγεννησα), generated, und produced* him through sharing the Word of God with him (cf. 1 Peter 1:23). We do not know the circumstances that originally brought Paul and Onesimus together. It may have been that *Epaphras* or some Christian friend had introduced Onesimus to Paul. On the other hand, it may have been that Onesimus had been apprehended as a run-away slave, or for some other misdemeanor, and Paul met him while he was serving time in prison. Whatever the actual circumstances were, one thing is certain, they were *sovereignly used by God* to lead a sinner to the Saviour through the Apostle Paul.

11. ***"who was once useless to you, but now both to you and to me very useful,"***

Now did Paul know that Onesimus had previously been useless to his master, Philemon? Epaphras, who had come from Colossae to Rome to visit Paul, may have shared this information with Paul. Onesimus, after he was saved, may have confessed to Paul about what a miserable slave he had been to Philemon. In view of how "useless" *(αχρηστον), unuseful,* and *unprofitable* Onesimus had been to Philemon, we can better understand the magnitude of Paul's job to convince Philemon to receive him back as a beloved brother.

The key word "once" (ποτε), at *one time,* and *formerly* refers to a time in the past when Onesimus was a sinner without Christ and God in this world (cf. Eph. 2:12). At *that time* he was useless and unprofitable to both God and man. Another key word "now" *(νυνι),* at the *present time,* refers to *a new era* in the life of Onesimus. Instead of being a sinner he is *now a saint,* instead of being dominated by Satan he is *now living for Jesus Christ* (cf. Gal. 2: 20; Phil. 2: 21). The pivotal point between what Onesimus *once* was and what he now is goes back to the time he was made *a new creature in Christ* (Gal. 6:15).

When one becomes a new creature in Christ "old things have passed away, behold things have become new" (2 Cor. 5:17). Paul tells Philemon that Onesimus is "now both to you and to me *very useful."* The Greek word translated "very useful" *(ευχρηστον)* is not just the opposite of the word translated "useless" *(αχρηστον),* but it

has the positive adverb "ευ" prefixed to it. This combined word conveys the idea of being *very or highly useful in that which is good.* Every believer should be involved in doing that which is *good* according to the standard of the Bible. Such working of good will make one's life *useful* to both God and men.

12. ***"whom I have sent back to you, himself, that is my deepest internal feeling."***

As Paul writes he puts himself in the *time-slot* of Philemon, the reader. He uses the aorist tense to say that he has *already sent* Onesimus to him. The use of the word "himself" *(αυτον)* emphasizes the fact that Paul is sending Onesimus back in person. According to Colossians 4:8-9, Paul sent Onesimus back with Tychicus.

Paul's reference to Onesimus as being his "deepest internal feeling" *(σπλαγχνα)* reveals the depth of *emotional attachment* Paul had to him. Onesimus was in essence his *innermost being,* his *feeling of compassion,* and the *most intense feeling* he was capable of expressing. The word that Paul uses here depicts a very *intimate bond* between himself and Onesimus. In spite of this close bond and Paul's desire to not be separated from Onesimus, he informs Philemon that he has sent him back.

13. ***"Whom I was desiring to retain for myself, that on behalf of you he might minister to me in the bonds of the gospel,"***

The use of the imperfect tense suggests that in the past Paul was wishing, wanting and considering how he might "retain" (κατεχειν), *detain, hold,* and *keep* Onesimus for himself. Paul had those who were associated with him in his imprisonment at various times: Timothy (Col. 1:1), Epaphras (Col. 1:7; 4:12), Luke and Demas (Col. 4:14), and Epaphroditus (Phil. 2:25). He apparently needed more help to adequately take care of the work of the Lord, and having evaluated Onesimus as a potential fellow worker, he really wanted him on his staff. There was a problem, however, for Onesimus belonged to Philemon, and Paul had *no right to keep him* apart from Philemon's consent.

As Paul contemplated his need for Onesimus, and considered how interested Philemon was in spreading the Gospel, it occurred to him that Onesimus might be able to minister to him *on behalf of Philemon.* Paul could have very well rationalized that Philemon was

deeply indebted to him, for he had received the Gospel from him, and the least Philemon could do would be to minister to him through Onesimus. For Paul to have acted on this basis would have *forced* Philemon to spread the Gospel through giving him Onesimus rather than giving him *freedom to do it of his own will.*

14. ***"but without your consent I determined to do nothing, that your good might not be by compulsion but thy free will."***

Even though Paul may have had a moral right to demand, pressure, and force Philemon to do what was right, he did not use this right. He refused to presume upon Philemon, he rejected the use of squeeze tactics, and he repudiated subtly putting him into a box. He "determined" *(ηθελησα), willed,* and deliberately *chose* to do nothing apart from Philemon's consent. The word translated "consent" *(γνωμης)* conveys the idea of *opinion and judgment.* In other words, Paul would not make Onesimus his fellow worker unless Philemon gave him the green light, his favorable judgment and opinion.

If Paul had kept Onesimus as a fellow worker, apart from Philemon's consent, it follows that he would be *compelling* Philemon to give him the services of his slave. Paul did not want Onesimus released to serve with him on the basis of "compulsion" *(αναγκην), necessity,* and *constraint.* A robot can be compelled to do good but such good is void of morality.

Paul wanted Philemon's good to come forth from a free will. This word translated "free will" (εκουσιον) expresses the idea of *voluntary* and *spontaneous.* If Paul was going to have Onesimus as a fellow worker, there was only one condition on which he would have him, Philemon would have to *voluntarily, spontaneously, and of his own accord* give him to Paul. High pressure methods are capable of producing spiritual robots, those who go through the actions, but *true spirituality requires the Spirit and a free will.*

15. ***"For perhaps this is the reason he was separated for an hour, that you might have him forever,"***

The Greek word translated "perhaps" (ταχα) basically means *hastily, quickly,* and *soon.* In extra-biblical Greek writings it is often translated *perhaps.* The only other time it is used in the New Testament is in Romans 5:7, where it may be translated either *quickly*

or *perhaps.* This verse could also be translated "For this reason he was quickly separated for an hour, that you might have him forever." The translation "quickly" would imply that Onesimus had *very hastily escaped* from Philemon his master.

It is important that we translate literally the words Paul uses in this verse if we are to grasp his *time-contrast.* The reason Onesimus was separated for an "hour" *(ωραν),* a very *short period of time,* was in order that Philemon might have him "forever" *(αιωνιον), a long period of time.* If we translate "ταχα" as *perhaps,* then the thought is that possibly the reason for the short separation was that you might have him a long time, for eternity. On the other hand, if we translate "ταχα" as *quickly,* then the thought would be that *as a result* of Onesimus hastily escaping for a short time Philemon would have him for a long time, forever.

Keeping what Paul says in this verse in proper perspective, we recognize that it was *during* the short period of time of separation that Onesimus *was made a new creature in Christ.* This relationship with Christ *lifted him out of the slave category* and made him *a fellow member with Philemon* in the Body of Christ. Philemon's former master to slave relation to Onesimus was temporal. His new brother to brother relation to him was eternal. Paul is trying to get over to Philemon the fact that the short time Onesimus was absent was insignificant when compared to the eternal results accomplished during this time.

16. ***"no longer as a slave but above a slave, a beloved brother, especially to me, but how much more to you, both in the flesh and in the Lord."***

As Onesimus goes back to Colossae with Tychicus, he is "no longer" (ουκετι), *no more,* and *not yet* to be looked upon as a slave. The strong adversative "αλλα" emphasizes the fact that he is now to be considered as a person "above" *(υπερ), beyond,* and *more than* a slave. This statement leaves *no room* for Christian masters to subject Christian men, women, and children to themselves as slaves. There is absolutely no room for one person to dominate another person in the Body of Christ, the Church (cf. Gal. 3:27-28)! Al economic relations between fellow believers must be on *a voluntary free will basis.*

Philemon is to recognize Onesimus as *a beloved brother.* Truly, in Christ, old relations have passed away, and now all believers in the Body of Christ bear a beloved-brother relationship to one another. Paul refers to *all* fellow members in the various local assemblies as being *beloved ones* (cf. Rom. 1:7; 1 Cor. 15:58; Eph. 5:1). Paul also commonly refers to various individual believers as beloved brothers (cf. Eph. 6:21; Col. 4:7).

Paul speaks of Onesimus as being a beloved brother "especially" *(μαλιστα), chiefly, and most of all* to him. In Colossians 4:9, he refers to Onesimus "the faithful and beloved brother." As we have already seen Paul's love for Onesimus was so great that he speaks of him as being his innermost feelings, the deepest part of his being, and the heart of his natural life (v. 12).

If Onesimus was in a special and particular way the recipient of Paul's love, he should *much more* be the recipient of Philemon's love. This would be true *both* as a flesh and blood human being and as a brother in the Lord. In spite of the faulty human relations Onesimus formerly had with Philemon, being useless and perhaps even having stolen from him (cf. v. 18); yet Paul expects Philemon, as a forgiving believer, to have *a strong love for him in the flesh.* In view of the circumstances Philemon may well have found it easier to love Onesimus in the Lord than to love him in the flesh.

17. ***"Therefore if you have fellowship with me, receive him even as me."***

Paul now uses his own personal relationship with Philemon to accomplish his end - to get Philemon to accept Onesimus on the proper terms. The Greek word translated "fellowship" *(κοινωνον)* basically means *to have in commonwith, to share together with,* and *to have commonphysical and spiritual interests.* Paul is bringing all that he has in common with Philemon, both physically and spiritually, to bear upon Philemon's correctly relating to Onesimus. He uses his mutual fellowship with Philemon as a gentle psychological lever to move him to do God's will in receiving back Onesimus. This is an excellent example of Paul's *masterful use of practical psychology* to accomplish the will of God.

Paul wants Philemon to give Onesimus the *same* kind of treatment that he would give to himself. On the basis of their mutual fellowship, Paul instructs Philemon to "receive" (προσλαβου), to *take*

to himself, and to *take back* Onesimus. Even as Philemon would obviously receive Paul with outstretched arms, likewise, he is to extend the same gracious hospitality to Onesimus. Since Onesimus is now a beloved brother in the Body of Christ with Paul, it is *logical* that Philemon should *treat them both the same.*

18. ***"An if he has wronged you in anything, or owes you, charge this to my account."***

We need to carefully observe that *what Paul says he will do* depends upon what Onesimus has already done to Philemon. The literal language that is used here *does not admit* that Onesimus has actually wronged or is obligated to Philemon but it does leave room for this as a possibility. Through what Paul had learned from both Epaphras and Onesimus, Paul recognized that Onesimus *might be guilty,* but having heard only one side of the story, he does not prematurely condemn him, as it were, before he has had a fair trial. The "if" (ει) used here makes this *a conditional* statement. Paul will assume responsibility for what Onesimus *may have done,* but on the other hand, as an astute attorney, *he does not implicate him* before the time.

Now that we have observed the conditional structure of this verse, let us consider the *specific meaning* of three words used in it. First, the word "wronged" *(ηδικησεν)* may be translated *acted unrightly, unjustly,* or *not according to Christian standards.* Second, the word "owes" *(οφειλει)* may be translated *indebted, obligated,* or has *anything due* you. Third, the words "charge to my account" (εμοι ελλογα) may be translated *place, enter in, ascribe,* or *impute to* my account (cf. Rom. 5:13).

Summarizing this verse in the light of the above meanings, Paul is telling Philemon that *if* Onesimus has not acted rightly, justly, and in keeping with Christian standards, or if he is indebted, obligated, or has anything due him; then he (Paul) will *assume this obligation.* It should be *entered in his account* as a debt which he owes to Philemon. This is a supreme example of what Paul teaches in Galatians 6:2, we are to "bear the burdens of one another." Paul completely identifies himself with his brother Onesimus in both the *spiritual and physical* realms. Onesimus' obligations were his obligations!

19. ***"I Paul have written it with my own hand, I will repay it, that***

I might not say to you that even yourself you owe to me."

The aorist tense is used in this statement and should be translated "I have written" (εγραψα). We must keep in mind that Paul looked at the time he wrote this epistle from the *viewpoint of his reader;* therefore it had been written weeks *before* Philemon actually received and read it.

Paul affirms that he had *personally* written it. The phrase "with my own hand" (εμη χειρι) emphasizes the fact that *he himself wrote* it instead of dictating it through a secretary. The word translated "it" is understood in the Greek text alluding to the word "epistle" *(*επιστολη*);* hence Paul is certifying the fact that he has *personally written this letter.* The fact that Paul has written the entire epistle means that every thing that is in it is over his signature, and this includes *his promise to pay* any debts Onesimus might owe Philemon.

The word translated "I will repay" *(*αποτισω*)* is derived from two Greek words and basically means that *from Paul payment will be made.* The emphasis is not just on the fact that Paul will repay but that this repayment will *come from him personally.* He feels so strongly on this *personal commitment* that he calls Philemon's attention to the fact that he has *personally written the letter.*

The Greek grammatical construction behind the phrase "that I might not say to you" *(*ινα μη λεγω σοι*)* expresses the idea of *purpose* and its meaning is usually very obvious. In this context the concept of purpose is *not readily risible,* however, that does not mean that it is not in the background. It appears to us that a free translation of what Paul is saying would be: "it is *not my purpose* to tell you that even yourself you owe to me." In the light of what Paul has said about paying what Onesimus owed, he reminds Philemon that he owes himself to him (Paul), in order that Philemon might keep the respective debts in true perspective. It was *not Paul's main purpose* to bring up the subject of Philemon's vast debt to him but as a secondary aspect of his appeal on behalf of Onesimus it did come up.

In view of all the information we have Philemon apparently came to know Jesus Christ through the personal and public ministry of Paul at Ephesus. In as much as Paul was the one who had taught him the Gospel of the Grace of God (cf. Acts 20:24), which resulted in his becoming a new creature in Christ (cf. 2 Cor. 5:17), it followed that he *owed even himself* to Paul. Likewise, because Paul faithfully taught

the Gospel of the Grace of God, and made known the Gospel of the mystery against all odds (cf. Eph. 6:19-20; Col. 4:3-4; Phil. 1:12-14), all believers today *should recognize their debt to him* and respond by *faithfully and uncompromisingly teaching this same Gospel* to their own generation!

20. ***"Yes, brother, I want help from you in the Lord. Refresh my innermost being in Christ."***

Paul uses the vocative case, the case used in directly addressing one, as he strengthens his appeal to Philemon as *a brother* in the Body of Christ. The address "brother" conveys both the idea of an *intimate relationship* as well as the *responsibility* that goes with it. As a brother in God's family, Paul "wants help" *(*ονναιμην*),* he literally *prays for help, profit, and benefit* from Philemon as indicated by the use of the optative mood. Paul's prayer is that Philemon will help by taking Onesimus back, not as a slave, but as a *beloved brother.* He wants this help and benefit from Philemon in the sphere of the Lord, i.e., that the Lord will *motivate and produce* this help through him.

The Greek word translated "refresh" *(*αναπαυσον*)* is derived from two words which literally mean to *rest or cease up.* The area in which Paul wants rest, cessation, and alleviation of stress is in his "innermost being" *(*σπλαγχνα*),* in his *abdominal cavity,* in the *pit of his stomach,* and in *that area in which emotional strain* results in ulcers.

Paul's love for his spiritual child Onesimus was so strong that it was hard for him to bear the thought that Philemon might not treat him as a beloved brother. Not knowing what Philemon's response to the will of God would be, whether or not he would accept Onesimus as a free beloved brother in Christ, Paul was under a certain amount of tension as he awaited Philemon's positive response. With Philemon's obedience Paul's tension would be *relaxed in Christ* and he would experience that rest which Jesus used the same word to describe in Matthew 11:28 (cf. v. 7; 1 Cor. 16:18).

21. ***"Having confidence in your obedience I have written to you, knowing that you will do even beyond what I say."***

If Paul had not believed that Philemon would do that which he has asked him to do, he would not have written this epistle to him. Prior to writing to Philemon Paul had evaluated his past record, his latest known spiritual condition, and what the chances were of his

being willing to make Onesimus a free beloved brother in the Lord. As a result of this evaluation Paul was convinced that Philemon would be willing to give up Onesimus as a slave.

The word translated "having confidence" (πεποιθως) is in the perfect tense and it indicates that Paul *had and continued to be convinced and persuaded* that Philemon would fully carry out his instructions. As Paul evaluated the potential for Philemon's obedience, the most important single factor was the *power of God the Holy Spirit* to bring lives into conformity with the will of God (Gal. 5:10; Phil. 1:6). Paul did not write this epistle with a defeatist attitude, he did not limit God's ability to conform men to His will, but he *had confidence* in a God who was able to do exceedingly beyond that which he could ask or think (Eph. 3:20)!

From the psychological viewpoint, the fact that Paul had confidence in Philemon's obedience was *a strong incentive toward his obedience.* God has created us as human beings so that we respond positively or negatively to given stimuli. Paul was one of the *greatest masters* in practical human relations He knew the Creator, he knew the man He had created, and he knew the response that a given stimulus would call forth. Paul intelligently used his practical psychology, not to satiate his own lust for wealth and power as most do, but *to the end of effectively teaching the Gospel of God's Grace.* Paul adds an even *further incentive* to stimulate Philemon to obey, for he says, "knowing that you will do even beyond what I say."

22. ***"At the same time also prepare for me a lodging, for I hope that through your prayers I shall be granted unto you."***

As Philemon does even "beyond" (υπερ), *above,* and *more* than what Paul has asked him to do, at the "same time" (αμα) he is also to "prepare" (ετοιμαζα) and *make ready* a "lodging" (ξενιαν), *a lodging place,* or *a guest room* for Paul. Observe the gentle but *irresistible way this motivated* Philemon to do more than what Paul has asked. Paul is coming to Colossae and all things must *meet his approval!*

It is Paul's hope, based upon Philemon's diligent prayers, that he will be "granted" *(χαρισθησομαι), given as a gift,* and *graced* unto them by God. In other words, he is anticipating that he will soon be released from prison in Rome. Paul apparently remained in prison about another year after this, and we have *no evidence* that he got to Colossae.

23. ***"Epaphras, my fellow prisoner in Christ Jesus, salutes you,"***

Epaphras was a beloved *fellow slave* of Paul, *a faithful minister* of Christ on behalf of the Colossians, and one who was *constantly praying* that they might stand perfect in all the will of God (cf. Col. 1:7; 4:12). In this verse Paul also speaks of him as being a "fellow prisoner" *(*συναιχμαλωτος), one who was *a captive with* and possibly in prison with Paul for faithfully teaching the Gospel of the mystery. Since Epaphras was from Colossae, one out of their assembly (ο εξ υμων*;* Col. 4:12), we would expect him to be the first one on the list sending greetings to Philemon.

24. ***"Mark, Aristarchus, Demas, Luke, my fellow workers."***

Paul adds these four individuals, plus those he refers to as his fellow workers, to the list of those sending greetings to Philemon. Mark's name is mentioned eight times in the New Testament. He was *a cousin of Barnabas* (Col. 4:10). He *deserted Paul* and Barnabas at Perga on their first missionary journey (Acts 13:13). Paul would not take him on the second missionary journey (Acts 1.5:38). By this time Mark is *again working with Paul* (Col 4:10). Paul's last reference to Mark is that he is *"very useful* to me for the ministry" (2 Tim. 4:11). Mark anticipated visiting the Colossians in the near future (Col. 4:10).

Who was Aristarchus who sends greetings to Philemon? He was *a Macedonian* and *fellow traveler* with Paul (Acts 19:29). He was from the city of *Thessalonica* (Acts 20:4). He was on the way to Rome *with Paul when he was shipwrecked* (Acts 27:2). He is referred to as *a fellow prisoner* and *fellow captive* of Paul as was Epaphras (Col. 4:10).

What do we know about Demas who sends greetings to Philemon? Demas is *with Paul* when he writes to the Colossians (Col. 4:14). Some years later Paul refers to Demas as having loved the present age, as having *left him,* and he was in Thessalonica (2 Tim. 4:10). The lack of information and compliments we have regarding Demas suggest that he never made any significant contribution to Paul's ministry.

Luke also sends his greetings to Philemon. He is apparently the one who had written the Gospel of Luke and the Book of Acts. During the last days of Paul's ministry, when some had deserted him and

some had departed on various missions, he speaks of Luke as being the *only one with me* (2 Tim. 4:11). It is highly possible that Luke may have kept a diary as he traveled with Paul which may account for many of the details in the Book of Acts. We have every reason to believe that Luke remained faithful to Paul to the very end.

25. ***"The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit,"***

The word "grace" (χαρις) is used at the end of all of Paul's epistles including the Book of Hebrews. Some of the most common forms used are "The grace of *our* Lord Jesus be with you," or "The grace of *the* Lord Jesus be with you," and "Grace be with you." In this verse Paul adds the word "spirit" (πνευματος), which is also true in Galatians 6:18 and Philippians 4:23.

It is Paul's desire that the grace which belongs to Christ, of which He is the very essence and expression, may be with the spirits of all believers. God's provision of grace in Christ was not only necessary for original salvation but it is also necessary for the daily deliverance from the power of in. We are constantly dependent upon the grace of the Lord Jesus Christ for a daily *renewing in the spirit of our minds* (Eph. 4:23).

Now let us consider the manner in which Paul uses the word "spirit." In First Corinthians 2:11, Paul says, "for who of men knows the things of man except the spirit of man that is in him?" Paul uses the word *spirit* in this passage as having the ability *to know,* i.e., of having at least some of the characteristics of the *mind* (cf. 1 Cor. 5:3-4). In Second Corinthians 2:13; Paul says, "that I did not have rest in my spirit when I did not find Titus my brother." The obvious meaning here is that Paul did not have *mental* rest and relaxation (cf. 2 Cor. 7:13). These two passages make it clear that Paul does use the word "spirit" *(πνευμα)* as a part of man that has the power to *know and comprehend.*

The Scriptures teach that man consists of three parts, a body, soul, and spirit. The spirit is at least partially associated with what we commonly call the *mind* (cf. Rom. 8:6). Likewise, the *spirit is the point of juncture* where God the Holy Spirit meets man, for Romans 8:16 says, "the Spirit Himself bears witness with our spirit that we are the children of God." In view of these facts it is *most logical* that the grace of Christ should be *with our spirit,* enlightening and renewing in the image of God (Col. 3:10).

Now that we have gone through this short epistle verse by verse, we want to restate the *purpose* for which Paul wrote it and the *means he used* to get Philemon to carry out the purpose.

The *first method* Paul uses to accomplish his purpose is that of *praise.* He tells Philemon that he *continuously thanks God* for his love and faithfulness to both the Lord Jesus and to all the saints (vv. 4-5). Paul lets Philemon know how *grateful* he is for his active love and faithfulness - two of the greatest Christian characteristics a believer can possess.

Furthermore, Paul also shares with Philemon how much *joy and encouragement* he has on the basis of his life style of love. The fact that Philemon was "walking in love" was manifest in his relations with fellow believers and Paul tells Philemon *how much it has meant to him (v. 7).* Paul *praises Philemon* because he was setting at rest and ease the deepest emotional needs of the saints.

The *second method* Paul uses to accomplish his purpose is that of *appealing to* instead of commanding. *Love* motivated Paul to use this method. He had the authority to *command* what was good, but did not use it, instead he insisted that good-doing be on *a free will voluntary basis.* If Paul had forced Philemon to receive Onesimus as a beloved brother, the overt act would have been performed, but *no good would have accured to Philemon.* For good to be good it must be motivated and performed as *a voluntary expression of the believer's will.* Thus we see that Paul gently put persuasively *appealed to Philemon's will* to take back Onesimus as an *equal beloved brother* in the Lord.

The *third method* Paul uses to accomplish his purpose is the *mutual friendship relation* that he had with Philemon. Because they are yoked together in *a bond of fellowship in* the Body of Christ Paul feels that Philemon would do most anything he wanted him to do. This fellowship has been totally voluntary, they have *a mutual sense of personal obligation to one another,* and Paul wants Onesimus to be included in this fellowship and to be treated the same as he is. Paul is already closely identified with Philemon and he wants this same *identification to be transferred to Onesimus.* Paul legitimately uses his friendship with Philemon as *a bridge to Philemon-Onesimus relations* for the glory of God.